

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Tyndale Open Study Notes

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Genesis 1:1

- *In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth:* This statement summarizes the entire creation story ([1:3-2:3](#)). It answers the key question: Who created the world? (see also [Proverbs 8:22-31](#); [John 1:1-3](#)). Genesis affirms God's role and purpose in creation.
- The common Hebrew name for God is 'elohim. This name shows that God has supreme power over all things. The word 'elohim is plural in form. However, it usually takes singular verbs. This shows that the Bible teaches there is one all-powerful God.
- *created* (Hebrew *bara'*): In the Old Testament, when this verb is used, God is always the one creating. It describes the act of making something new, such as:
 - the heavens and the earth ([1:1](#), [21](#); [2:3](#)),
 - humans ([1:27](#)),
 - the nation of Israel ([Isaiah 43:1](#)), and
 - the future new creation ([Isaiah 65:17](#)).
- *the heavens and the earth:* This phrase means the whole ordered universe (cosmos).

Genesis 1:1-2:3

- These verses introduce the Pentateuch (the first five books of the Bible). They teach Israel that one true God created, ordered, and populated the world, not the gods of nearby nations.
- God blessed three specific things:
 - animal life ([1:22-25](#)),
 - human life ([1:27](#)), and
 - the Sabbath day ([2:3](#)).

These three blessings emphasize the Creator's plan. God made humans in his image to rule in his place over earth's creatures and to join in God's Sabbath rest.

Genesis 1:2

- This verse provides context for the summary in [1:1](#) and the detailed description in [1:3–2:3](#). God's words of creation bring order to the universe's chaos.
- *formless and void* (Hebrew *tohu* and *bohu*): This phrase means something like "wild and waste." It strongly contrasts with the final ordered state of the heavens and earth ([1:1](#)).
- *surface of the deep* (Hebrew *pene tehom*): Some scholars suggest this refers to the Mesopotamian goddess Tiamat (representing chaos). But Genesis sees *tehom* as empty chaos, not as a deity or goddess that God fought in a cosmic battle.
- *the Spirit of God*: God directly guided and oversaw the process of creation.

Genesis 1:3

- *And God said*: God created everything in chapter [1](#) by his powerful word (compare [Psalm 33:6, 9](#)).
- *"Let there be ... and there was"*: God's command put his will into action to create the world. God is not part of creation or limited by it. He supremely rules over everything (see [Nehemiah 9:6](#)).

Genesis 1:3–13

In the first three days, God shaped the formless world into a place where people and animals could live.

Genesis 1:4

Light is the opposite of chaotic *darkness* ([1:2](#)). God considers *light to be good, but not darkness* ([John 1:5](#)). God is the source of this light ([Genesis 1:14–19](#)). God separated light, just like he separated

water ([1:6–8](#)), using his word that creates. Light is associated with life and blessings ([Job 38:19–20](#); [Psalms 19:1–6](#); [97:11](#); [104:19–20](#); [Isaiah 60:19–20](#)). It limits the darkness that could destroy cosmic order.

Darkness often represents fear, death, and evil ([Genesis 15:12](#); [Job 18:6, 18](#); [Psalm 88:12](#); [Ephesians 5:11–12](#); [1 John 1:5](#)).

Genesis 1:5

- *God called* (or *named*): Naming something shows authority over it (see also [2:19–20](#)).
- *day*: The Hebrew word *yom* can mean:
 - daylight ([1:5a](#)),
 - a 24-hour period ([1:5b](#)), or
 - an unspecified time ([2:4b](#), "when," literally *in the day*; compare [Exodus 20:8–11](#)).
- *evening ... morning*: The Hebrew day started at sundown. This was like the first day that began with darkness and led to morning light.

Genesis 1:6–8

The creation story describes how things appear from a human perspective. The sky looks like a shiny dome separating two groups of water (see [Job 37:18](#); [Ezekiel 1:22](#)). In the ancient Near East, people understood the universe to have three levels, with rain coming from the highest level (see [Genesis 7:11–12](#) and study note).

Genesis 1:9–10

Let the waters ... be gathered into one place: Other ancient cultures considered the sea to be a hostile force. Genesis shows God further controlling chaos by setting specific boundaries for the sea (see study note on [1:2](#)). The flood was an act of God's judgment ([6:7](#)). It removed these boundaries and returned the earth to chaos ([7:1–24](#)).

Genesis 1:14

let them ... mark the seasons and days and years: The movement of the heavenly objects ordered Israel's liturgical calendar. This calendar, rooted in creation, provided sacred timing for Israel's festivals and celebrations (see [Exodus 23:15](#); [Leviticus 23:4](#)).

Genesis 1:14-31

On days four through six, God filled the domains that had been formed during days one through three ([1:3-13](#)).

Genesis 1:16

- In the surrounding pagan cultures, people worshiped the sun and moon as gods. But in Genesis, they serve God and humanity (see [Psalm 136:7-9](#); [Jeremiah 31:35](#)).
Here, this verse does not name the sun and moon. They are simply called *the greater light* and *the lesser light*. Not naming them may have reminded Israel that they were not gods.
- *rule*: Compare [1:26](#), [28](#); [Psalm 136:9](#).
- *the stars*: The stars bear witness to God's power to create, and they declare his glory ([Psalms 19:1](#); [148:3](#)). They do not predict the future, as Israel's neighbors believed (see [Jeremiah 10:2](#)).

Genesis 1:21

Unlike pagan beliefs that the great sea creatures existed from the beginning along with God, the Bible teaches that God created them. God has complete power and authority over them. The Hebrew word *tanninim* ("sea creatures") can also refer to:

- crocodiles ([Ezekiel 29:3](#)),
- powerful monsters ([Jeremiah 51:34](#)), or
- the sea creature Leviathan ([Isaiah 27:1](#); compare [Job 41:1-34](#)).

Genesis 1:22

- *God blessed them*: This blessing orders and enables them to do what God has said (see "Blessing" Theme Note).
- *fill the waters of the seas ... let the birds multiply on the earth*: These instructions explain the blessing. The fish and birds can reproduce because of God's command. It is not through pagan ceremonies, as some of Israel's neighbors believed.

Genesis 1:26

- *Let Us make*: This statement is more personal than the earlier command, "Let there be" (for example, [1:3](#), [6](#)).
- *Us*: The use of the plural pronoun here has several possible explanations:
 1. It may refer to the Trinity (one God who exists forever in three persons).
 2. It may be a plural form used to show God's greatness.
 3. It may describe God speaking to himself (a kind of inner council).
 4. It may describe God speaking with his heavenly court (angels).

The idea of the Trinity was revealed later in the Bible. Because of this, it is unlikely that the human author meant that here.

Many Hebrew scholars do not accept the idea that this is a plural used to show God's greatness. The grammar does not clearly support that view.

The idea that God is speaking to himself also lacks clear evidence. The only similar examples refer to Israel as a group (for example, [2 Samuel 24:14](#)).

However, the Old Testament often shows God speaking to his heavenly court (angels). This idea has strong support (see [Genesis 3:22](#); [11:7](#); [1 Kings 22:19-22](#); [Job 1:6-12](#); [2:1-6](#); [38:7](#); [Psalm 89:5-6](#); [Isaiah 6:1-8](#); [Daniel 10:12-13](#)).

- *in Our image, after Our likeness*: These phrases mean almost the same thing in Hebrew. Humans have a special relationship with God.
- *to rule*: Humans represent the Creator as his ambassadors and his delegated rulers on earth.

Genesis 1:27

- The first poetry of Genesis celebrates God's ultimate achievement in creating humans.
- *man*: This term (Hebrew *ha-'adam*) often refers to all of humanity (see [6:1](#), [5-7](#); [9:5-6](#)). Although traditionally translated as "man," it includes both male and female.

Genesis 1:28

- *God blessed them*: See study note on [1:22](#); also see [17:16](#); [48:16](#); [Deuteronomy 7:13](#).
- *said*: God speaks directly and intimately to humans. We are caretakers of his shared authority.
- *subdue it; rule*: As representatives of God's rule, humans are responsible for taking care of the world God created and managing it (see also [Genesis 9:2](#); [Psalm 8:5-8](#)).

Genesis 1:29-30

These verses emphasize how God provides for humans, animals, and birds all over the earth. He

gives every *seed-bearing plant* and every tree whose *fruit contains seed*.

Genesis 1:31

The creator calls his work *good* seven times in chapter 1. After creating humans, God says it is all *very good*.

Genesis 2:1-3

Humans are the most important of God's creation ([1:26-31](#)), and day 7 is the most important of the creation week. When God rested, he approved all creation. There was nothing more needed! This seven-day framework structured Israel's week.

The seventh day was the model for their weekly Sabbath. God intended for the Sabbath to celebrate his completed work. God set apart the seventh day as holy. The people dedicated it to the Creator, who also rested on this day (see [Exodus 20:8-11](#); [31:12-17](#); compare [Matthew 12:1-8](#); [Romans 14:5-6](#); [Colossians 2:16-17](#); [Hebrews 4:1-11](#)).

Genesis 2:3

- During the first six days of creation, God separated light from darkness, day from night, and water from dry land. The final act of creation separated the ordinary from the holy. This was the basis for Israel's worship. It also anticipated a future time of rest ([Hebrews 4:1-11](#); [12:2](#); [13:14](#)).
- The lack of the usual "evening ... morning" phrase shows the creator's desire for endless fellowship with humans.

Genesis 2:4

- *This is the account* (literally *These are the generations*; Hebrew *toledoth*): This phrase appears often in Genesis. It helps outline the book. It usually introduces the family line or story of an important person ([5:1](#); [6:9](#); [10:1](#); [11:10, 27](#); [25:12, 19](#); [36:1](#); [37:2](#)). Some people think the first part of [2:4](#) belongs with [1:1-2:3](#), but it probably introduces the next story.
- *LORD God* (Hebrew *Yahweh Elohim*): This is the second name for God in Genesis. *Elohim* ([1:1-2:3](#)) refers to the all-powerful creator God. *Yahweh Elohim* refers to the eternal God who made a lasting covenant with Israel ([Exodus 3:6, 13-15](#)). So, [Genesis 2:4-25](#) focuses on God as a provider more than as a creator. The three themes of sexuality, dominion, and food in chapter [1](#) are now in reverse order (food, [2:8-17](#); dominion, [2:18-20](#); sexuality, [2:21-25](#)).

Genesis 2:4-25

This story (see study note on 2:4) of the heavens and the earth is not a second creation story. Instead, it expands on [1:1-2:3](#) with more theological and historical details. The focus shifts to what the universe (*kosmos*) produced rather than on its creation.

Special attention is given to the first man and woman. As the story continues, it is shaped by contrasts such as good and evil, knowledge and ignorance, life and death, and harmony and conflict.

Genesis 2:5

Work does not result from sin. It was part of creation's original design. It has a close link to human identity and purpose ([1:28](#); [2:15](#)).

Genesis 2:6

springs: The word refers to underground water that rises up to the surface of the ground.

Genesis 2:7

- In [1:1-2:3](#), creation happens by God's command ("Let there be ... And it was so"). This story describes a more personal process of creation (see also [2:8-9, 21-22](#)).
- *from the dust of the ground*: In Hebrew, '*adamah* means "ground." This forms a wordplay on '*adam*, which means "man." The earth is a key reference point for humans, who become dust again at death ([3:17-19](#); [4:11](#); [Job 4:19](#); [10:8-9](#); [Isaiah 29:16](#)).
- *breathed the breath of life into his nostrils*: God gives his breath only to humans, not to other animals. God made humans in his image ([Genesis 1:27](#)) and only they can communicate with their Creator ([2:16-17](#); [3:8-13](#)). They are the only ones with spiritual awareness and a moral conscience (see [Job 32:8](#)).

Genesis 2:8

- Eden was the general location in which the garden was placed, not the garden itself. The term could mean "plain," "delight," or "fertility." The description that follows suggests the idea of fertility.
- *in the east*: The exact location of Eden is unknown. But it was east of Canaan, which later became Israel's home.
- God placed the man in the garden to have a relationship with him and to receive his physical blessings (see also [2:15](#) and study note there).

Genesis 2:8–14

Similar to the holy time set on the seventh day of creation ([2:2–3](#)), the garden in Eden was a holy place separate from the rest of the world. It was like a garden-temple or sanctuary because the Lord showed his presence there in a special way.

Genesis 2:9

- Beauty and abundance characterized humanity's original environment (see [13:10](#)).
- *the tree of life*: This represented God's presence and care. Eating from it would give everlasting life ([3:22](#)), making it a powerful image for later Israelite and Christian thought ([Proverbs 3:18](#); [11:30](#); [13:12](#); [Revelation 2:7](#); [22:2](#), [14](#), [19](#)). The candlestick in Israel's tabernacle may have been a stylized representation of the tree of life ([Exodus 25:31–35](#)).
- Eating the fruit from *the tree of the knowledge of good and evil* gave humans the ability to be wise ([Genesis 3:6](#)) and have moral understanding ([3:5](#), [22](#); compare [Deuteronomy 1:39](#), “not know good from evil”). Eating from it showed a human desire to be independent and have wisdom that belonged to God alone (see [Proverbs 30:1–4](#)). Humans ignored God's instruction for moral understanding, showing independence instead of following God's will (compare [Proverbs 1:7](#)). Choosing human wisdom over God's instruction brings death and destruction (see [Psalm 19:7–9](#); [Ezekiel 28:6](#), [15–17](#)).

Genesis 2:10

- The river that watered the garden was a physical blessing, bringing fertile land for farming. It also represented God's presence (compare [Psalm 46:4](#); [Ezekiel 47:1–12](#); [Zechariah 14:8](#); [Revelation 22:1–2](#)).
- *branched into four headwaters*: The common understanding is that one river had its source in Eden, flowed down through the garden, and then split into the four rivers named.

Genesis 2:10–14

This description portrays the eastern region around Eden as a mountain with rivers flowing out to the world. Eden's beauty and fertility enriched the entire earth.

Genesis 2:11

The Pishon and the Gihon ([2:13](#)) cannot be identified with certainty. If the land of Havilah was in southeast Arabia or on the African coast, as some biblical data suggest (see [10:7](#); [25:18](#); [1 Samuel 15:7](#)), then the Pishon was possibly the Nile River. The Jewish historian Josephus thought that Havilah and the Pishon were in India (Antiquities 1.1.3).

Two other ideas suggest the Pishon and Gihon might be:

1. rivers in the mountains of eastern Turkey, where the Tigris and Euphrates ([Genesis 2:14](#)) also flow, and
2. the marshy delta near the Persian Gulf.

Current geographical conditions make it impossible to prove any theory with certainty.

Genesis 2:12

- The garden's beauty and richness spread to nearby areas through its rivers. The four rivers might suggest the garden's bounty reached all parts of the world.
- The Israelites later used *gold* and *onyx* to decorate the tabernacle, the temple ([Exodus 25:3–9](#); [1 Chronicles 29:2](#)), and the priests' clothing ([Exodus 28:9–14](#), [20](#)).
- The people used *bdellium* (a fragrant resin) in sacred incense ([Exodus 30:34](#)).

Genesis 2:13

- *Gihon*: The exact location is unknown, but some think it could be the Nile River or the Jordan River (as in the Greek version of [Jeremiah 2:18](#); Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.1.3). Or according to Jewish tradition, it could be a river that once flowed through the Kidron Valley ([1 Kings 1:33](#); [2 Chronicles 33:14](#)).
- Although Cush often refers to ancient Ethiopia, the immediate setting here seems to be a region in Mesopotamia connected with Babylon (see [10:8](#)). Cush may refer to the land of the Kassites, a people who ruled in Babylonia.

Genesis 2:14

Tigris ... Euphrates: These well-known rivers flow from the mountains of eastern Turkey.

Genesis 2:15

to cultivate and keep it: The garden needed care and management. Caring for the garden was humanity's honorable work. The Scriptures later apply these roles in God's garden-sanctuary to his

tabernacle (see [Leviticus 8:35](#); [Numbers 3:5–10](#); [4:46–49](#)).

Genesis 2:17

- *but you must not eat*: This rule is given in the same way as Israel's Ten Commandments (see [Exodus 20:1–17](#); [Deuteronomy 5:6–21](#)). The Lord included law and obedience in his covenant with humanity.
- *the knowledge of good and evil*: See study note on 2:9.
- *you will surely die*: Disobedience would bring immediate spiritual death (loss of relationship with God) and eventual physical death (see [3:22–23](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:6–7](#)).

Genesis 2:18

- *It is not good*: This is God's first negative comment about an otherwise good creation ([1:31](#)). The Lord God is like a father finding a bride for his son (compare chapter [24](#)).
- The solution for the man's need is a helper who is perfect for him. She is his ideal partner. God made her in the same image of God ([1:26–27](#)), gave her the same mission ([1:28](#); [2:15](#)), and gave her the same rule ([2:17](#)). The man cannot achieve his purpose alone.

Genesis 2:18–23

Human creation was the most important part of chapter [1](#), and human intimacy is the highlight of chapter [2](#). God's focus on mutual support and companionship among humans is unique in ancient Near Eastern writings.

Genesis 2:19–20

to see what he would name each one: Following God's example ([1:5](#), [8](#), [10](#)), the man named each creature. By doing this, he showed his authority over creation ([1:26](#), [28](#)).

Genesis 2:23

- Adam recognized the woman as his "suitable helper" ([2:20](#)). He celebrated their unity through poetry and song, focusing on their connection, not their differences (compare [29:14](#)).
- *"she shall be called 'woman,' for out of man she was taken":* Adam understood their connection (see [Ephesians 5:28–29](#)). Earlier, Adam looked at the animals but did not find a suitable partner. This evaluation is very different!

Genesis 2:24

- Marriage between a man and a woman is not only a human idea. It comes from the natural order.
- *a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife:* Marriage involves shifting loyalty from parents to a spouse.
- *they will become one flesh:* Marriage and its commitments make it the most basic covenant among people. Marriage is a powerful image of Israel's covenant with God ([Hosea 2:14–23](#)) and of Christ's relationship to the Church ([Ephesians 5:22–32](#)). God designed marriage to be a permanent, exclusive relationship between a man and a woman. The family it creates is the foundation of human society.

Genesis 2:25

both naked: Before the first humans disobeyed God (chapter [3](#)), being naked showed innocence and trust. After this, it came to show vulnerability and shame (see [9:22–23](#); [Leviticus 18:1–23](#); [Isaiah 47:3](#)). Shame is more than embarrassment. It can include being exposed, mistreated, or humiliated (see [Deuteronomy 28:48](#); [Isaiah 58:7](#); [James 2:15–16](#)).

Genesis 3:1

- Genesis describes the deceiver as a serpent, one of the animals God created (see also [3:14](#) and study note). Scripture later identifies him as Satan, the great enemy of God's people ([Revelation 12:9](#); [20:2](#)). He used manipulative language and disguised himself as a serpent. The serpent was the most clever of all creatures. This showed Satan as a master deceiver.
Satan uses different methods to oppose God's people (see [1 Chronicles 21:1](#); [Zechariah 3:1-2](#)). Deception remains one of his main strategies (compare [2 Corinthians 11:3](#), [14](#)). The Hebrew word for *crafty* is 'arum. It can have a positive meaning ("prudent," [Proverbs 14:8](#)) or a negative meaning (as here; see [Job 5:12](#)). Here it forms a wordplay with "naked" (Hebrew 'arummim) in [Genesis 2:25](#). Adam and Eve were naked and vulnerable. The serpent was crafty and cunning.
- The serpent probably asked the woman because God gave Adam the rule before he created Eve (see [2:16-17](#)). Adam was probably aware of the serpent's craftiness, since he had named all the animals before God created Eve ([2:19-20](#), [23](#)).
- *Did God really say:* The deceiver started by twisting God's words to make the people doubt God's goodness. God's original rule applied to only one tree ([2:16-17](#)), not to all of them.

Genesis 3:1-24

When the man and woman rebelled against God, it disrupted their harmony with the earth, animals, each other, and God.

Genesis 3:2-3

The woman tried to clarify things. But in several ways, she made the privileges God gave her and her husband seem less important:

1. She changed God's words from "freely eat" ([2:16](#)) to *may eat*.
2. She minimized the importance of having fruit from every tree except one ([2:17](#)).
3. She added not touching to God's rule against eating ([2:17](#)).
4. She made the threat of death seem less certain ([2:17](#)).

Genesis 3:4-5

You will not surely die: This directly contradicts God's clear and emphatic words: "you will surely die" ([2:17](#)). The serpent takes advantage of the woman's doubt. He denies there will be any penalty and quickly shifts her focus to the supposed reward. He says she will become like God, knowing good and evil.

The deceiver falsely implies that this would be totally beneficial for them. The term used for God is *Elohim*. It can also mean "divine beings," such as God and the angels (for example, [Psalms 29:1](#); [89:7](#)).

Genesis 3:6

- *She saw ... that it was desirable:* The woman made two serious mistakes:
 1. She assumed she could decide what was good or bad. But God is the only one who has the right to decide what is good or bad.
 2. She coveted God's wisdom, meaning she strongly desired something that did not belong to her (see [Deuteronomy 5:21](#)).

- *her husband who was with her:* Scripture highlights the woman's role in humanity's first sin (compare [1 Timothy 2:14](#)). But, the man was also present and responsible. He becomes the focus in the following verses and in biblical teaching. His sin brought serious consequences for all people. The good news is that through Jesus Christ, the "second Adam," God offers salvation to everyone ([Romans 5:12–21](#)).

Genesis 3:7

- Shame is the opposite of the naked innocence Adam and Eve enjoyed before they disobeyed God ([2:25](#)). This damaged their relationship with each other and God.
- *sewed together fig leaves:* These covered their bodies but not their shame. They could not fix their broken relationships (see also [3:21](#) and study note).

Genesis 3:8

- *in the garden in the breeze of the day:* Traditionally, the Hebrew text refers to the cool part of the day, probably the evening. Some believe it describes a powerful appearance of God's presence (a *theophany*; see [Exodus 19:16–25](#); [1 Samuel 7:10](#)) as a storm. If this is true, the man and woman hid from the sound of the Lord appearing in judgment (see [2 Samuel 5:24](#); [Psalm 29](#)).
- God placed *the trees of the garden* for humans to enjoy fellowship with him. Now, the man and woman used them to hide from God.

Genesis 3:9–10

- *Where are you?:* The man's answer shows the real purpose of this question ([3:10](#)). The real meaning of the question was, "Why are you hiding?" (compare [4:9–10](#)).
- *I was afraid because I was naked:* Modesty was not the problem. The shame from their rebellion made Adam and his wife hide. They might have also feared punishment (see study note on 3:8).

Genesis 3:12

The woman whom You gave me: The man avoided admitting his sin. He blamed the woman for giving him the fruit and blamed God for giving him the woman.

Genesis 3:13

- *What is this you have done?:* This question is not asked to get information. It is an expression of shock and horror (see [4:10](#)).
- *The serpent deceived me:* The man blamed the woman ([3:12](#)), and the woman blamed the serpent. The serpent did play a role and would be punished ([3:14](#)). But this did not free the woman or the man from their guilt.

Genesis 3:14

- *to the serpent:* Though later revelation identifies the deceiver as Satan, it is the created animal who was cursed, like the ground ([3:17](#)).
- *On your belly will you go, and dust you will eat:* Groveling in the dust shows humiliation and defeat ([Psalm 72:9](#); [Micah 7:17](#)).

Genesis 3:14–19

God judged the serpent, woman, and man because of their sin. Each received a punishment specific to their actions. Their important relationships changed. God is fair in judgment, not unpredictable. Each punishment matches the sin.

Genesis 3:15

- *enmity*: The prophet Isaiah looks ahead to a future when the Messiah's kingdom will restore all creation to peace, like the garden of Eden before humans disobeyed God (see [Isaiah 11:8](#)).
- *her seed* (or *offspring*): This term can refer to a single descendant or many. In ancient Near Eastern culture, "you and your offspring" (see [Genesis 28:14](#)) describes a shared identity. Here, it describes ongoing hostility between humans and snakes. The pattern is set using singular terms (*He ... you*). Christian interpreters have traditionally understood this verse to be a prophecy about Christ. He is the seed of Abraham and fulfills the promise of the woman's seed (see [Galatians 3:16; 4:4](#)).
- *strike*: This refers to the suffering of God's servant (see [Isaiah 53](#)). Crushing the serpent's head is a more decisive action. The death, resurrection, and final victory of Jesus over Satan fulfill this promise (see [1 Corinthians 15:55–57](#); [Revelation 12:7–9](#); [20:7–10](#)).

Genesis 3:16

- The judgment affects the woman's special role in childbearing and her relationship with her husband.
- *Your desire will be for your husband, and he will rule over you*: The marriage relationship now includes conflict instead of only security and happiness. New life in Jesus can restore a man and woman's marriage relationship ([Ephesians 5:18–32](#); compare [Matthew 20:25–28](#)).

Genesis 3:17–19

- God emphasized his first command not to eat the fruit by mentioning eating several times in [3:17–19](#). The judgment made it harder for humans to get food. This matched their sin of eating what God had forbidden.
- *cursed is the ground*: The man's relationship with the ground (see study note on 2:7) became hostile as judgment affected his main role ([2:5, 15](#)). He must work hard to cultivate the ground, but with less success than before. Human sin impacts all of creation (see [4:12](#); [6:7](#); [Leviticus 26](#); [Deuteronomy 11:13–17, 28](#); [Romans 8:22](#)).

Genesis 3:20

The name *Eve* (Hebrew *khawah*) sounds like the word *khayah*, which means "to give life." After God announced Adam's future death ([3:19](#)), Adam showed hope by naming Eve with a name related to life. Adam named Eve soon after [3:16](#). Some understand this to show that Adam's act of naming the woman reflects his role and responsibility in the relationship after they sinned (see study note on 2:19–20).

Genesis 3:20–24

Soon after they were judged for their sin, Adam and Eve were banished from the garden.

Genesis 3:21

God showed mercy and gave Adam and Eve better clothing (compare [3:7](#)) before sending them into the harsh world outside the garden.

Genesis 3:22

- *like one of Us*: The plural likely shows God speaking with his heavenly court of angels (see study note on [1:26](#)).
- *the tree of life ... live forever*: God showed mercy by preventing the humans from eating from the tree of life and living forever in a sinful condition. But through Jesus Christ, eternal life is available again (see [Revelation 2:7](#); [22:2](#), [14](#), [19](#)).

Genesis 3:23

Therefore the LORD God banished him from the Garden of Eden: Before humans disobeyed God, the garden was a sanctuary where humans could be in God's holy presence. Now their sin meant God had to expel them from that place. This same idea also influenced Israel's laws. The laws limited the access Israelites had to God in the tabernacle or temple (for example, [Leviticus 16:1–2](#); [Numbers 5:3](#)).

Genesis 3:24

- Cherubim are a type of angel that guard access to God's presence ([Exodus 26:31](#); [Ezekiel 28:14](#)).
- *east ... of Eden*: In Genesis, moving east often means leaving God's presence or blessing. This can happen because of:
 - judgment ([Genesis 4:16](#)),
 - human pride or independence ([Genesis 11:2](#); [Genesis 13:11](#)), or
 - separation from the family ([Genesis 25:6](#)).

Genesis 4:1

- *had relations* (literally *knew*): In some contexts, the Hebrew word meaning "to know" is a way to describe having sexual relations with someone ([4:17](#); [19:33](#), [35](#)). It is never used for animals, which mate by instinct.
- *With the help of the LORD*: Eve fulfilled her God-given role of having children despite the negative effects of sin (see [3:16](#), [20](#)).
- *I have brought forth a man: Cain* (Hebrew *qayin*) sounds like a Hebrew word (*qanah*) that can mean "produce" or "acquire."

Genesis 4:2

Cain's brother Abel: The name "Abel" may come from the Hebrew word *habel*, meaning "breath," "vapor," or "meaningless." This might hint at Abel's tragically short life (compare [Ecclesiastes 1:2](#)). Alternatively, it may come from the Akkadian word *ablu*, meaning "son."

Genesis 4:3

There was nothing wrong with offering grain to the Lord ([Leviticus 2:14](#); [Deuteronomy 26:2-4](#)). But Cain only gave a small portion of his crops. God requires the first and best ([Exodus 23:16, 19; 34:22, 26](#)). Cain's attitude made his offering less valuable than Abel's ([Hebrews 11:4](#)). So, God did not accept Cain's offering.

Genesis 4:4-5

the best portions of the firstborn of his flock (or the firstborn of his flock and their fat portions): Abel gave God the best animals and their richest parts. Unlike Cain, Abel offered the best he had. True worship is a costly privilege.

Genesis 4:7

sin is crouching at your door ... you must master it: Sin is like a wild animal ready to attack Cain (see study note on 3:16). Either sin will control Cain, or Cain will fight against the urge to sin. There is no middle ground in this struggle.

Genesis 4:8

- The impact of the sin on human relationships is tragically shown in the first murder.
- The word *brother* appears seven times in [4:2-11](#), emphasizing Cain's act of killing his brother despite responsibility to one's family.

Genesis 4:9

Where is your brother?: The questions God asked Cain ([4:6, 9, 10](#)) remind us of those God asked Cain's parents ([3:9-13](#)). In both situations, humans answered by avoiding the truth (compare [3:12-13](#)). It is surprising how defiant Cain's answer is. This suggests that his attitude was the real problem with his offering.

Genesis 4:10

- *What have you done?*: This is more an expression of horror and blame than a question seeking answers (see [3:13](#)).
- Abel's blood acts as a legal witness that accuses Cain of a crime.
- *from the ground*: See study note on 4:11-12.

Genesis 4:11-12

- Like his father (see [3:9-12, 17-19](#)), God asked Cain questions before he judged him ([4:9-10](#)). Adam's sin had already caused the ground to be cursed. Now Cain was cursed and driven away from the land he had farmed because he had polluted it with innocent blood.
- *a fugitive and a wanderer*: God sentenced Cain to endless wandering in a land that offered neither food nor safety. The consequences of sin were becoming worse.

Genesis 4:13-14

For Cain, being driven from the land (the place where he worked as a farmer; see [4:2](#); compare [3:23](#)) meant being separated from God's presence. God warned the Israelites to remain faithful to the Sinai covenant. If not, he would force them to leave the promised land. This would also mean separation from God's presence in the temple (see, for example, [Leviticus 26:27-32](#)).

Genesis 4:15

- Sevenfold punishment was the full weight of justice. Cain complained that his punishment was too harsh. But the severe sentence for anyone who killed Cain shows how gracious the Lord was to him. Cain deserved death (see [9:5–6](#)).
- The *mark* graciously provided protection to Cain after God's judgment (compare [3:21](#)).

Genesis 4:16

- The name *Nod* (which means "wandering") describes Cain's fate (see [4:12](#), [14](#)) more than a specific place. It suggests a life of wandering, and its exact location is unknown. Cain's sin denied him rest and a sense of belonging.
- Cain's exile east of Eden is another point of connection with Adam's story (compare [3:24](#)). Cain did not learn from his father's sin, so he also experienced separation from the ground and was driven east into exile (see study note on [3:24](#)).

Genesis 4:17

- Cain likely married a close relative, since Adam and Eve had other sons and daughters ([5:4](#)). The Bible does not give further details.
- God condemned Cain to be a wanderer. He might have built a city to rebel against this punishment, using walls for protection. Naming the city after his son shows how people who rebel against God often make humanity and its achievements into idols.

Genesis 4:17–5:32

These records of family lines do more than just list names. They contrast how human culture developed. Some people rebelled against God (Cain, [4:17–24](#)), while others obeyed God (Seth, [4:25–5:32](#)). Genesis usually explains the history of the rejected line before continuing with the promised line that became Israel.

Two key contrasts are worth noting:

1. Lamech is the main focus of the first family history. He is the seventh man from Adam through Cain's line. Like Cain, Lamech killed a human and lived in fear of death as a result ([4:23–24](#)). In contrast, Enoch lived in a way that pleased God and did not experience death ([5:24](#)). Enoch was the seventh man from Adam through Seth's line ([4:25–5:32](#)).
2. Human culture and technology advanced through Cain's line. They made the first city, raised livestock, built shelters, developed metal work, and created music. But sin still strongly shaped human life. Seth's line does not have any technological advances mentioned. Instead, people began "to call upon the name of the LORD" ([4:26](#)) and "found favor in the eyes of the Lord" ([6:8](#)).

Genesis 4:18

father of: This can also mean "ancestor of," and this meaning applies throughout the verse. Hebrew family lists do not always include every generation.

Genesis 4:19

Marrying two women was against God's ideal pattern for marriage ([2:24](#)). It might also show the pride and rebellion of Cain's descendants.

Genesis 4:20–22

New tools and skills can hide a growing desire for people to rely on themselves instead of God. They

can also show that people are moving farther away from God (see study note on 4:17-5:32).

Genesis 4:23-24

- Lamech's disturbing boast shows how sin's impact on humanity has increased. Cain's descendants reached an extreme of violence with Lamech's contempt for human life. In his arrogance, he turned his actions into a poem.
- *avenged ... seventy-sevenfold*: God warned that anyone who tried to kill Cain would experience total justice (4:15). Lamech claimed that anyone who harmed him would face an even more severe penalty. This shows he felt accountable to no one, not even God.

Genesis 4:25

another seed in place of Abel: Cain (4:8-16) and Lamech (4:19-24) show the consequences of sin. The birth of Seth brought new hope. See also study note on 5:1-2.

Genesis 4:25-5:32

The story returns to Adam and follows the line of Seth. This family line later leads to Abraham and the nation of Israel.

Genesis 4:26

Enosh means "humankind." In the Old Testament, this term often appears in poems emphasizing human mortality and weakness (for example, [Psalm 144:3](#), "what is man").

Enosh was born when people started to worship the Lord by name (literally *call upon the name of the LORD*). In Genesis, this meant worshiping the Lord through sacrifice and prayer (similar Hebrew terms are found in [Genesis 12:8](#); [13:4](#); [21:33](#); [26:25](#)).

Genesis 5:1

- *the book of the generations*: The earlier section ([2:4-4:26](#)) focused on Adam, Eve, and their first children. But it was more about "the account of the heavens and the earth." [Genesis 5:1-32](#) is a more typical family line.
- *in His own likeness*: See [1:26](#) and study note.

Genesis 5:1-2

This section introduces the second account in Genesis ([5:1-6:8](#); see study note on 2:4). It connects God's purpose in creation with the line of Seth rather than the line of Cain ([4:17-24](#)).

Genesis 5:1-32

The family lines in Genesis do more than record history. They use select details and structure to communicate spiritual truths. These genealogies show God's blessings. They confirm the family heritage of key people. They connect the Genesis story by showing family continuity.

Adam's family line through Seth records ten generations to Noah (see [1 Chronicles 1:1-4](#); [Luke 3:36-38](#)). The great flood occurred before another 10 generations from Noah to Abram. The number 10 symbolizes completeness. Examples include the 10 plagues ([Exodus 7:8-11:10](#)) and the Ten Commandments ([Exodus 20:2-17](#)). Noah ended the pre-flood history, and Abram began a new era.

Genesis 5:2

- *Male and female ... "man"* (Hebrew 'adam): See [1:27](#) and study note.
- *blessed them*: See [1:28](#) and study note.

Genesis 5:3

in his own likeness, after his own image: The image and likeness of God continue to exist in all human beings even after sin entered the world (see note on [1:26](#)). When Adam had children, they carried

both the image of God and the effects of Adam's sin ([Romans 5:12–14](#)).

Genesis 5:5

he died: Adam died (see [2:17](#); [3:18–19](#)) and so did his descendants (see [Romans 5:12–14](#)).

The Bible does not mention Cain's violent actions here (see [Genesis 4:8](#), [15](#), [23–24](#)). Important figures in Seth's family line live in hope (see [5:29](#)).

Genesis 5:6

the father of: This can also mean “ancestor of.” Hebrew family lists do not always list every generation.

Genesis 5:22

Enoch walked with God (also in [5:24](#)): Enoch, the seventh man from Adam in the family line, contrasts with Lamech, the seventh man from Adam in Cain's family line (see study note on 4:17–5:32).

Genesis 5:24

Unlike other sons of Adam, Enoch did not die. Instead, he disappeared because God took him away (compare [2 Kings 2:9–12](#) and [Hebrews 11:5](#)).

Genesis 5:27

969 years: This statement and the numbers given in [5:25](#), [28](#), and [7:6](#) mean that Methuselah died the same year as the great flood.

Genesis 5:28–29

Like Enoch ([5:21–24](#)), the typical family line pattern is interrupted to share key theological details about Noah.

The name *Noah* sounds like the Hebrew words *nakhham*, which means “relief” or “comfort,” and *nuakh*, which means “rest.” Noah was the first person born after Adam died (see study note on

5:5). His father, Lamech, hoped Noah would undo the curse caused by Adam's sin ([3:17](#)). See [8:21](#); [2 Corinthians 1:3–7](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:16–17](#).

Genesis 6:1–2

The sons of God have generally been understood as fallen angels (or demons). The main interpretation of the phrase seems to refer to demons. The same Hebrew phrase is in [Job 1:6](#); [2:1](#); [38:7](#); [Psalms 29:1](#); [89:7](#). This idea appears often in ancient Jewish and Christian writings (for example, *1 Enoch* 6:1–7:6; Justin Martyr, *Apology* 2.5). The New Testament also seems to support this view in some passages (see [1 Peter 3:18–20](#); [2 Peter 2:4](#); [Jude 1:6–7](#)).

Some interpreters argue that God would not allow angels to have children with humans. They doubt that the New Testament texts should be understood in this way.

Another possibility is that the phrase *the sons of God* refers to the righteous descendants of Seth. The beautiful women would be from Cain's evil line. This matches [Genesis 4:17–5:32](#) but is weakened by the language of [6:1–2](#). That passage seems to refer to all human daughters, not just Cain's.

Others believe the phrase *the sons of God* refers to cruel human kings. These kings were possibly influenced by demons. They followed Lamech's practice of having multiple wives and made it even worse ([4:19](#)) by seizing the daughters of righteous people. The language is similar to [3:6](#) (“saw ... took”). It shows the rebellious nature of their actions.

Genesis 6:1–8

Human wickedness became very great, so God sent the flood to destroy all living things. But there is a sign of hope, because God showed favor to Noah ([6:8](#)).

Genesis 6:3

- *will not contend with:* Many think that this is an announcement of God's decision to withdraw the restraining influence of his Spirit from human society and allow human wickedness to fully develop. Others think it means God would take away his life-giving breath from humans at an earlier age. The Hebrew word *ruakh* can mean both "spirit" and "breath" (see [6:17](#); [7:22](#); see also [Psalm 104:29-30](#)).
- *his days shall be 120 years:* This might be a new limit on how long people could live. But after the great flood, people lived longer than 120 years (see, for example, [Genesis 11:10-26](#)). Or, this might refer to a 120-year period of grace before the great flood (see [Jonah 3:4](#); [Matthew 24:37-38](#); [1 Peter 3:20](#); [2 Peter 2:5](#)).

Genesis 6:4

The Nephilim: This term might mean "fallen ones." The context suggests they were the children of the *sons of God* and God would destroy them in the great flood. [Numbers 13:31-33](#) uses the same term for other giants who opposed God's people and would also be destroyed. [Deuteronomy 2:11](#) connects the Anakite *nephilim* with another group called the Rephaim (Hebrew *repa'im*).

Genesis 6:5

- *every inclination of the thoughts of his heart:* In the Old Testament, the heart is the center of choice, thought, and morality (see [Proverbs 4:23](#)). Wicked actions come from a corrupt inner life.
- *altogether evil all the time:* Strong language shows how widespread, deep, and persistent human evil is. Humanity remained corrupt even after the great flood (see [Genesis 8:21](#)).

Genesis 6:6

- *The LORD regretted:* Because humans had become so evil, the Lord regretted creating them (see also [6:7](#); compare [1 Samuel 15:11, 35](#)).
- *He was grieved in his heart:* The evil in people's hearts caused God great sadness ([Genesis 6:5](#)). Sending the flood brought deep grief to God.

Genesis 6:7

- *blot out ... from the ... earth:* Just as God expelled Adam and Eve from the garden-sanctuary ([3:23](#)), God would remove all humans from his good creation.
- *every man and beast and crawling creature and bird of the air:* Human sin had so damaged the earth that animals and birds, over which humans had control, faced judgment (see [1:28](#) and study note). Humans have a special role in creation ([1:28-30](#)), so human moral decisions influence creation (see [8:1](#); [Job 38:41](#); [Hosea 4:3](#); [Romans 8:19-22](#)).

Genesis 6:8

Noah lived a godly life, which was very different from the sinful lives of the rest of humanity.

Genesis 6:9

- *the account:* See study note on 2:4
- *a righteous man, blameless in his generation:* The text does not say Noah was without sin (see [Romans 5:12-14](#)). Noah was righteous and blameless because he had a close relationship with God. See also [Genesis 7:1](#); [17:1](#); [Hebrews 11:7](#).

Genesis 6:11–13

- See [Genesis 6:5–7](#).
- *violence*: The Hebrew word here is *khamas*. Murder had greatly corrupted Cain's descendants ([4:8, 23–24](#)).

Genesis 6:14

- *ark*: This was a long rectangular boat built for survival, not navigation. The Hebrew word *tebah* is the same for the basket that carried baby Moses on the Nile River ([Exodus 2:3, 5](#)).
- *gopher wood*: It is not clear what kind of wood this was. It may have come from a conifer (a tree like cypress).

Genesis 6:15

The ark was so large that when it floated, it likely pushed aside about 43,300 tons of water. This is similar to how much water a modern large cargo ship moves aside when it floats.

Genesis 6:16

- A gap of about 46 centimeters (18 inches) below the roof went around the boat. This allowed light and air to enter the boat.
- God told Noah to build a door, and God would close it ([Genesis 7:16](#)). God was the captain of this unique boat, which had no sail or rudder. God also brought the animals to Noah ([Genesis 6:20](#)).

Genesis 6:17

will bring floodwaters upon the earth: Some scholars suggest the great flood might have only covered the ancient Near East, as known to Noah or Moses. But the flood's purpose was to destroy every living thing that breathes (see also [6:7, 11–](#)

[13; 7:1, 4, 18–23; 8:21](#)). It was also intended to undo creation (see study notes on 1:9–10; 7:11–12). This suggests the great flood covered the entire planet (see also [1 Peter 3:20; 2 Peter 2:5; 3:6](#)).

Genesis 6:18

This is the first clear mention of a covenant (a formal and binding agreement) in the Bible. It refers to a promise that God made on his own with people and with all the earth after the great flood (see [9:9, 11, 14–17](#)).

Genesis 6:19–20

- *every kind*: God's instructions to Noah repeat the language of creation (compare [1:24](#), "according to their kinds").
- *male and a female*: These animals would reproduce and repopulate the earth again after the great flood.

Genesis 7:2

every kind of clean animal: There were animals meant to repopulate the earth. There were also these ceremonially clean animals for food and for Noah's sacrifice after the flood ([8:20–21](#)).

This passage does not use the specific terms found in the rules about ceremonially clean and unclean animals given to Israel at Mount Sinai (see [Leviticus 11; Deuteronomy 14:3–12](#)). But the basic idea is the same. It could be that God explained it directly to Noah.

Genesis 7:4

The number *forty* is often connected with times of testing, hardship, or judgment (see [Exodus 16:35; Judges 13:1; 1 Kings 19:8; Ezekiel 4:6; Jonah 3:4; Matthew 4:2; Acts 1:3](#)).

Genesis 7:6

came upon the earth: See study note on 6:17 for more information.

Genesis 7:8

See the study note on 7:2.

Genesis 7:11–12

- *on the seventeenth day of the second month:* This specific detail gives the flood account a sense of seriousness. It shows that the event is presented as something that happened in history.
- *fountains of the great deep:* See [2:6](#).
- *the floodgates of the heavens were opened:* The great flood undid the boundaries established on the second and third days of creation ([1:6–13](#)). Other parts of the Bible describe God's judgment as undoing creation (see [Jeremiah 4:23–26](#); [Amos 7:4](#)).
- *forty days and forty nights:* See study note on 7:4.

Genesis 7:16

the LORD shut him in: This showed that God was in control. He protected the people inside the ark and punished those who remained outside (see also [6:16](#) and study note).

Genesis 7:17

- *the waters rose* (literally *waters multiplied*): This is the same word used for the increase of humans and animals during creation (see [1:22](#), [28](#)). Now, ironically, the story uses this word for the water that would destroy them.
- *high above the earth:* The Hebrew word translated as “ground” or “earth” appears eight times in eight verses ([7:17–24](#)). The great flood was now cleansing the earth, which humans had polluted.

Genesis 7:22

every living thing: See study note on 6:17.

Genesis 8:1

- *God remembered:* This key part of the great flood story does not mean God ever forgot Noah. It uses covenant language to show God's faithfulness to his promise to keep his covenant partner safe (see [6:18](#); [9:15–16](#); [Exodus 2:24](#); [Leviticus 26:42, 45](#)).
- *wind:* The same Hebrew word is translated as “Spirit” in [Genesis 1:2](#). This and other similarities suggest that restoring the earth after the great flood was like a new creation (see [Genesis 9:1–2](#)).

Genesis 8:2

The springs of the deep and the floodgates of the heavens: See study note on 7:11–12.

Genesis 8:4

The mountains of Ararat might be in the region of Ararat (Urartu), southeast of the Black Sea near Lake Van. This area borders parts of eastern

Turkey, Armenia, and Iran. There is a Mount Ararat (*Agri Dag*) in Turkey, but this verse only identifies the region, not a specific mountain.

Genesis 8:5

the waters continued to recede: This is another similarity to the creation week (see [1:9](#)). This suggests that restoring the earth was like a new creation (see study note on 8:1).

Genesis 8:7

The *raven* is the biggest bird in the crow family and in Noah's time the raven was considered ceremonially unclean ([Leviticus 11:15](#); [Deuteronomy 14:14](#)). As a scavenger that eats dead animals, it could survive without returning to the boat.

Genesis 8:11

Unlike the raven ([8:7](#)), the dove eats plants. Olive trees are short, so Noah knew the water was almost gone.

Genesis 8:13

In Noah's six hundred and first year, on the first day of the first month: This was two months after the mountain peaks first appeared ([8:5](#)).

Genesis 8:14

the earth was fully dry: This word for dry land is often used with the sea to show God's rule over both land and sea (see [1:9–10](#); [Exodus 14:22, 29](#); [Psalm 95:5](#); [Jonah 1:9](#)).

Genesis 8:17

be fruitful and multiply: See [9:1](#).

Genesis 8:20

- This first mention of an altar in the Bible shows how thankful Noah was for surviving the judgment.
- *offered burnt offerings:* The same wording is used for the whole burnt offering in Leviticus ([Leviticus 1:3–9](#)), but it can refer to any offering that is burned. Noah gave this offering to thank and worship God, who saved him and his family from the great flood.

Genesis 8:21

- *smelled the pleasing aroma*: The narrator uses anthropomorphic language (he describes God's activity in human terms) to show God's acceptance of Noah's offering (see also [Exodus 29:18](#); [Leviticus 1:9](#); [Numbers 15:3](#)). In the ancient Near East, people often believed that their gods ate the sacrifices offered to them. This idea is not found in the Bible.
- *in his heart*: This is the same phrase as in [6:6](#). In the same way, here *every inclination of his heart* echoes "every inclination of the thoughts of his heart" ([6:5](#)). God's commitment to a new order replaced his grief over the old.
- *Never again will I curse ... destroy*: The old curse remained ([5:29](#)), but God promised not to add to it. He set new limits for life in a chaotic world (compare [Isaiah 54:9](#)). The flood was meant to stop violence, not to change the human heart (the inner thoughts and desires that lead people to do wrong; [Genesis 6:5](#)). Human beings have a tendency toward evil, but this would be limited to some degree by a new law that holds people responsible for their actions ([9:5-6](#)).

Genesis 8:22

God's promise to sustain the rhythm of the seasons reaffirmed the created order ([1:14](#); see also [Jeremiah 33:20](#); [Zechariah 14:7](#)).

Genesis 9:1

Be fruitful and multiply: This blessing and command, first given to Adam ([1:28](#)), God now gives again to Noah. He is the "Adam" of the newly cleansed world in need of repopulation.

Genesis 9:1-7

God's first speech after the great flood starts and ends with a blessing ([9:1](#), [7](#)). In this speech, God explains again how humans and animals relate to each other, with some changes from the original creation. God gives special attention to the value of life (the importance of protecting human life).

Genesis 9:2-3

There are two changes to the original order of creation:

1. Before the flood, humans ruled over the animals ([1:28](#)). After the flood, animals would fear humans. This uses language often connected with military victory (see [Exodus 23:27-31](#), [Deuteronomy 11:25](#); [31:8](#)).
2. This fear is connected to a change in human diet. Humans were now allowed to eat animal meat, in addition to grains, fruits, and vegetables ([Genesis 1:29](#)).

Genesis 9:4

God gives an important restriction. Blood represents life (it stands for life), so it had to be drained from an animal before its meat could be eaten (see [Leviticus 3:17](#); [7:26-27](#); [17:10-14](#); [Deuteronomy 12:16, 23](#)).

The Law of Moses also forbade eating animals that died naturally, because their blood had not been drained ([Deuteronomy 14:21](#)). God provided animal blood to atone for human sin ([Leviticus 17:11](#); [Hebrews 9:22](#)).

Genesis 9:5-6

Violence, including murder, was a major factor in bringing about God's judgment of the flood ([4:8](#); [6:11](#), [13](#)). At this new beginning for human beings, God affirmed the value of human life (that human life is sacred) and established justice for those who take a human life (see also [Psalm 9:12](#); "Retribution" Theme Note).

The function of law is to restrain human wickedness and preserve moral order. This law was further developed in the law of Moses ([Exodus 21:12-14](#); [Leviticus 24:17-22](#); [Numbers 35:16-34](#); [Deuteronomy 17:6-7](#); [19:15](#)).

Genesis 9:6

for in His own image God has made mankind: God made human beings in his own image. That is why this passage gives a theological reason for the death penalty in the Old Testament. Human beings have a unique place in creation because they bear God's image ([1:26-28](#)). If someone murders another person, that person destroys a life that reflects God in a special way. Because of that, the murderer must receive the highest penalty. See also [Exodus 21:23-25](#).

This does not mean people should take revenge for themselves ([Romans 12:17-19](#)). Instead, God has given governing authorities the duty to carry out justice ([Romans 13:1-7](#)).

Genesis 9:7

be fruitful and multiply; spread out (literally *swarm and fill*): In contrast to those who would destroy human life ([9:5-6](#)), God wants human life to grow and flourish.

Genesis 9:8-17

God's second post-flood speech conveys his promise and plan for preserving creation.

Genesis 9:9-10

God had promised this covenant before the flood ([6:18](#)). Its scope extends beyond humanity to include the earth and all animals.

Genesis 9:11

This promise does not prohibit worldwide judgment, but it restricts the means by which God will do it (see [2 Pet 3:4-13](#)).

Genesis 9:12

In the Bible, covenants are frequently confirmed by some sort of sign (e.g., [17:11](#); [Exod 31:13, 17](#); [Luke 22:20](#)).

Genesis 9:13-16

- God brought great judgment through the rainstorm (a very large and destructive storm). Now he gives the rainbow as a sign of peace for the whole earth (see [9:17](#)). The rainbow appears after the rainstorm and is connected to it, but it now shows that God will not destroy the earth in this way again.
- The same Hebrew word can mean both "rainbow" and "bow" (a weapon used in war). In some places, God is described as a warrior who shoots arrows to bring judgment (see [Deuteronomy 32:42](#); [Psalms 7:12](#); [18:13-14](#); [Habakkuk 3:9-11](#)). Because of this, some interpreters think the picture in [Genesis 9:13-17](#) shows God hanging up his bow. This means he is putting aside his weapon of judgment and choosing peace instead.

Genesis 9:18

Ham was the father of Canaan: See also [9:20-27](#); [10:6-20](#). The text repeats this idea to show a connection between Canaan and Ham. It explains that the people of Canaan came from Ham's family line.

This connection also points back to Ham's shameful act (a serious dishonor) in [9:20-27](#). Because of this, the identity of the Canaanites is closely tied to that event.

The people of Egypt (where Israel lived as slaves) and the people of Canaan (the land Israel later entered) both came from Ham's descendants ([10:6](#); see [Leviticus 18:3, 24-26](#); [Psalms 105:23, 27](#); [106:22](#)).

Later stories in Genesis describe moral failure (wrong behavior) in both places. Egypt is shown

this way ([Genesis 12:10–20](#)) and Canaan ([34:1–31](#); [38:1–30](#); see [9:20–27](#) and [10:6–20](#)).

Genesis 9:20–27

The story of Noah begins with him walking in righteousness and obeying the Lord ([6:9](#)). It ends with him drunk and naked in his tent, cursing Canaan. Even after the great flood, people still showed sinful behaviors that led to the flood.

The text emphasizes the cursed origin of the Canaanites, a corrupt and idol-worshiping group. Israel would later remove them from the promised land (see also [15:16](#) and study note; [Leviticus 18:3](#); [20:23](#)).

Genesis 9:21

wine ... became drunk: Wine is a gift from God ([Deuteronomy 14:26](#); [Psalm 104:15](#); [Isaiah 55:1](#); see [Luke 22:14–20](#); [John 2:1–11](#)). Scripture clearly teaches that drinking too much alcohol is a dangerous sin ([Proverbs 23:20–21](#), [29–35](#); [1 Corinthians 6:10](#)).

Genesis 9:22

- *the father of Canaan:* See study note on 9:18.
- Ham's behavior was shameful. He looked at his father's nakedness and did not cover him. Instead, he told his brothers and took away his father's honor (see [Exodus 21:15](#), [17](#); [Lamentations 4:21](#); [Habakkuk 2:15](#)). An ancient Near Eastern story says that a son is expected to come to his father's aid when he is drunk (*Tale of Aqhat*; compare [Isaiah 51:17–18](#)). Ham did not do his duty to his family. Because of this, Noah blessed Shem and Japheth but cursed Ham ([Genesis 9:24–27](#)).

Genesis 9:25

Cursed be Canaan!: Noah understood that Ham's actions showed the character of his descendants through Canaan.

Genesis 9:26

Noah refers to God as *the LORD*, who made a covenant with Israel. Shem became the ancestor of the people of Israel (see [10:21–32](#)).

Genesis 9:27

may he dwell in the tents of Shem: Japheth's descendants would live among Shem's descendants and share Shem's prosperity (compare [Romans 11:17–18](#)).

Genesis 10:1

who also had sons after the flood: This fulfilled the renewed command of creation to populate the earth ([9:1](#), [9](#); compare [1:28](#)).

Genesis 10:1–11.9

The fifth account ([10:1](#)) in Genesis (see study note on 2:4) unites the Table of Nations ([10:2–32](#)) and the Babel story ([11:1–9](#)) around the theme of scattering the nations ([10:5](#), [18](#); [11:4](#), [8–9](#)). The Table of Nations appears before the Babel story, but the Babel event explains how the nations and languages in that list came to exist.

By placing these events in this order, Genesis connects the filling of the earth with the blessing God gave to Noah and his sons (see [9:1](#) and study note). It shows that the growth of the nations comes from God's blessing.

This order also prepares for Abram's call ([12:1–3](#)). Abram's call shows God's answer to the problem seen at Babel ([11:1–9](#)), where humans were separated from God. Through Abram, God begins to restore that relationship.

Genesis 10:2

- The seven sons of Japheth settled in the region of Anatolia (the western plateau lands of Turkey) and spoke Indo-European languages.
- Gomer was the ancestor of the Cimmerians, who lived north of the Black Sea.
- Magog probably was the ancestor of those who settled in Lydia (see [Ezekiel 38:2](#)).
- The descendants of Madai became the Medes of northwest Iran (see [2 Kings 17:6](#); [Jeremiah 51:11](#); [Daniel 5:28](#)).
- The descendants of Javan were the Ionian Greeks.
- The descendants of Tubal and Meshech were sometimes allies in battle ([Ezekiel 38:2](#)). They probably came from Anatolia's coastal regions (see [Ezekiel 27:13](#)).
- The descendants of Tiras possibly became the Thracians living near the Aegean Sea.

Genesis 10:2–32

- This section explains where the ancient Near Eastern nations came from. Ham was at the center ([10:6–20](#)) while the descendants of Japheth and Shem spread out to the surrounding regions of Greece, Crete, Asia Minor, Mesopotamia, Madai, the Arabian peninsula, and northeast Africa.
The list is selective in focusing on nations important to Israel. The 70 names (seven times ten) indicate completeness (see [46:27](#); [Deuteronomy 32:8](#)). These names represent the whole world, which Abraham's descendants would later bless ([Genesis 18:18](#)).
- Although Shem is mentioned first in [10:1](#), he is addressed last in the Table because of his connection to Abram ([10:21–31](#); [11:10–32](#); [12:1](#)). Although God established the boundaries of all nations (see [Deuteronomy 32:8](#); [Amos 9:7](#); [Acts 17:26](#)), Israel was his special creation (a small group of 70 people; [Genesis 46:27](#)). God called them to be a blessing to a world of 70 nations (see [12:3](#)).

Genesis 10:3

- The descendants of Gomer came from the area near the upper Euphrates, north of the Black Sea (see [Ezekiel 38:1–9](#)).
- The descendants of Ashkenaz were the Scythians, who lived between the Black and Caspian Seas.
- Riphath is near Carchemish.
- The descendants of Togarmah are associated with Til-garimmu. This is the capital of Kammanu in what is now Armenia (see [Ezekiel 38:6](#)).

Genesis 10:4

- Elishah is probably Cyprus.
- Tarshish might be southwest Spain (see study note on Jonah 1:3).
- The Kittites lived in southern Cyprus.
- The Rodanites lived on the island of Rhodes, which later became part of Greece.

Genesis 10:5

- *maritime peoples ... into their territories:* These were seafaring people who settled around the Mediterranean Sea and on different islands.
- *languages:* This happened after the tower of Babel story ([11:1–9](#); see study note on 10:1–11:9).

Genesis 10:6

- The peoples descended from Ham's four sons (Egyptians, Babylonians, Assyrians, Canaanites) were Israel's most hostile neighbors.
- Cush might have been in Ethiopia or ancient Nubia (northern Sudan).
- Mizraim was the old name for Egypt ([50:11](#)).
- Put was in Libya.
- Canaan included southern Syria, Phoenicia, and Palestine west of the Jordan River. In the time of Moses, Egypt and Canaan were part of the same empire. Ham's descendants did not receive the blessing given to Shem's family line ([9:20–28](#)).

Genesis 10:7

- The sons of Cush and Raamah add up to seven in total.
- Seba was in northern Africa (see [Isaiah 43:3](#); [45:14](#)).
- Havilah was in southwest Arabia.
- Sabtah was in southern Arabia, in ancient Hadramaut, near the Persian Gulf.
- Raamah was in southwest Arabia near Najran.
- Sabteca was in ancient Samudake near the Persian Gulf.
- Sheba was a kingdom in southwest Arabia with trading colonies (see [1 Kings 10:1–29](#)).
- Dedan was in northern Arabia.

Genesis 10:8–12

The text gives special attention to the early history of Babylonia and Assyria. These Mesopotamian empires (kingdoms from the land between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers) later conquered and exiled (forced to leave their land) Israel and Judah.

Genesis 10:9

- *Nimrod* became famous through conquest and fear. His empire reached from Babylonia in the south to Assyria in the north ([10:10–12](#)).
- *a mighty hunter before the LORD:* Assyrian kings often praised their own power, showing themselves as brave hunter-conquerors.

Genesis 10:10–12

- *His kingdom*: This is the region around the Tigris and Euphrates rivers in southern Mesopotamia. This kingdom eventually expanded into northern Mesopotamia (Assyria).
- Babylon is the most important city because it played a key role in the story of the tower of Babel (see [11:4](#) and study note).
- Erech, known as ancient Uruk, is now Warka in southern Iraq (see [Ezra 4:9–10](#)).
- Accad, once called Agade, is north of Babylon and was home to the famous ruler Sargon (2370–2295 BC).
- The location of Calneh is uncertain. But it is probably one of Nimrod's cities north of Aram-naharaim in southern Mesopotamia (compare [Amos 6:2](#)).
- *built ... Nineveh*: Like Cain, Nimrod built cities (see [Genesis 4:17](#) and comments). Nineveh was an ancient Assyrian city on the east bank of the Tigris River in northern Iraq.
- Rehoboth-Ir was either a nearby city or a daughter-city of Nineveh.
- Calah is modern Tell Nimrud, south of Nineveh.
- Resen is possibly modern Selamiyeh, northwest of Tell Nimrud.

Genesis 10:13–14

- *the Ludites* were Lydian tribes located west of the Nile delta.
- The identity of *the Anamites* is unclear. They might have been Egyptians near Cyrene, west of Egypt.
- *the Lehabites* were probably a Libyan tribe.
- *the Naphtuhites* lived in northern Egypt.
- *the Pathrusites* lived in southern Egypt.
- *the Casluhites* might have lived in an Egyptian area also known as "Cyrenaica."
- *the Caphtorites* were Cretans (see [Jeremiah 47:4](#); [Amos 9:7](#)).
- *the Philistines* from Crete were warriors and traders who traveled by ship from Crete to settle in southwest Canaan. They lived there during the time when the Israelites left Egypt and in later periods ([Exodus 13:17](#); [Amos 9:7](#)). During the early years of Israel's kings, the Philistines were one of Israel's strongest enemies (see 1–2 Samuel).

Genesis 10:15–18

- Sidon settled in Phoenicia, north of Canaan.
- *the Hittites*: In Genesis, these were a group of cities in Canaan (see [26:34–35](#); [27:46](#); [Ezekiel 16:3](#)). They were probably different from the Hittites of Anatolia (Asia Minor). Their empire was a major power in the time of the biblical patriarchs.
- The Jebusites were ancient people living in Jerusalem ([Joshua 15:63](#); [Judges 19:10–11](#); [2 Samuel 5:6–9](#)).
- The Amorites lived in the mountains of Palestine in Canaan (see [Genesis 15:16](#); [48:22](#); [Numbers 13:29](#); [Deuteronomy 3:8](#); [Joshua 10:5](#); [Judges 1:35](#); [10:8](#); [Ezekiel 16:3](#)).
- Little is known about the Girgashites, a Canaanite tribe ([Genesis 15:21](#); [Deuteronomy 7:1](#); [Joshua 3:10](#)).
- The Hivites were a Canaanite people group who did not practice circumcision ([Genesis 34:2](#), [13–24](#); [Joshua 9:1](#), [7](#); [11:3](#); [Judges 3:3](#); [2 Samuel 24:7](#)).
- The Arkites lived in Tell 'Arqa in Lebanon.
- The Sinites formed a city-state in Phoenicia.
- The Arvadites lived in Ruad in northern Phoenicia, near the El Kebir River. They were known for shipping (compare [Ezekiel 27:8](#)).
- The Zemarites lived in Sumur (modern Sumra), north of Arka on the Phoenician coast.
- The Hamathites founded what is now Hama on the Orontes River, the northern border of Canaan (see [Numbers 34:8](#); [Joshua 13:5](#); [2 Samuel 8:9–10](#); [1 Kings 8:65](#); [2 Kings 14:25–28](#)).

Genesis 10:19

- God set apart *the borders of Canaan* to be taken from its people and given to Israel (see [15:18](#); [Numbers 34:2–12](#); [Ezekiel 47:15–20](#); [48:1–28](#)).
- An ancient highway along the seacoast, the Via Maris, ran from Sidon toward Gerar, connecting Egypt to Mesopotamia.
- Modern Gaza is 18 kilometers (11 miles) northwest of Gerar.
- Sodom and Gomorrah were cities on the southeastern border of the Dead Sea.
- *Admah, and Zeboiim*: The Bible mentions these cities 15 times in connection with Sodom and Gomorrah ([14:2](#), [8](#); [Deuteronomy 29:23](#); see [Hosea 11:8](#)). God destroyed all four cities to cleanse the land (see [Genesis 19](#)).
- Lasha was possibly in the northern area of the Dead Sea.

Genesis 10:21

- Shem, the older brother of Japheth, was the ancestor of the Semitic peoples (people groups connected by language and culture in the ancient Near East). The people listed here lived mainly to the east of Israel, in areas like modern Iraq, Iran, and Syria.
The narrator focuses on places in Mesopotamia (the land between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers). This is important because Abram, the ancestor of Israel, came from this region (see [11:27–32](#)).
- Eber receives special attention because he is an ancestor of Abram and is closely connected to the Hebrews (see study note on 10:24).

Genesis 10:22

- The descendants of Elam lived in what is now southwestern Iran (see [14:1](#), [9](#); [Ezra 4:9](#); [Isaiah 11:11](#)).
- The descendants of Asshur became the Assyrians, who lived under Nimrod's rule (see [Genesis 10:11](#)). Sumerians, who descended from Ham, were expelled by Mesopotamian Semites.
- Arphaxad may have settled northeast of Nineveh. There is more information about his descendants in [11:12–26](#).
- Lud was near the Tigris River. The people of Lud were related to the Lydians (see [10:13](#)).
- Aram was a kingdom of tribes living in the Mesopotamian plains.

Genesis 10:23

- The patriarchs later interacted with the descendants of Aram (see [25:20](#); [31:20](#); [Deuteronomy 26:5](#)).
- Uz was the main Aramean tribe, possibly northeast of the Jordan River. It was Job's home (see [Job 1:1](#); see also [Lamentations 4:21](#)).
- Hul is unknown. He might have founded Armenia.
- Gether is unknown. He might have founded the Syrians.
- Mash might have a connection to Mount Masus in northern Mesopotamia or to a part of the Lebanon Mountains.

Genesis 10:24

- Shelah is not well-known, but it might be short for Methushelah (compare [38:5](#), [11](#)).
- Eber was an ancestor of Abram the Hebrew ([11:10–26](#)). His name is the source of the word *Hebrew* (see [14:13](#); [39:14](#); [40:15](#); [41:12](#); [Exodus 2:11](#); [3:18](#)).

Genesis 10:25

- *Peleg* means "division," which refers to the dividing of people into different language groups after the tower of Babel event ([11:1–9](#)). Peleg's descendants included Abram (see [11:16–26](#)).
- Joktan was the ancestor of the southern Arabian tribes. The Ishmaelite tribes lived in northern Arabia (see [25:13–16](#)).

Genesis 10:26–29

- Almodad was an ancestor, region, or tribe in what is now Yemen.
- Sheleph was a tribe in Yemen.
- Hazarmaveth had a link to Hadramaut in southern Arabia.
- Jerah is unknown but might have a connection to Mount Barach.
- Hadoram was an Arabian tribe.
- Uzal was Sana'a, an ancient capital of Yemen before Islam.
- Diklah was a southern Arabian oasis in Mina.
- Obal was between Hodeida and Sana'a in southwest Arabia.
- Abimael was a Sabaean. These were an ancient people of southern Arabia.
- Sheba was in southern Arabia (see [10:7](#)).
- Ophir was a region in southern Arabia between Sheba and Havilah. It was famous for gold ([Isaiah 13:12](#)).
- *Havilah*: See [10:7](#).
- Jobab might have been Jobebitai in southern Arabia.

Genesis 10:26–32

Shem had 14 sons through Eber and Joktan. The tower of Babel story connects Joktan to God's judgment there ([11:1–9](#)) and connects Peleg to Abram ([11:27–12:1](#)).

Genesis 10:30

- Mesha was a region in northern Arabia, located south of Hadramaut.
- Sephar is the same as Isfar, which is south of Hadramaut in Yemen.

Genesis 11:1

Now: The events in [11:1–9](#) caused the nations to scatter, as shown in the family histories of [10:2–30](#). Although these events happened in a different order than they are written, the author arranged them this way to help explain things about God's actions and plans more clearly (see study note on [10:1–11:9](#)).

Genesis 11:1–9

The story of the unfinished tower continues themes from the Table of Nations (chapter [10](#)). These themes include language and human unity. The builders wanted independence from God, which recalls the rebellion in the garden of Eden (chapter [3](#)). This also helps show why Abram's faithful response to God is needed (chapter [12](#)) during a time of disorder among the nations.

The scattering of the nations also points forward to later warnings given to Israel. God warned that idolatry would lead to their being scattered, and that their cities would be ruined (see [Leviticus 26:33](#); [Numbers 10:35](#); [Deuteronomy 4:27](#); [28:64](#); [30:3](#)).

In the timeline of Genesis, this goes back to an earlier time. It explains how the nations spread out during the time of Peleg (see [Genesis 10:25](#)).

Genesis 11:2

- *journeyed eastward*: See study note on [3:24](#).
- Shinar (Babylonia) was in southern Mesopotamia, where Nimrod later built his empire and cities (see [10:10](#); [Isaiah 11:11](#); [Daniel 1:2](#); [Zechariah 5:11](#)).

Genesis 11:3

- Stone was plentiful in Canaan. In Mesopotamia, stone was rare, so they developed brick-making technology.
- They made *tar* from bitumen, a natural, waterproof asphalt similar to cement (see [6:14](#); [Exodus 2:3](#)).

Genesis 11:4

- Far from the original garden ([2:15](#)), the first cities of Genesis represent arrogance ([4:17](#)), tyranny ([10:8–12](#)), and evil ([18:20–21](#)). The city on the Babylonian plain attracted human pride and idol worship.
- *a tower that reaches to the heavens*: This was probably a temple-tower (a ziggurat). In ancient Babylonian cities, people considered ziggurats to be sacred mountains where gods came down to earth. Jacob's dream in [28:12](#) might indicate this idea.
- *that we may make a name for ourselves*: The tower builders wanted fame through their idol-worshipping ambition. God promised to make Abram famous because of his humble obedience ([12:2](#)).

Genesis 11:5

came down: The tower was a human attempt to reach up to God's realm (God's dwelling place; see [Deuteronomy 26:15](#); [Psalms 2:4](#); [103:19](#); [115:16](#)). This effort was foolish. God had to "come down" to see what they were building, which shows how small and weak their work really was.

Genesis 11:6

If no one stopped them, the tower builders would become united and ambitious. This would allow human evil to grow in ways that cannot be imagined.

Genesis 11:7

- *Come, let Us go down*: God speaks to his angelic court (see [1:26](#); [3:22](#); and study notes).
- *will not understand one another's speech*: When people could no longer understand one another, their shared plan to do wrong would stop. Later, at Pentecost, God allowed people to understand many languages. This showed a partial reversal (undoing) of what happened at Babel ([Acts 2:5–13](#); see [Zephaniah 3:9](#)).

Genesis 11:8

the LORD scattered them: In a similar way, God punished Adam and Eve for trying to become independent of his rule. God punished Cain for murder. Their punishments involved exile and scattering ([3:23](#); [4:12](#), [14](#); [9:19](#); [10:5](#), [25](#), [32](#)).

Genesis 11:9

- *Babel*: The Babylonians saw their city as the home or gateway of the gods. The double meaning at the end of this story shows Babylon's spiritual confusion. Babylon became important under Nimrod ([10:10](#)) and later in biblical history (see [2 Kings 25:1–30](#)). Its role as a center of pride and idol worship makes it a symbol for the forces opposed to God in the end times (for example, [Revelation 14:8](#); [16:19](#); [18:2](#)).
- The tower builders gathered together in one place to reach up into God's realm (God's dwelling place; [Genesis 11:3–4](#)). God came down and scattered them across the earth. In this way, he stopped their idolatrous ambition (their desire to act against him and seek their own glory).

Genesis 11:10

- This account of Shem continues from [10:21–32](#), focusing on the family line leading to Abram. Only Abram and Israel inherit Shem's God (see [9:26–27](#); [Deuteronomy 32:8–9](#)). The Babel story strongly rejects the culture that God called Abram to abandon ([Genesis 12:1](#); [24:6–7](#)). Together with the account of Terah's descendants ([11:27–32](#)), this account of Shem's line forms a bridge from the universal history of chapters [1–11](#) to Israel's national history that begins in chapter [12](#).
Abram was part of the small group that remained faithful after the confusion at Babel. God chose Abram as an act of grace. Through Abram, God began a new plan. God's purpose was to bless the whole world, even though the nations had been divided and scattered at Babel ([12:3](#)).
- *the father of* (or *the ancestor of*): Hebrew family records (genealogies, or lists of ancestors) do not always include every generation.

Genesis 11:18

Peleg: See the study note on 10:25.

Genesis 11:27

- *Nahor* was Laban's grandfather. Laban's daughters later married Jacob (chapters [29–31](#)).
- *Lot*: See the "Lot" Profile.

Genesis 11:27–32

This brief section provides a complete summary of Terah's life and accounts for his other sons and their marriages. It also introduces Lot, Abram's nephew, who later played an important role. The

ancestors, including Terah and his family, were idolatrous, worshiping other gods in Mesopotamia ([Joshua 24:2](#)).

Genesis 11:27–25:11

This is the account: The Hebrew word is *toledoth* (a term that introduces a new section or family history; see study note on 2:4). This section tells about Terah's family.

The details in [11:28–25:11](#) are about the family line that comes from Terah. The focus is on Abraham and God's covenant with him.

The passage also highlights Isaac, the promised child. Isaac continued the family line and carried God's blessing to the next generation.

Genesis 11:28

- Abram received his calling from God in Ur of the Chaldeans ([15:7](#); [Acts 7:2–4](#)). This was the main city of Sumer in Mesopotamia near the Persian Gulf. The family had moved there perhaps generations before this calling. Their original home ("country," [Genesis 12:1](#)) was probably near Haran, in the region of Shem's descendants ([11:10–26](#)). They settled in Haran after leaving Ur ([11:31](#)). Later, they were described as Arameans ([Deuteronomy 26:5](#)).
- *native land:* The same Hebrew phrase appears in [12:1](#) ("country"), indicating that Ur, not Haran, was where Abram received his calling (see [15:7](#); [Nehemiah 9:7](#); [Acts 7:2](#)).

Genesis 11:29

- *Sarai* means "princess" in Hebrew. The text does not mention Sarai's parents. This might have been to create suspense in the story of Abimelech. This story reveals her as Abram's half-sister ([20:9–12](#)). Later, the law forbade such marriages ([Leviticus 18:9](#); [20:17](#); [Deuteronomy 27:22](#)).
- Nahor's wife was Milcah, who was the daughter of Haran and Nahor's niece (see [Genesis 11:29](#)). Her son Bethuel was Rebekah's father. Rebekah became the wife of Abram's son Isaac ([24:10, 15, 24](#)). The name *Milcah* is related to the Hebrew word for "queen." In Akkadian, it is a title for the goddess Ishtar, the daughter of the moon god. Terah's name is related to the Hebrew word for "moon." His family probably worshiped Sin, the moon god (see [Joshua 24:14](#)).

Genesis 11:30

Sarai, Rebekah, and Rachel could not have children at first ([25:21](#); [29:31](#)). Sarai's case especially shows the tension between what people could see and what God had promised. God had promised to make Abram into a great nation ([12:2](#)).

Israel began through women who could not bear children. This shows that Israel existed because of God's power and choice. God gave children to women who were barren (unable to have children), as these passages also show (see also [1 Samuel 1:2; 2:5](#); [Psalm 113:9](#); [Isaiah 54:1](#)).

Genesis 11:31

- *Terah took:* Abram left Ur because God called him (see study note on 11:28). Yet, the story relates from Terah's viewpoint, reflecting the ancient Near Eastern culture where the oldest male led the family. This respect for elders is probably why Abram did not go to Canaan alone at that time (see [Acts 7:2-4](#)).
- Haran was 885 kilometers (550 miles) northwest of Ur, near the Syrian-Turkish border. Despite the similar name, there is no connection to Terah's son Haran, who died in Ur ([11:28](#)).
- *Haran* means "caravan." It was a major trade center where ancient trade routes met.
- Haran was also famous for moon worship, which Terah's family probably practiced (see study note on 11:29).

Genesis 12:1

Abram knew that he should leave, but he did not know where he was going. Obedience required faith.

Genesis 12:1-3

These verses are structured around two commands to Abram: *Leave* and *be a blessing* (see study note on 12:2). Each command is followed by three promises conditioned upon obedience.

Genesis 12:1-9

- Through Abram's faith and family, God started to restore the blessing. God called Abram from a pagan world to start a new nation. His promises to Abram later became a covenant (chapter [15](#)).
- God's calling of Abram later helped convince the Israelites to leave Egypt and go to the land God promised to Abram. It also reminded the Babylonian exiles of their need to return to their own land (for example, [Isaiah 51](#)).

Genesis 12:2

- *make your name great:* Abram gained the fame that the builders of the tower of Babel wanted for themselves (see [11:4](#) and study note).
- *so that you will be a blessing:* This statement is a command and a promise in Hebrew. It depends on Abram obeying God's command ([12:1-3](#)): "Go ... so that you will be a blessing. I will bless those who bless you and curse those who curse you."

Genesis 12:3

- Because Abram obeyed the command to be a blessing ([12:2](#)), God gave him three more promises.
- *those who curse you*: People who ignored Abram and his covenant were rejecting God's choice and plan.
- *all the families on earth will be blessed*: By faith, they could join the covenant God was making with Abram. The blessing spread worldwide through Abraham, Israel, the covenants, the prophets, Scripture, and the Messiah ([Galatians 3:8, 16](#); compare [Romans 9:4–5](#)).

Genesis 12:4

Abram was middle-aged, settled, prosperous, aristocratic, and polytheistic (see study note on 11:27–32). When the Lord spoke to him ([12:1–3](#)), he obediently left his old ways in Ur to follow God's plan. Since Abram responded in faith, God's promises ([12:2–3](#)) could be confirmed in a binding covenant ([15:8–21](#)).

Genesis 12:4–9

Abram's obedience to God's call corresponded to God's commands (see study note on 12:1–3). He journeyed to Canaan ([12:4–6](#)) and became a blessing ([12:5–9](#)).

Genesis 12:5

The people (Hebrew *hannepesh*, “the lives”) he had taken into his household were probably converts; Abram first became a blessing by influencing people in his household to join him in following the Lord.

Genesis 12:6–7

The oak of Moreh was apparently a Canaanite shrine; fertile groves of trees were sacred to the Canaanites (cp. [Isa 1:29](#)), and *Moreh* means

“teacher.” Abram proclaimed (Luther: “preached”) the Lord's name beside a pagan place of worship and instruction ([Gen 12:8](#)). • Abram continued to be a blessing when he built an altar to worship God at Shechem and east of Bethel ([12:8](#)).

Genesis 12:7

- *the LORD appeared to Abram* at Shechem ([12:6](#)) to confirm that this was the promised land. Israel was meant to live in this land, but they needed faith to share in God's promises (compare [Numbers 14](#); [Joshua 1:6–9](#)).
- *to your offspring*: Abram did not own the land yet. He lived there as a temporary settler.

Genesis 12:8

he worshiped the Lord (literally *he made proclamation of the Lord by name*): Proclaiming the name (identity and character) of the Lord is central to worship and witness (cp. [4:26](#); see [Exod 34:5–7](#)). Abram had to distinguish his sacrificial worship from that of the pagan Canaanites.

Genesis 12:8–9

Abram had to keep moving camp because the Canaanites had the fertile land.

Genesis 12:10

The Nile River supplied plenty of water for crops, so Egypt was usually the last area to experience famine.

Genesis 12:10–13

Abram's scheme was rooted in fear that jeopardized his family and God's promises. Abram was not walking by faith when he went to Egypt. He stopped building altars and his deceptiveness took center stage. Deception would plague his family throughout Genesis ([26:1–11](#); [27:1–29](#); [29:15–30](#);

[30:34–36](#); [31:6–11](#); [37:18–35](#); [39:7–20](#)). • Abram's plan was probably based on a social custom whereby a brother arranged the marriage of his sister (cp. [24:29–61](#)). Abram may have thought that any potential suitor would have to deal with him, giving him time to leave with Sarai. He did not count on Pharaoh's acting without negotiation ([12:14–16](#)).

Genesis 12:10–20

This episode shows that God would not allow Abram to jeopardize his promises. Just after Abram's obedience to the call, a famine tested his weak faith. God delivered him and his family, even though Abram foolishly used deception rather than trusting in God to preserve him in Egypt. • This story deliberately parallels Israel's later bondage in Egypt. Because of a famine ([Gen 12:10](#) // [Gen 47:13](#)), Abram/Israel went to Egypt ([Gen 12:10](#) // [Gen 47:27](#)); there was an attempt to kill the males and save the females ([Gen 12:12](#) // [Exod 1:22](#)); God plagued Egypt ([Gen 12:17](#) // [Exod 7:14–11:10](#)); Abram/Israel plundered Egypt ([Gen 12:16](#) // [Exod 12:35–36](#)); they were expelled (Hebrew *shalakh*, "send"; [Gen 12:19–20](#) // [Exod 12:31–33](#)) and ascended to the Negev ([Gen 13:1](#) // [Num 13:17, 22](#)). Israel was to believe that God would deliver them from bondage in Egypt through the plagues because their ancestor had already been rescued from bondage in Egypt.

Genesis 12:13

tell them you are my sister: This request occurs three times in Genesis (see also [20:2](#); [26:7](#)). The text explains that this was Abram's usual strategy ([20:13](#)), and his son did likewise. This first occasion was outside the land, the second (ch [20](#)) within, showing that God protected his promise in both regions.

Genesis 12:14–15

Sarai was 65 years old, but she lived to be 127; she was like a modern childless woman of about 35. She and Abram came from a noble family (see study note on 11:29), so she was regal in her person and dress. Pharaoh was attracted by her physical appearance and her political assets.

Genesis 12:14–16

Abram was bound by the king's gift to an unwanted agreement about Sarai that he could not prevent. His scheme had resulted in a terrible bind that endangered him, Sarai, and the promise. • Abram appeared to prosper from his deception, but the new possessions also caused crises. Abram and Lot had to separate (ch [13](#)), and Hagar, an Egyptian maiden, became the mother of the Ishmaelites, perennial enemies of Israel (ch [16](#)).

Genesis 12:15

Pharaoh was a title, not a personal name ([37:36](#); [Exod 1:15](#)).

Genesis 12:17–19

God's intervention rescued Sarai and preserved the marriage to fulfill the covenant promise. Sarai's restoration to Abram came with a rebuke from Pharaoh on God's behalf ([12:18–19](#)).

Genesis 12:20

No answer to Pharaoh's questions ([12:18–19](#)) was needed, because the rebuke was followed by expulsion. Pharaoh's command paralleled God's command to Abram ([12:1](#)), but Pharaoh's demand brought shame and disgrace. God was faithful in preserving his promise.

Genesis 13:1–7

This story is set in conflict amid God's blessings. In the opening verses, Abram returns to a place where he had built an altar. Previous events are emphasized as Abram's return to the land is described ([13:3–4](#)); Abram renewed his worship and again proclaimed the Lord's name (cp. [12:8](#)).

Genesis 13:2

Abram already had powerful resources ([12:5](#)). His time in Egypt increased his wealth and power ([12:16](#)).

Genesis 13:5-7

Lot was also wealthy, with flocks and herds. Tents figure prominently in Lot's story ([13:12](#)). • The Canaanites and Perizzites (see [34:30](#); [Deut 7:1](#); [Judg 1:4](#); [3:5](#)) held the well-watered land; the quarrel between Abram's and Lot's herdsmen left Abram more vulnerable to attack.

Genesis 13:8

Abram was concerned that there be no conflict (Hebrew *meribah*) between them, as they were close relatives (literally *brothers*). Moses later reproved Israel over the incident in the wilderness at Meribah ([Exod 17:1-7](#); [Num 20:1-13](#)) and instructed them on exercising faith in such situations. Meribah thereafter became a watchword for testing and striving with the Lord in unbelief (see [Ps 95](#)).

Genesis 13:8-13

Abram, to whom the land was promised, might have told Lot to find his own place. Abram's generosity was an act of faith; he knew that even if he gave the whole land away, God would still give it to him and his descendants. Abram did not have to cling to things, whereas Lot's choices were self-seeking.

Genesis 13:10

What appealed to Lot would be short-lived. In the garden of the Lord, Adam and Eve succumbed to their craving for what they saw; Israel was later enslaved in Egypt. Sodom and Gomorrah are reminders of putting intense desires ahead of obedience to God ([3:5-6](#); see [1 Jn 2:16](#)). • Zoar was a small town in the plain to which Lot and his daughters later fled ([19:18-22](#)); it was previously called Bela ([14:2](#)).

Genesis 13:11

Lot's choice was totally selfish, without concern for Abram or faith in the Lord. • The region called the whole Jordan Valley (literally *the circle of the Jordan*) is believed to have been near the south end of the Dead Sea, based on descriptions in ancient

records that locate cities of the Plain. This area is now very desolate.

Genesis 13:11-18

The narrator makes many contrasts between Lot and Abram.

Genesis 13:13

This suggests that Lot would not oppose Sodom's influence because he was focusing on his own interests.

Genesis 13:14-17

Abram could give Lot the choice land because he believed in God's promise. Abram waited for God to give him the land. Lot just took what he wanted.

Genesis 13:18

Hebron was an Anakite city ([Num 13:22](#)) originally called Kiriath-arba ("city of Arba"), located in forested highlands just north of the Negev ([Gen 12:9](#); [Josh 17:15](#)). Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob all settled there ([Gen 18:1](#); [35:27](#); [37:14](#)), and Sarah, Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, and Leah were buried there ([23:19](#); [35:27-29](#); [49:29-32](#); [50:13](#)). • Mamre was an Amorite ([14:13](#); [15:16](#)).

Genesis 14:1

Tidal apparently ruled several city-states. The text calls his people *Goiim*, which means "nations" in Hebrew.

Genesis 14:1-2

Archaeology has not identified these kings, but similar names from antiquity corroborate the report's accuracy. The Mesopotamian kings were confederates under a suzerain, apparently Amraphel, who is mentioned first.

Genesis 14:1–16

In this typical ancient political conflict, powerful kings allied to control smaller dependent states.

Genesis 14:4

King Kedorlaomer apparently defeated the Siddim Valley kings at an earlier time and put them under tribute for asphalt, olive oil, and copper. In the thirteenth year they refused to send it; in the fourteenth year ([14:5](#)), the invaders returned to subjugate them again.

Genesis 14:4–5

This was Chedorlaomer's war. Under the feudal system of tribal affiliations, those in covenant with him had to fight. It was also Abram's battle to rescue Lot, and those under treaty with him had to accompany him.

Genesis 14:5–8

The invaders came down the King's Highway on the east side of the Jordan Valley to the Gulf of Aqaba, then circled back to the valley of the Dead Sea.

Genesis 14:8–12

The five cities of the plain were close together at the south end of the Dead Sea. The Mesopotamian kings defeated the frail uprising, looted the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah, and carried off Lot with the other captives.

Genesis 14:13

The word Hebrew first occurs here in the Bible. It is not equivalent to the later term *Habiru* from Egyptian texts; the *Habiru* were mercenaries that roamed the land in the era of the judges. • Mamre: See study note on 13:18. • relatives: Or *allies*; literally *brothers*.

Genesis 14:14

Abram . . . mobilized the 318 trained men who had been born into his household: Abram was a formidable force, an outworking of God's promise to make him great ([12:2–3](#)). • Dan was a city about 150 miles north of Abram's home in Hebron, then named Laish or Leshem (see [Josh 19:47](#) and study note; [Judg 18:29](#)). Dan, whose descendants migrated north in the days of the judges ([Judg 18:1–29](#)), had not yet been born ([Gen 30:6](#)). An editor apparently updated the text so that later readers could identify this city.

Genesis 14:14–16

God could give his people victory over any forces invading the Promised Land. Faithfulness to God was the prerequisite for victory. God promises to bless his people and give them victory over the world. He uses those who respond to his call and can skillfully use weapons of war (cp. [Eph 4:8; 6:10–19](#)).

Genesis 14:15

Damascus was 64 kilometers (40 miles) north of Dan. Hobah was 97 kilometers (about 60 miles) north of Damascus.

Genesis 14:17

The Valley of Shaveh, or King's Valley, was probably the Kidron Valley (see [2 Samuel 18:18](#)).

Genesis 14:18

Melchizedek means "king of righteousness," suggesting that he was a righteous servant of God. He was probably a Jebusite priest and king; later authors regarded him as a type of Christ ([Ps 110:4; Heb 7:1–19](#)). • Salem is the ancient name of Jerusalem (cp. [Ps 76:2](#)).

Genesis 14:19–20

By paying a tithe (a tenth) to Melchizedek, Abram acknowledged Melchizedek as a spiritual superior

(see [Heb 7:4](#)) and affirmed that God had given him victory.

Genesis 14:21–24

Abram knew that accepting the offer of the king of Sodom (see study note on 14:1–2) could make him his ally or subject, as Lot had been. This would jeopardize the fulfillment of God’s promises. Faith looks beyond the riches of the world to the greater blessings that God has in store.

Genesis 14:22

In the words of this oath, Abram may have been clarifying that his God, the Lord (Yahweh), was the God Most High that Melchizedek invoked. Perhaps Melchizedek had never heard the name Yahweh.

Genesis 15:1

Do not be afraid: Abram lacked a son to be his heir. The Lord addressed Abram’s anxiety about the future with comforting words. • I will protect you (literally *I will be your shield*): The Hebrew word for “shield” (*magen*) is from the same root as Melchizedek’s word *defeated* ([14:20](#)). The Lord who had defeated Abram’s enemies would continue to protect him. • your reward will be great: The promise of offspring ([12:2–3](#); cp. [Ps 127:3](#)) was still unfulfilled.

Genesis 15:1–21

God made a covenant (a special agreement) with Abram. In this covenant, God confirmed the promises he had made earlier when he summoned Abram to leave his country ([12:1–3](#)). Abram’s descendants would experience a long period of slavery before God made these promises come true.

Genesis 15:2–3

Using a wordplay, Abram expressed his concern that Eliezer of Damascus (Hebrew *dammeseq*), a man in Abram’s household, would be his heir (Hebrew *ben-mesheq*, “son of possession”), as was customary when there was no son.

Genesis 15:4–6

God affirmed that the promise was for Abram’s own offspring and showed him the stars as a promise of the vast number of descendants that he would have ([22:17](#); [26:4](#)). Paul quotes this promise in [Rom 4:18](#) to underscore the strength of Abram’s faith.

Genesis 15:6

And Abram believed: God made his covenant with a believer; the statement does not indicate when Abram came to faith. The Hebrew text does not link Abram’s belief with the promise of the stars; it just says parenthetically that Abram believed God. Abram already had faith; his departure from Ur was his first great act that demonstrated it (see [Heb 11:8–10](#)). • God counted him as righteous because of his faith: This central statement about Abram’s saving faith is quoted three times in the New Testament ([Rom 4:3](#); [Gal 3:6](#); [Jas 2:23](#)) to support the doctrine of righteousness before God by faith (see also [Rom 4:22–23](#)).

Genesis 15:7–21

With a solemn ceremony, God made a binding covenant with Abram that guaranteed the fulfillment of God’s promises to him.

Genesis 15:10

Obedying God’s instructions, Abram gathered three herd animals for the ceremony and cut them in half. Cutting the animals symbolized the oath, indicating that the covenant maker staked his own life on his word ([Jer 34:18](#)).

Genesis 15:11

birds of prey: These are ceremonially unclean birds that symbolize those who unjustly attack Abraham’s heirs ([15:13–14](#)).

Genesis 15:13

oppressed: The same word is used in [Exod 1:11–12](#). Egypt, like predatory birds ([Gen 15:11](#)), would try to destroy Israel and hinder the covenant's fulfillment. • Apparently 400 years is a round number (also [Acts 7:6](#); cp. [Exod 12:40](#); [Gal 3:17](#)). Using the chronology in the Hebrew text, the family moved to Egypt around 1876 BC, and the Exodus occurred around 1446 BC (though many scholars date the Exodus later, around 1270 BC; see Exodus Book Introduction, “The Date of the Exodus”).

Genesis 15:13–16

Not even 400 years of slavery could interfere with God's plan to fulfill the covenant.

Genesis 15:16

The reasons for Israel's bondage included God's justice. God would tolerate the sins of the Amorites until they fully deserved judgment. • do not yet warrant their destruction (literally *are not yet full*): To give the Promised Land to Israel, the Lord would dispossess the land's inhabitants in a way that satisfied his justice. The fulfillment of promises to Israel also brought retributive judgment on people of the land (though individuals were saved by faith; see [Josh 2:1–15](#); [6:23–25](#); [Heb 11:31](#); [Jas 2:25](#)). Until then, God would send the family to Egypt where Israel could become a great nation. Seeing all this in advance was terrifying ([Gen 15:12](#)), but it was comforting to know that nothing could interfere with God's plan.

Genesis 15:17–18

smoking firepot . . . flaming torch: Fire represented the Lord's cleansing, consuming zeal and unapproachable holiness (cp. [Isa 6:3–7](#)). The holy God made (literally *cut*) a unilateral covenant with Abram; its promises were absolutely sure because they did not depend on what Abram or his descendants might do.

Genesis 15:18–19

God specified the boundaries of the Promised Land. His clear message to Abram was that despite

prospects of death and suffering (enslavement), he and his descendants would eventually receive the promises, for God had sworn an oath (see [Heb 6:13–14](#)). Nothing can separate God's people from his love or the fulfillment of his plans (see [Rom 8:18–39](#); [2 Pet 1:3–4](#)).

Genesis 16:1–3

Abram and Sarai faced the tension of her being barren and beyond childbearing years. By custom, a barren woman could give her servant to her husband as a slave-wife; the child born to that union was considered the wife's child and could be adopted as the heir. Sarai's suggestion, unobjectionable by custom, set a problematic human plan in motion. God's promises would be fulfilled by faith.

Genesis 16:1–16

While waiting for their promised son to be born, Abram and Sarai attempted an alternate plan that was not in keeping with faith.

Genesis 16:4–6

Hagar might have thought Abram would favor her instead of Sarai (compare [Proverbs 30:21–23](#)).

Genesis 16:7

The angel of the Lord was the Lord himself ([16:13](#); [21:17](#); [22:11–12](#); [31:11–13](#); [48:16](#); [Exod 3:2](#); [32:34](#); [Judg 6:11](#), [16](#), [22](#); [13:22–23](#); [Zech 3:1–2](#)) but was also distinct from the Lord ([Gen 24:7](#); [2 Sam 24:16](#); [Zech 1:12](#)). The angel of the Lord was probably a *theophany* (a manifestation of God) or a *Christophany* (an appearance of the pre-incarnate Messiah; see [Gen 18:1–2](#); [19:1](#); [Num 22:22](#); [Judg 2:1–4](#); [5:23](#); [Zech 12:8](#)), speaking with the authority of the Lord himself.

Genesis 16:8–12

The angel's rhetorical questions encouraged Hagar to pour out her heart to God. When she did, God commanded her to return and submit ([16:9](#)), promising that her son would have innumerable

descendants. The angel of the Lord never referred to Hagar as Abram's wife, only as Sarai's servant. She would have Abram's child, but Ishmael was not central to God's covenant with Abram.

Genesis 16:10–12

Hagar's son would become the father of a great but wild and hostile nation living in the Arabian Desert as perennial enemies of Israel (cp. [25:18](#)). God blessed Ishmael as Abram's descendant, but not as the line chosen to carry on the covenant. That blessing was reserved for Abram's chosen heir.

Genesis 16:11

Names in Genesis often capture the message of a passage and aid the remembrance of the events and their significance in the history of the faith. The name Ishmael, which means "God hears," commemorates that the Lord . . . heard Hagar's cry of distress (see also study note on 16:14–15). This name would have greatly comforted Hagar; God listened to her prayers and acknowledged her complaint.

Genesis 16:13

Hagar responded to God's messages by faith, in her words and in her obedience. • the God who sees me: God knew Hagar's plight and watched over her.

Genesis 16:14–15

The names Beer-lahai-roi, which means "well of the Living One who sees me," and Ishmael (see [16:11](#)) were a message and a rebuke for Abram and Sarai. God sees affliction and hears the cries of those in need. Sarai and Abram should have prayed rather than taking the fulfillment of the promise into their own hands by following social custom (cp. [25:21](#)). Giving children to the barren woman is God's work ([Ps 113:9](#); cp. [1 Sam 1:1–28](#); [Luke 1:1–25](#)); impossible difficulties cannot be resolved by human intervention. The Lord hears the afflicted, sees them in their need, and will miraculously provide for them.

Genesis 17:1

El-Shaddai: This name for God emphasizes his power (see also [28:3](#); [35:11](#); [43:14](#); [48:3](#); [49:25](#)). • Serve me faithfully and live a blameless life: Being a blessing to the nations required obedience from Abram; his conduct would be guided by Almighty God.

Genesis 17:1–27

God now gave the family signs that the promises would be fulfilled. He changed Abram's name to Abraham ([17:1–8](#)), instituted the rite of circumcision as the sign of the covenant ([17:9–14](#), [23–27](#)), and changed Sarai's name to Sarah ([17:15–22](#)).

Genesis 17:4–5

God guaranteed his promise by changing Abram's name. Abram referred to his noble lineage, as Terah was the "exalted father" ([11:27](#)). His new name, Abraham (Hebrew 'ab hamon) was a wordplay on the promise of his own progeny (see also [John 8:31–59](#); [Rom 4:16–17](#); [Gal 3:7](#), [15–19](#), [29](#)). Whenever the new name was used, he and his household would remember that a multitude of nations would issue from him.

Genesis 17:6

kings will be among them! This is the first indication that Israel would become a monarchy (see also [35:11](#); [36:31](#); [Num 24:7](#); [Deut 17:14–18](#); [28:36](#)).

Genesis 17:7–8

The land of Canaan was to be an everlasting possession for the descendants of Abraham; the Lord would be their God forever (see [Jer 31:31–40](#); [Zech 8:8](#); [Luke 1:68–79](#); [Rev 21:1–4](#)).

Genesis 17:9–14

God gave circumcision as a confirming sign that reminded all households of loyalty to the covenant.

Genesis 17:14

will be cut off. This punishment seems to have several applications. A person could be exiled from society or put to death by the community; most often it warned that a person might die prematurely as God cut him off from the land of the living (see [Exod 31:14](#); [Lev 7:20-27](#); [17:3-4](#); [20:17-18](#); [23:28-29](#); [Num 15:30-31](#); see also [Ps 31:22](#); [Ezek 21:4](#); [Rom 9:3](#); [11:22](#)). Failure to be circumcised was a serious violation (see [Exod 4:24-26](#); cp. [Gal 5:2-4](#)).

Genesis 17:15-16

Sarah: The new name, fitting for one who would be the mother of kings, was a milestone in Sarah's calling and brought attention to the promise.

Genesis 17:17-18

Abraham laughed (Hebrew *yitskhaq*) because the promise seemed unbelievable; he had begun to believe that his line would come through Ishmael. But Abraham and Sarah would have a son of their own.

Genesis 17:19

The name Isaac (Hebrew *yitskhaq*, "he laughs") would constantly recall Abraham's disbelieving laughter when he heard the promise. It was also a reminder of God's favor and his pleasure in the birth (cp. [21:6](#)).

Genesis 17:20-21

God would not abandon Ishmael. His family would prosper (see [25:13-16](#)). But the covenant promises were for Isaac.

Genesis 17:23-27

Having received God's word about Isaac, Abraham immediately complied with God's instructions. He implemented the rite of circumcision as an act of faith; it signified their participation in the covenant

(cp. [Rom 4:11-12](#); [Gal 5:2-6](#), [11](#); [6:15](#); [Phil 3:2-3](#); [Col 2:11-12](#); [1 Pet 3:21](#)).

Genesis 18:1-15

The Lord's visit to Abraham set the time for Isaac's birth. The three visitors were probably the Lord and two angels (see study note on 16:7). Abraham's peaceful and generous reception of the visitors contrasts sharply with the chaos and corruption of Sodom (ch [19](#)). Eating together was important in making or confirming covenants; when God was ready to fulfill the covenant promise, he came in person to share a meal with Abraham. Fellowship with God has always been signified by a communal meal (see [Exod 24:9-11](#); [Matt 26:17-30](#) // [Luke 22:7-38](#); [Acts 2:42](#); [1 Cor 11:20-34](#)).

Genesis 18:2-8

Abraham received his visitors as very important guests, perhaps realizing that they were messengers from God.

Genesis 18:3

My lord: The Hebrew text uses *'adonay*, which always refers to God. In Hebrew tradition, people said this word when they saw the letters of God's holy name ("Yahweh") in the text. The text here might use *'adonay* instead of the more common *'adoni* to show this was the angel of the Lord, meaning the Lord himself (see study note on 16:7). We do not know if Abraham knew who his visitors were at first. But by the end of the story, he knew he had been talking with God.

Genesis 18:9

The visitors asked about Sarah by name, even though no one had told them who she was.

Genesis 18:10

I will surely return: The Hebrew phrase is emphatic. The statement announced a certain promise and dramatic change.

Genesis 18:13–15

Sarah thought her disbelieving laughter was hidden, but God knows human hearts (see [Ps 69:5](#); [Prov 20:27](#); [Mark 4:22](#); [Luke 8:43–48](#); [Heb 4:13](#)), whether they stagger at the promises or step out in faith (see [Heb 11:11–12](#)).

Genesis 18:14

Is anything too hard for the Lord? The question is rhetorical. God is able to do marvelous things. Nothing is incredible to those in covenant fellowship with the Lord, because nothing is too difficult for him.

Genesis 18:16–33

God took Abraham into his confidence as his prophet ([18:16–21](#); see [20:7](#)); Abraham, in turn, interceded for Sodom ([18:23–32](#); see [Heb 7:23–26](#)). God is able to do whatever he chooses to do; this passage affirms that it will be just and right.

Genesis 18:17–19

Abraham was responsible for teaching his descendants righteousness and justice so that they might enjoy God's blessings. It was important for Abraham to know how God's righteousness was at work in judgment.

Genesis 18:20

The outcry: See [Ezekiel 16:49–50](#).

Genesis 18:20–21

The omniscient God was cautious in his judgment: He knew the sins of Sodom and Gomorrah, but this close scrutiny communicated God's justice in human terms—he would not destroy the people of the plain unless he was absolutely sure they were wicked.

Genesis 18:22–33

Abraham probably thought there were more righteous people in Sodom and Gomorrah than there were (see study note on 19:14). In his concern for them, he approached the Lord with a legal appeal based on God's justice. His prayer seems too bold at times, as though he were bargaining with God, but he approached God with genuine humility and reverence. He did not try to talk God into doing something against his will, but prayed for the well-being of others (contrast Lot's prayer, [19:18–23](#)). God is a righteous judge; righteousness exalts a nation ([Prov 14:34](#)), and righteous people help to preserve society (cp. [Matt 5:13](#)).

Genesis 19:1

The two angels also first appeared to Abraham as men ([18:2](#)). • Lot was no longer living in tents next to Sodom ([13:12](#))—he had become a citizen and leader in Sodom, sitting there at the entrance of the city. Community leaders (elders) usually congregated in the gates, where legal and business transactions were publicly finalized (cp. [23:18](#); [Job 29:7, 12–17](#)). As a righteous man ([2 Pet 2:7–8](#)), Lot tried to modify the townspeople's wickedness by giving advice on good living (cp. [Gen 19:9](#)). Although he denounced gross evil, Lot preferred Sodom's sumptuous lifestyle to life in the hills (cp. [13:10–11](#)), where there was clean living but no "good life." As long as the Lord left Lot and his family alone in Sodom, he lived comfortably there and kept his personal belief in God; but finally, he could not hold to both. Sodom would have destroyed Lot if the Lord had not destroyed Sodom. • This account showed Israel that God is the righteous judge of the whole earth ([18:25](#)) who will judge evildoers with justice and equity. In wicked societies, moral and ethical failures lead to social injustice.

Genesis 19:1–14

The two angels who were with the Lord at Mamre (cp. [18:2, 22](#)) visited Sodom reluctantly, knowing what kind of people lived there. Despite Lot's hospitality, they preferred lodging in the square to entering Lot's house.

Genesis 19:1-38

The Canaanites were an evil, corrupting people. God judged their morally bankrupt civilization and warned others against becoming like them. It was difficult to get Lot and his family out of Sodom; it was more difficult to get Sodom out of Lot and his family. This chapter helped later Israelites to understand the moral and spiritual threat of the peoples living in and around the Promised Land, such as the Canaanites and Lot's descendants, the Moabites and the Ammonites (see [Num 22-25](#); [Deut 23:3-6](#); [Josh 24:9](#); [Judg 10:7-9](#); [11:4-5](#); [1 Sam 10:27](#); [1 Kgs 11:1-3](#); [2 Kgs 24:2](#)).

Genesis 19:4-5

The evil actions of the men of the city were matched by the hypocrisy of Lot ([19:6-9](#)). The men acted in a wicked and violent way toward Lot's visitors. Lot tried to protect his guests. However, he offered his daughters to the crowd instead. This action showed serious moral failure.

Genesis 19:6-9

Lot opposed homosexuality and rape and rebuked their wicked plans, but he was hypocritically willing to sacrifice his daughters to fend off the townsmen's vice. Lot had originally pitched his tent next to Sodom; now Sodom controlled his life.

Genesis 19:9

The men of the city were enraged by Lot's attempts to curtail their wickedness. Lot had apparently not condemned them before, since they were amazed that he now judged them.

Genesis 19:14

Lot's warning words were not taken seriously because of his hypocrisy. It seemed that there would not be even ten righteous people in the city.

Genesis 19:15-23

- Lot escaped God's judgment because of God's grace, but Lot was still hesitant to leave Sodom. Israel would forever remember Lot as someone who hesitated and needed angels to pull him to safety. The Lord was merciful and spared Lot because of Abraham ([18:23](#); [19:29](#)).
- Today, people who follow God often feel pressure to copy the wrong ways that many people live. God asks his followers to live differently from people who do not follow him. This means Christians should choose actions and behaviors that show they belong to God ([1 John 2:15-17](#)). God will judge the corrupt systems of the world. This judgment will be even more severe than the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah ([Matthew 11:23-24](#)).

Genesis 19:18-22

Lot asked the angels for permission to live in the small town of Zoar (which means "little place") even after they saved him.

Genesis 19:23-25

Cp. [Luke 17:29](#). The eruption of Vesuvius and the destruction of Pompeii in AD 79, as well as recent natural disasters, show how quickly a thorough catastrophe like this could happen.

Genesis 19:26

looked back: The verb indicates prolonged, intense gazing toward the world she loved, not a curious glance ([15:5](#); [Exod 33:8](#); [Num 21:9](#); [1 Sam 2:32](#); cp. [Exod 3:6](#)). Lot's wife was too attached to Sodom to follow God's call of grace, so she was included in the judgment as she lingered on the valley slopes. Christ's return to judge the world will be as sudden and devastating as the destruction of Sodom ([Luke 17:32-37](#)). Those who crave the life of this wicked world will lose this world and the next.

Genesis 19:29

God listened to Abraham's plea (compare [18:23-32](#)). But Lot lost everything during the destruction of Sodom. His choice to live in the fertile land of Sodom eventually led him into a dangerous situation ([13:10-13](#)). After this, he could no longer remain in the land he had chosen.

Genesis 19:30-35

The character of Lot's daughters was formed by Sodom's culture more than by their father's heritage, so they had no qualms about having children by their drunk father (cp. [9:21-22](#)). They saw no other way to carry on their line.

Genesis 19:30-38

The poverty of the cave contrasts with the wealth Lot shared with Abram and the good life he lived in Sodom. Abraham would father a righteous nation ([17:1](#)), but Lot and his daughters gave birth to a new Sodom.

Genesis 19:36-38

The daughters' plan worked, and they each became pregnant by their own father. From these two incest-born sons came two perennial enemies of Israel, the nations of Moab and Ammon. Their grotesque wickedness was due in part to their origin. • Both daughters chose ambiguous names that hinted at their actions without raising the suspicions of those who did not know the stories.

Genesis 20:1

Gerar was near the coast in Philistine land, about twelve miles south of Gaza and fifty miles southwest of Hebron.

Genesis 20:1-18

This second "sister story" in Genesis (cp. [12:10-20](#)) occurred shortly before Sarah became pregnant with Isaac (ch [21](#)). On both occasions, God

protected Abraham and Sarah's marriage in purity for the sake of the covenant promises. Participation in God's plan requires separation from worldly corruption. • This story took place in the Promised Land; it showed Israel how God intervened in people's lives to fulfill his plan, how God continued to protect them against threats from other tribes, and how God used his chosen people to mediate his relationship with the nations. • God's preventing the destruction of Abraham's marriage by adultery reminded the Israelites to keep their marriages morally and racially pure ([Ezra 9:1-4](#); [Neh 13:23-27](#); [Mal 2:10-17](#)); they should not allow any opportunity for temptation ([Exod 20:14, 17](#); [Lev 20:10](#); [21:13-15](#)). Adultery would eventually destroy the covenant and the covenant people.

Genesis 20:2

Abraham told the same lie to Abimelech that he had told to Pharaoh ([12:13](#)); Isaac would later do the same ([26:1-11](#)), probably having learned this tactic from his father. • Abimelech (literally *my father the king*) was probably a title like "Pharaoh" ([37:36](#); [Exod 1:15](#)), not a proper name (see study note on Gen 26:1).

Genesis 20:3

that night God came . . . in a dream: God urgently intervened to stop Abimelech from violating Sarah's purity shortly before God's promise was fulfilled ([18:10](#); [21:1-3](#)).

Genesis 20:3-7

God gave Abimelech a stern warning against committing adultery; it was a capital offense (cp. [Exod 20:14](#)), viewed throughout the ancient Near East as a "great sin" ([Gen 20:9](#)).

Genesis 20:4-5

Abimelech was innocent ([20:6](#)); his conscience was clear. Nonetheless, he was about to commit adultery, and ignorance does not excuse guilt ([Lev 4:13-14](#)). • will you destroy an innocent nation? Abimelech's appeal to God echoes Abraham's earlier words (cp. [18:23-32](#)) and rebukes Abraham's lack of faith on this occasion.

Genesis 20:6

Because Abimelech acted with a clear conscience, God kept him from sinning. God will graciously help those who try to do what is right. When people act with reverence toward God, God gives them more revelation and draws them into more specific faith (see [Acts 10](#)).

Genesis 20:7

Abraham's prayer saved the king's life and restored his family ([20:17-18](#)). Abimelech learned that Abraham's God was sovereign (meaning God has complete power and authority over everything). Abraham, as God's prophet, received God's messages and would pray for others (see [Numbers 12:13](#); [Deuteronomy 9:20](#)). This was true even if he did not always act like a prophet.

Genesis 20:8-10

Abraham had earned rebukes from Abimelech and from God (cp. [12:17-19](#)). Abimelech was angry that Abraham's deception had made him guilty of this great sin (see study note on 20:3-7). He knew that taking a married woman into his harem was wrong.

Genesis 20:11-13

Abraham's duplicity was not a momentary loss of faith. Despite the rebuke he received in Egypt, he practiced this strategy wherever he went (cp. [12:12-13](#)). Living by faith requires perseverance.

Genesis 20:14-16

Abimelech showed he was an honorable person by making things right (see study note on 20:4-5). He made things right by letting Abraham live in the area. He also gave him slaves, livestock (compare [21:27](#)), and 1,000 pieces of silver to make up for any wrong done to Sarah.

Genesis 20:17-18

The infertility suggests that some time had passed. God controls births; he opens and closes wombs ([25:21](#); [29:31](#); [30:2, 17, 22-23](#); [1 Sam 1:19-20](#); [Pss 113:9](#); [127:3](#); [Luke 1:13](#)).

Genesis 21:1-2

See [Genesis 18:10](#).

Genesis 21:3-4

Abraham responded in faith by naming his son Isaac and circumcising him according to the terms of the covenant (see [17:9-14](#)).

Genesis 21:5

Isaac was born 25 years after God first made the promise to Abraham (compare [12:4](#)).

Genesis 21:6

Sarah's wordplay on the name *Isaac* (Hebrew *yitskhaq*, "he laughs") shows that the laughter of unbelief when the promise was given ([18:12](#)) had changed to the laughter of joy at its fulfillment. Isaac's name could refer to the pleasure of God and of his parents at his birth. Sarah knew that everyone who heard about this would laugh with her and rejoice at the news.

Genesis 21:6-7

Sarah was filled with joy and praise for this amazing event. Only God could enable her to have a child.

Genesis 21:8-9

The feast for Isaac's weaning probably occurred when he was three and Ishmael was about seventeen years old ([16:16](#)). Sarah saw Ishmael making fun of her son, Isaac: The verb *metsakheq* ("making fun of") is related to the word for "laughter"; this theme ([21:6](#)) is given a sour twist by Ishmael's mockery.

Genesis 21:8–21

God used the incident of Ishmael's mocking Isaac to separate Ishmael and Hagar from the family and the child of promise. They would constantly threaten the promised descendant if they remained with the family.

Genesis 21:10

Earlier, Sarah mistreated Hagar and pressured her to flee ([16:6](#)); when Hagar's son mistreated Isaac, Sarah demanded that that slave woman and her son leave.

Genesis 21:11–13

Abraham was upset by Sarah's demand to oust Hagar and Ishmael. God told him to comply, assuring Abraham that Ishmael would also have a future as Abraham's offspring.

Genesis 21:14–21

God again rescued Hagar in the wilderness and guaranteed her future (cp. [16:7–14](#)). This passage is similar to ch [16](#), but the differences are great. Here, Hagar and Ishmael are rescued, but there is no commemorative naming. God's earlier promise to Hagar is reiterated, but this time Hagar is not told to return to Sarah. The repeated motifs on the two occasions confirm God's sovereign plan for Hagar and Ishmael. As Joseph later told Pharaoh, a twofold event demonstrated God's confirmation ([41:32](#)). God did not abandon Hagar and Ishmael but met them in their despair (cp. [16:7](#)), provided sustenance for them, and promised again that Ishmael would found a great nation ([21:13](#); cp. [16:11–12](#)). Paul uses this event in his letter to the Galatians to illustrate how God's people must relinquish all that threatens the fulfillment of God's promise ([Gal 4:21–31](#)).

Genesis 21:16

a bowshot away: This means the distance an arrow can travel when someone shoots a bow. The phrase

connects with Ishmael's future work as an archer ([21:20](#)).

Genesis 21:22–23

Abimelech pressed for the treaty so that Abraham would not cheat or deceive him. Abimelech knew that God was blessing Abraham even though Abraham was not entirely trustworthy ([20:9–10](#)). This sad contradiction made the treaty necessary. By contrast, God's faithful people are exhorted to speak the truth ([Eph 4:15, 25](#)), and Jesus warned against manipulating truth by the clever use of oaths ([Matt 5:37](#); [Jas 5:12](#)).

Genesis 21:22–34

This passage, at its climax, explains the name of Beersheba, Abraham's home ([21:31–34](#)). Beersheba reflected the covenant Abraham made with the residents of the land, which enabled him to dwell there in peace and prosperity. God's promise was coming to fruition ([12:7](#); [13:14–17](#); [15:7, 18–21](#); [17:8](#)).

Genesis 21:25

The motif of the well appears again (cp. [16:14](#); [21:19](#)). God provided water (a symbol of blessing) in the barren wilderness and later even brought water out of a rock for Israel ([Exod 15:22–27](#); [17:1–7](#); [Num 20:1–13](#)).

Genesis 21:27–31

Abraham's gifts to Abimelech (cp. [20:14](#)) secured his legal right to dwell peaceably in the land and to claim ownership of the well. Beersheba marked one more step toward the fulfillment of God's promise.

Genesis 21:32

The Philistines in Genesis are different from the Philistines of Judges through Kings. The earlier Philistines had Semitic names (e.g., Abimelech) and Canaanite culture. The later Philistines were apparently of Greek origin, with Greek customs and culture. They seem to have arrived in Canaan by sea

from the Aegean area around 1200 BC, during the time of the judges. Probably the name of the later Philistines was used here simply to describe the region's earlier inhabitants.

Genesis 21:33-34

A tamarisk tree requires a lot of water; this act indicated Abraham's security in his land rights and his faith that God would provide water in this desert area. He settled as a foreigner in the land, but dwelling under his tree was a sign of peaceful security (cp. [Zech 3:10](#)). • there he worshiped the Lord: See study note on 12:8.

Genesis 22:1

Some time later: Abraham had sent Ishmael away and settled in the land. Now God tested Abraham's faith by telling him to give up Isaac. This pushed the limits of logic and of Abraham's knowledge of God. Would he still obey when God seemed to be working against him and against the covenant? Would he cling to the boy or surrender him to God (see [Exod 13:11-13](#))? Did he believe that God would still keep his word and bless the world through Abraham's offspring?

Genesis 22:1-2

The greatest test in Abraham's life came after he had received the promised child following a long wait. He had grown to love Isaac and had enjoyed his presence for a number of years.

Genesis 22:2

Obedience to God's earlier call ([12:1-3](#)) was rewarded with great blessing; now Abraham had the opportunity to show even greater obedience. • Take your son . . . Isaac, whom you love so much: By this detailed description of Isaac, God reminded Abraham that the young man was his beloved son, and intensified his awareness of the cost of the sacrifice. • The name Moriah is explained by the Chronicler ([2 Chr 3:1](#)) as the place of the later Temple Mount in Jerusalem. • Go: By wording the command in this way, God helped Abraham to obey by recalling his former call (cp. [12:1-3](#)).

Genesis 22:3

Abraham's immediate, unquestioning obedience is almost as astounding as the test.

Genesis 22:5

We will worship there, and then we will come (or *We will worship there so that we may come back*): Abraham's amazing statement makes us wonder what he was thinking. Abraham knew that God had planned the future of the covenant around Isaac and that God wanted him to sacrifice Isaac. He could not reconcile these things in his mind; he could only do what God commanded him to do, and leave the future to God (cp. [Heb 11:17-19](#)).

Genesis 22:7-8

In response to Isaac's question, Abraham again showed his faith in the Lord, saying God will provide, although he was not sure how. This theme is central to the entire narrative.

Genesis 22:9-19

God's intervention was dramatic and instructive, confirming that he never intended for Isaac to be sacrificed. God later made it clear that child sacrifice was an abomination to him (see [Lev 18:21](#); [20:1-5](#); [Deut 18:10](#); [2 Kgs 16:2-3](#); [Isa 57:5](#); [Jer 32:35](#)). God wanted Abraham to sacrifice his own will and surrender it to God, and when he did, God intervened. This passage sets a pattern for all sacrificial worshipers. Like Abraham, true worshipers of God know that everything belongs to God—it all came from God and must therefore be acknowledged as God's possession. A true worshiper holds nothing back but obediently gives God what he asks, trusting that God will provide for all needs, and then discovering through experience that God always does so.

Genesis 22:11

The angel of the Lord stopped Abraham just as he was ready to plunge the knife into his son.

Genesis 22:12

Now God knew that Abraham would hold nothing back from him, that he did truly fear God. To fear the Lord means to reverence him as sovereign, trust him implicitly, and obey him without protest. The sacrifice that pleases God is a heart broken of self-will, surrendered to God ([Pss 40:6–8](#); [51:17](#)) and offering its best to God. • You have not withheld: Cp. [Rom 8:32](#), which uses the same verb (“spare”) as the Greek Old Testament uses here. If God gave us his dearest possession, he will surely provide all things for us.

Genesis 22:13

God provided a ram caught by its horns in a thicket for the sacrifice. God graciously allowed Abraham to substitute an animal sacrifice in place of Isaac. Later, all Israel would offer animals to the Lord, knowing that God’s grace had provided this substitution ([Exod 29:10](#); [Lev 4:15](#); [16:20–22](#)). In the New Testament, God substituted his only son for all humanity; the perfect sacrifice was made once and for all ([Isa 53:6](#), [10](#); [John 1:29](#); [Heb 7:27](#); [10:1–14](#); [1 Pet 3:18](#)).

Genesis 22:14

As with many patriarchal narratives, the heart of the matter is retained through commemorative naming. Yahweh-Yireh . . . means “the Lord will provide” (see [22:8](#)). That Abraham used the holy name in this act shows that the patriarchs knew the name Yahweh (cp. [Exod 6:2–3](#)) but not its full meaning (see study note on [Exod 6:2–3](#)). • To this day: Later Israelites understood this passage as a lesson about their own worship in Jerusalem. Abraham’s sacrifice took place on the mountain of the Lord, later the location of the Temple in Jerusalem (see study note on [22:2](#)). Three times a year, the people of Israel brought their best to God as a sacrifice, trusting that he would continue to provide for their needs.

Genesis 22:15–19

After the event, God again confirmed his covenant with Abraham (cp. [15:5](#), [18–21](#); [17:3–8](#)). His descendants would be numerous like the stars in the sky (cp. [26:4](#)), like the sand on the seashore (cp.

[32:12](#)), and like the dust of the earth (cp. [13:16](#); [28:14](#)).

Genesis 22:16

By Myself: There is no higher name by which God can swear ([Hebrews 6:13–17](#)).

Genesis 22:17

Joshua and Old Testament Israel partially fulfilled the promise that Abraham’s descendants would conquer the cities (literally *take possession of the gates*) of God’s enemies; this will be fulfilled fully by the church (cp. [Matt 16:18](#) and study note there).

Genesis 22:18–25.11

Abraham passed the test of faith; from this point, his task was to pass the covenant blessings to Isaac. He purchased a burial plot (ch [23](#)), acquired a wife for Isaac (ch [24](#)), and distributed his property ([25:1–11](#)).

Genesis 22:20

Milcah was the wife of Nahor. She was also his niece (see [11:29](#)).

Genesis 22:20–24

A report came from the east that Abraham’s brother Nahor (see [11:27–29](#)) was flourishing. The actors in the following narrative are introduced here.

Genesis 22:21

Uz may have been an ancestor of Job ([Job 1:1](#)).

Genesis 22:22–23

Bethuel was the youngest of Nahor’s eight sons by Milcah; he was the father of Rebekah, Isaac’s future

wife (see [24:15](#), [67](#)). Rebekah would follow Sarah as matriarch of the clan ([23:1–2](#)).

Genesis 23:1–2

- Sarah was 127 years old, and Isaac was 37 at this time (compare [17:17](#)).
- *Hebron*: See the study note on 13:18.

Genesis 23:1–20

When Sarah . . . died, Abraham acquired a parcel of land for a burial place. This transaction was the first sign that a permanent transition had taken place, as people were normally buried in their ancestral homeland (cp. [49:29–50:13](#)). In burying Sarah, Abraham detached from his just-mentioned ancestral home (where his relatives still lived, [22:20–24](#)); his future would be in Canaan, where his descendants would realize the promise.

Genesis 23:3–4

Abraham bargained with local Hittite elders for a piece of land for a burial site. These Hittites had apparently migrated south to Canaan from the great Hittite empire in eastern Asia Minor (modern Turkey; cp. [10:15](#)). • Abraham was a stranger and a foreigner among these people; his hope was in God's promise that he would eventually possess the land.

Genesis 23:5–6

my lord, you are an honored prince: Either Abraham was highly regarded by these people, or they were politely appealing to his generosity. • Choose the finest. . . . No one here will refuse: They were willing to accommodate his request, especially if they could legally obligate him to themselves ([23:11](#)).

Genesis 23:7–16

Abraham wanted to buy Ephron's cave at Machpelah, but Ephron wanted him to buy the entire field.

Genesis 23:9

This would be a permanent burial place for Abraham's family. The site was near Mamre ([23:19](#)), where Abraham lived (see [13:18](#); [14:13](#); [18:1](#)). Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, and Jacob and Leah would all be buried in this cave ([23:19](#); [25:9](#); [35:27–29](#); [49:29–31](#); [50:13](#)), their permanent place in the Promised Land.

Genesis 23:11

Ephron did not intend to give the cave to Abraham; Abraham was expected to "give" the full price in return. Ephron wanted to sell as much as he could to avoid responsibility for caring for the cave and to receive as high a price as possible.

Genesis 23:12–13

Abraham did not want the whole field, but he was willing to take it to get the cave.

Genesis 23:15

four hundred shekels of silver: This was a high price. Ephron's politeness was part of the usual bargaining process.

Genesis 23:16–20

Abraham paid the amount and finalized the transaction, avoiding indebtedness by accepting no gifts from the people (cp. [14:21–24](#)). The Hittite elders witnessed the transaction, ensuring that no one could challenge Abraham's full ownership of the land. The transaction took place at the city gate, where public legal and business dealings were conducted (cp. [19:1](#)). The land became Abraham's permanent possession, a down payment on God's promise to give him the land. Abraham knew that God's promise was not fulfilled ([12:7](#)) by this acquisition, so he planned for the future. By buying land for his dead, he declared that God's promises do not end with this life. This is the hope of all who die in faith.

Genesis 24:1–9

Confident in the Lord's promise, Abraham had his chief servant (probably Eliezer, [15:2](#)) swear to find a wife among Abraham's relatives in his homeland, some 450 miles away. Abraham was faithful to the covenant by preparing for Isaac's future.

Genesis 24:1–67

Isaac's marriage to Rebekah ensured that God's plan would continue into the next generation. God showed covenant faithfulness by working through his faithful people ([24:12](#), [27](#), [49](#)).

Genesis 24:2

Putting his hand under Abraham's thigh (cp. [47:29](#)), the servant took a very solemn oath, assuming the burden of completing this mission.

Genesis 24:3

Isaac knew how wicked and threatening the local Canaanite people were, so he maintained separation from them (cp. [26:34–35](#); [27:46](#); [28:8–9](#)).

Genesis 24:6–8

Under no circumstances was the servant to take Isaac from the Promised Land to seek a wife. Abraham ensured Isaac's safety and secured God's promises in the land of blessing.

Genesis 24:10

Aram-naharaim ("Aram of the two rivers") was also called *Paddan-aram* ("the field of Aram," cp. [25:20](#)). It was a two-week journey in each direction, so the servant had ten . . . camels for provisions and gifts ([24:22](#), [53](#)).

Genesis 24:10–27

The servant obeyed his master's instructions and trusted God to lead him to the right woman.

Genesis 24:10–60

The servant faithfully carried out the mission, and he glorified God in displaying faithful covenant love for Abraham's family by bringing all the details together. God sovereignly worked behind the scenes to accomplish his will through the circumstances of those acting responsibly in faith.

Genesis 24:14

Abraham's future daughter-in-law manifested hospitality and industry like Abraham's (see [18:1–8](#)). Ten thirsty camels could drink 250 gallons of water, so a woman who would work that hard for a stranger was certainly not lazy, but generous and hospitable.

Genesis 24:15–22

The servant received a precise, immediate answer to his prayer for guidance.

Genesis 24:22

The servant showed his gratitude by giving the girl expensive jewelry.

Genesis 24:23–24

God guided the servant to Abraham's relatives.

Genesis 24:25

Rebekah again showed kindness by offering lodging for the servant and food for his camels.

Genesis 24:26

The servant bowed to the ground and worshiped the Lord for his loyal love and faithfulness in guiding him to the exact family he sought.

Genesis 24:27

The Lord has shown unfailing love and faithfulness to my master: These words express this chapter's message (cp. [24:48](#)). Believers can trust the Lord's leading because he is sovereign in all things. He never leaves his people to their own resources in carrying out his covenant work.

Genesis 24:29–31

Laban . . . ran: He was not going to miss the chance to marry his sister off and receive more gifts. Laban's response to the servant's wealth foreshadows his avaricious character (see [24:54–56](#) and study note; [29:21–27](#); [30:27–36](#); [31:1–13](#)).

Genesis 24:33–48

The servant was not diverted from his mission; he insisted on telling his story before he would eat. He recounted his mission and acknowledged God's providence in directing him to Rebekah before attending to his personal needs. The servant wanted everyone to know that this was God's work, not a chance or humanly arranged meeting.

Genesis 24:48

The way that God directed this event from behind the scenes is different than in most of Genesis, but it is true to how the life of faith normally works. Faith, expressed in personal prayer and obedience, looks for evidence of God's working. Believers usually have to make wise choices and remain faithful to the covenant, trusting that God will guide them through the circumstances of life to accomplish his will.

Genesis 24:50–51

Following his testimony about God's guidance, the servant secured the family's blessing and permission to take Rebekah to his master's son Isaac.

Genesis 24:53

The servant gave expensive gifts to Rebekah, her mother, and her brother to conclude the arrangements.

Genesis 24:54–56

It was hard for Rebekah's family to let her go so suddenly, and Laban may have hoped to gain more wealth. However, the servant had sworn an oath and would not rest until it was completed. There was no reason for him to stay.

Genesis 24:57–58

Rebekah chose to leave at once to be with her new husband, which ended the disagreement. She accepted what seemed to be the Lord's clear leading.

In that culture, young women usually wanted to marry (not marrying brought great shame and hardship). Later stories about Laban help explain why Rebekah may have wanted to leave (compare [31:14–15](#)).

Rebekah showed faithful love to the servant, to Abraham's family, and to Isaac by going to become his wife.

Genesis 24:60

When Rebekah left, her family blessed her, hoping she would become the mother of millions. They said, *May your offspring possess the gates of their enemies*. Rebekah's marriage to Isaac was part of God's plan to bless "all the families of the earth" ([12:1–3](#)).

Genesis 24:62

Isaac lived in the Negev, in the southern part of Canaan.

Genesis 24:67

Isaac was 40 years old when he married Rebekah ([25:20](#)), so Abraham was 140 ([21:5](#)).

Genesis 25:1

The exact time when Abraham married Keturah is unknown. It was probably after Sarah's death, but this is not certain.

Genesis 25:1–11

Even though Abraham had sons with another wife, he protected Isaac's inheritance and blessing.

Genesis 25:2–4

The birth of these nations from Abraham partially fulfilled God's promise to him ([12:2](#); [17:4](#)).

Genesis 25:3

Sheba and Dedan: Compare [10:7](#). Abraham's descendants probably settled in these regions. They became known by these names, along with people from other family lines.

Genesis 25:5–6

Abraham loved all his sons, so before he died, he gave them gifts and sent them away as he had sent Ishmael ([21:8–14](#)). This made certain that Isaac remained his heir.

Genesis 25:7–8

Abraham's death is recorded before the births of Jacob and Esau, but he lived until they were fifteen years old ([25:19–26](#); cp. [21:5](#); [25:26](#)). This literary arrangement closes Abraham's story before focusing on Isaac's family.

Genesis 25:11

God's blessing transferred to Isaac; Abraham's other sons had been sent away. Isaac lived near Beer-lahai-roi—a special place where God had answered prayer ([16:14](#)) and where Isaac waited on the Lord ([24:62](#)).

Genesis 25:12–18

This record lists Ishmael's descendants before tracing Isaac's ([25:19–35:29](#)), which is in keeping with the literary arrangement of Genesis (see Genesis Book Introduction, "Summary").

Genesis 25:16

Ishmael's 12 sons fulfilled God's promise of blessings ([Genesis 17:20](#)).

Genesis 25:18

Havilah was a region in north-central Arabia. • Shur was a region between Beersheba and Egypt. • in open hostility toward all their relatives: The wording is close to that of [16:12](#).

Genesis 25:19–20

Isaac . . . married Rebekah: Isaac's marriage tied him and his family even more closely to Abraham's ancestors. Had he married a Canaanite, the covenant faith would have been imperiled by this corrupt, syncretistic people.

Genesis 25:19–26

Jacob's struggle to be greater than his brother began before the twins were born (see [Hosea 12:3](#)).

Genesis 25:19–35:29

This account of the family of Isaac, the chosen son of Abraham, mostly recounts Jacob's struggle for the blessing ([25:27–34](#); chapters [27–33](#)).

Genesis 25:21

For twenty years, Rebekah was barren (cp. [25:20, 26](#)), like Sarah (see [16:1](#)). This condition tested their faith (see study note on 16:1–3). How could they be childless when God promised that nations would issue from them? • Isaac pleaded with the Lord and the Lord answered Isaac's prayer. Isaac

apparently learned from his father's mistake and responded in faith.

Genesis 25:22

When the pregnancy was difficult, Rebekah went to ask the Lord about it, probably by visiting a prophet—perhaps Abraham ([20:7](#); see study note on 25:7–8).

Genesis 25:23

rivals: Jacob and Esau fought in the womb, and their descendants (Israel and Edom) fought continuously throughout their history. In their many conflicts, Israel achieved supremacy over Edom. • your older son will serve your younger son: God's choice of the younger son over the elder ran against natural order (cp. [48:12–14](#); see [Mal 1:1–3](#); [Rom 9:11–16](#)).

Genesis 25:24–26

When the twins were born, the unusual circumstances inspired each boy's name and hinted at what would happen to them in the future.

Genesis 25:25

Two wordplays anticipate Esau's later life. Esau sounds like Hebrew *se'ar*, which means "hair"; Esau's later homeland, Edom, was known as *Seir* ("hairy") because it was wooded (as though covered with hair). • red (Hebrew *'admoni*) sounds like Esau's other name, Edom ([25:27–34](#)); Edom had red soil. • Esau's >hair was like the fur coat of an animal, foreshadowing his unspiritual character ([25:34](#); [Heb 12:16](#); cp. [Lev 26:22](#); [Deut 7:22](#); [1 Cor 15:32](#)). The description of the child uses words that highlight the Edomites' nature.

Genesis 25:26

The name Jacob (Hebrew *ya'aqob*, from Hebrew *'aqeb*, "heel, footprint") was originally positive, meaning "protect" (like a rear guard), but it took on the negative meaning of "heel grabber" or "deceiver" in the context of Jacob's deceptive, grasping, usurping character (see [27:36](#)).

Genesis 25:27

Esau was a skillful hunter and an outdoorsman—a wild man who loved wild country. Jacob had a quiet (or *even*) temperament and preferred to stay at home (literally *dwelling in tents*)—i.e., he was civilized.

Genesis 25:27–34

Jacob and Esau each developed in accord with his initial characteristics ([25:24–26](#)). Esau, the reddish, hairy man, cared about physical things rather than spiritual things (see [Heb 12:16](#)); he was finally overcome by physical appetites and sold his birthright. Jacob, the heel grabber, knew the birthright's value and drove a ruthless bargain to gain it presumptuously from his brother.

Genesis 25:28

The parents each practiced favoritism. • because: Isaac's love for Esau was conditioned upon his son's performance. Rebekah's love for Jacob was constant and unconditional.

Genesis 25:29

Ironically, Jacob proved the more cunning hunter. The word cooking (Hebrew *wayyazed*, "boiling") sounds like the word for "hunter" (Hebrew *tsayid*). While boiling stew, Jacob was laying a trap for the hairy red animal. He may have waited a long time for this opportunity. This word for "boil" was also used for presumptuous action (like water boiling over the rim of the pot). Jacob overstepped his boundaries when he seized the promise for himself. By contrast, Abraham knew the promise was his and was secure in giving the land away (see study note on 13:8–13). • Esau was exhausted and hungry, but his life was not in danger ([25:32](#); see study note on 25:33–34).

Genesis 25:30

Esau was preoccupied with his appetite. Being driven by one's appetites leaves no place for spiritual values. The text emphasizes this by using

a Hebrew word (translated give) that was normally used for feeding animals. • Edom, which means “red”: See study note on 25:25.

Genesis 25:31-33

Jacob was the better hunter on this occasion, but great danger lay in exercising such strong ambition. God’s people should desire the things of God, but they must not seek them in the flesh (see [Zech 4:6](#); [Gal 5:16-17](#); [Eph 6:10-12](#)). The Lord dealt severely with Jacob to purge him of carnal methods. He later received the promise not as crafty Jacob the usurper, but as Israel (meaning, “God fights”), with God fighting on his behalf ([Gen 32:28](#)).

Genesis 25:33-34

Esau eagerly took Jacob’s bait and fell into the trap. He ate and left too quickly to have been near death ([25:32](#)). The final comment on the passage explains that Esau showed contempt for his birthright, considering it worthless ([Heb 12:16](#)). It is foolish to sacrifice spiritual blessings to satisfy physical appetites (cp. [Gen 3:6](#)).

Genesis 26:1

This Abimelech is probably not the man in ch [20](#), for these events could have been 90 years apart. Possibly Abimelech was a dynastic name or title (a later King Achish, [1 Sam 21:10](#), was also called Abimelech, [Ps 34:title](#)).

Genesis 26:1-35

In this digression from Jacob’s story, Isaac’s prosperity (ch [26](#)) shows that the blessing had passed to him (cp. [25:11](#)) despite his failures of faith.

Genesis 26:2-5

The Lord assured Isaac that the covenant promises (cp. [12:2-3](#); [15:5-8](#); [17:3-8](#); [22:15-18](#); [28:13-14](#)) would pass to him because Abraham faithfully listened to God and obeyed all his requirements, commands, decrees, and instructions. These terms

were later used in Deuteronomy to describe God’s full legal covenant with Israel. An Israelite reader would immediately think of the complete Torah when hearing these words and be prompted to obey God’s law as Abraham did, though Abraham had only a few commands from the Lord. Through these words, the text emphasizes that Abraham would have obeyed the later commands if he had had them, because he was an obedient servant of the Lord.

Genesis 26:6-11

While staying in Gerar, Isaac, like his father, deceived people into believing that his wife was his sister. Some suppose that this story duplicates the stories of Abraham’s deception ([12:10-20](#); [20:1-18](#)), but the differences are greater than the similarities, and the son’s repetition of his father’s lie is natural. Through numerous parallels with Abraham, ch [26](#) shows how God’s plan continued with Isaac. Even when Isaac jeopardized the covenant as his father had, God prevented disaster and preserved the marriage. Abraham’s descendants would be blessed because of Abraham, but they had to exercise their own faith to enjoy the blessings. Genuine faith in God’s promises engenders a fearless walk with him; cowering in fear endangers the blessing and mocks the faith.

Genesis 26:8

Abimelech . . . saw Isaac caressing Rebekah: The word for “caressing” (Hebrew *metsakheq*) is the same as the word used for Ishmael’s “making fun of” Isaac ([21:9](#)); the word is related to the name “Isaac” (Hebrew *yitskhaq*). It is as though Isaac’s lapse of faith made fun of Abimelech and made a mockery of Rebekah and the great promise embodied in Isaac’s name.

Genesis 26:10-11

Isaac, like his father, was rebuked by Abimelech (see study note on 20:1-18). This legal wording would remind Israel of how important it was to preserve marital purity. Abimelech recognized the danger to his own people. Though his decree preserved his own society, it was also a word from God that preserved the sanctity of Isaac’s and

Israel's marriages. If Isaac's marriage had ended here, there would have been no Israelite society.

Genesis 26:12–13

Isaac lived in the land as a temporary settler, enjoying abundant prosperity because of God's blessing; his crops flourished and he became very rich.

Genesis 26:14–16

The Philistines envied Isaac's prosperity and filled his wells with dirt. The king then ordered Isaac to leave that region because he was too powerful for them (cp. [21:22–23](#)).

Genesis 26:17–22

Isaac moved . . . to the Gerar Valley (away from the city of Gerar itself, [26:6](#), but probably still within ten miles) and reopened his father's wells. Isaac was also opposed there, but chose not to fight back; he relinquished one well after another until God's blessing outdid the opposition. Whenever Isaac reopened a well, and regardless of how often enemies caused them to cave in, he found water. God was blessing Isaac and that blessing could not be hindered. Finally, the Philistines left Isaac alone.

Genesis 26:23–25

At Beersheba, . . . the Lord appeared to Isaac to confirm his covenant (cp. [21:31–33](#)). Isaac responded in faith as his father had done by building an altar to the Lord and proclaiming the Lord's identity and nature (see study note on 12:8; [21:33](#)).

Genesis 26:26–33

This treaty is similar to the one an earlier king had made with Abraham (cp. [21:22–31](#)). This king acknowledged that God was blessing Isaac and realized that a treaty with Isaac would benefit him. No opposition can hinder God's blessing—it will flourish, and other nations will see it and seek peace with God's people to share in the blessing.

Genesis 26:33

Since the earlier treaty was renewed with Isaac, the name of the well was also renewed by the oath.

Genesis 26:34–35

Esau's marriages illustrate how unfit he was to lead the covenant people into God's blessings, and how foolish was Isaac's later attempt to bless Esau ([27:1–40](#)). Esau later married a third wife in a vain attempt to do the right thing ([28:6–9](#)).

Genesis 27:1–4

The first scene sets up the chapter's crisis. Isaac knew of God's oracle ([25:22–23](#)), yet he thwarted or ignored it by trying to bless Esau. • Isaac was old and turning blind: He was losing his senses, both physically and spiritually.

Genesis 27:1–40

Jacob got his father Isaac's blessing through deception. In this story, an entire family tries to carry out their responsibilities by physical means rather than by faith. Faith would have provided Rebekah and Jacob a more honorable solution to the crisis.

Genesis 27:3–4

Like Esau, Isaac allowed his palate to govern his heart (cp. [25:28–34](#)).

Genesis 27:5

Esau agreed to Isaac's plan, thus breaking the oath he had sworn to Jacob ([25:33](#)).

Genesis 27:5–17

The blessing seemed to be in jeopardy. In scene two, Rebekah and Jacob sought to achieve God's blessing by deception, without faith or love. Rebekah planned to deceive the old man into

thinking that he was blessing Esau when he was actually blessing Jacob.

Genesis 27:11-12

Jacob had no qualms about this deception; he only feared that it might not work and that he would be cursed for trying.

Genesis 27:18-20

Jacob lied about his identity, and then came close to blasphemy (speaking in a way that dishonors God) by lying about God.

Genesis 27:18-29

In scene three, Jacob deceives his father and receives the blessing.

Genesis 27:20-27

Isaac expressed his doubts three times. But his senses, which were not working well, eventually misled him (see study note on 27:1-4).

Genesis 27:30-40

In scene four, everything is discovered, and the family becomes even more divided.

Genesis 27:33

When Isaac understood what happened, he started shaking uncontrollably. He had tried to change God's plan, but God stopped him.

Genesis 27:34-35

Esau was very bitter and angry enough to kill. After Jacob received their father's blessing, Esau planned to take his brother's life ([27:41](#)).

Genesis 27:36

Esau began to realize Jacob's true nature, saying he has cheated me (or *tripped me up*, or *deceived me*) twice, by taking the birthright (the right of inheritance, Hebrew *bekorah*; [25:27-34](#)) and by deceiving their father to receive the blessing (the spoken pronouncement of the inheritance, Hebrew *berakah*). • Esau's assessment of Jacob was correct, but he failed to see his own ungodliness in these transactions (see study note on 27:5; [Heb 12:16](#)).

Genesis 27:37

There was no going back. Isaac had declared an oracle from God, who had made Jacob to be Esau's master (see [Rom 9:11-13](#)).

Genesis 27:39-40

All that remained for Esau was a promise of hardship and struggle (compare [3:17-19](#); [16:11-12](#)).

Genesis 27:41-45

Rebekah and Jacob got the blessing but reaped hatred from Esau and separation from one another; there is no indication that Rebekah and Jacob ever saw each other again. They gained nothing that God was not already going to give them, and their methods were costly. Jacob fled from home to escape Esau's vengeance.

Genesis 27:42-33:17

Jacob met the Lord on a road that Abraham had traveled 125 years earlier. The story in [27:42-33:17](#) follows a pattern (called a "chiasm") focusing on Jacob's exile:

- A: Jacob runs away from Esau ([27:42–28:9](#))
 - B: Angels of God meet Jacob at Bethel ([28:10–22](#))
 - C: Jacob lives in exile in Paddan-aram ([29:1–31:55](#))
 - B': Angels of God meet Jacob at Mahanaim ([32:1–2](#))
- A': Jacob reconciles with Esau ([32:3–33:17](#)).

Genesis 27:46

Rebekah convinced Isaac to send Jacob away by carefully planning her words and actions. Like Isaac, Jacob married a woman from his relatives who lived in the east.

Genesis 28:1–2

Isaac remained in the land, but Jacob had to leave it. God would deal with Jacob under the hand of Laban, his uncle (see study note on 29:1–31:55). • Believers in any age must remain spiritually pure by marrying other believers ([2 Cor 6:14–18](#)). The Canaanite people incorporated dozens of groups and clans into their society and religion by wars, treaties, and marriages (see [Gen 34:20–23](#)). Abraham's family was to resist such mixing (cp. [24:3](#); ch [34](#)); they were to marry within their clan to maintain the purity of the line and of the faith that identified them as the chosen seed. The surest way to lose their distinctiveness was to intermarry with people of other tribal backgrounds and beliefs (see [Ezra 9–10](#); [Neh 13:23–29](#)).

Genesis 28:3–5

Before Jacob departed, Isaac gave him a pure, legitimate blessing. He did not hold back, because he now knew what God wanted him to do. Isaac clearly passed on the blessing God Almighty (Hebrew El-Shaddai; see [17:1](#)) had given to Abraham and to him regarding prosperity and the land (cp. [15:5](#), [18–20](#)).

Genesis 28:6–9

Esau, the unchosen son still trying to please his father, married a woman from the unchosen line of Ishmael, which he thought would be more acceptable. He did not understand the uniqueness of the covenant family.

Genesis 28:10–22

Despite Jacob's previous means of securing the blessing, God assured him of protection and provision. The God of Abraham and Isaac was also the God of Jacob. The revelation dramatically changed Jacob's outlook and brought faith into clearer focus.

Genesis 28:11

The good place where Jacob set up camp was apparently a protected area at the foot of a hill. The stone to rest his head against was probably large, more for protection than for a pillow.

Genesis 28:12–13

stairway (traditionally *ladder*): This word occurs nowhere else in Scripture. The imagery probably reminded readers of a staircase or ramp up the front of a ziggurat that signified communication between heaven and earth (see study note on 11:4). God initiated a divine communication between heaven and earth to guide and protect Jacob, the steward of his covenant ([28:13–15](#); see [Ps 91:11–15](#)). • Jesus said that he himself is the stairway between heaven and earth ([John 1:51](#)).

Genesis 28:12–15

The point of the vision was that God and his angels were with Jacob on his journey. God reiterated to Jacob the covenant promises made to Abraham and Isaac, promising him land, descendants numerous as the dust (cp. [13:16](#); [22:17](#)), and universal blessing through him (cp. [12:2–3](#); [15:5](#), [18](#); [17:3–8](#); [22:15–18](#); [35:11–12](#)). God also promised to be with Jacob and watch over him until he returned.

Genesis 28:14

Jacob inherited Abraham's entire covenant (see [22:17](#)), which confirmed Isaac's blessing ([28:3–4](#)) and stipulated a temporary exile ([28:15](#); see [15:12–16](#)).

Genesis 28:15

I am with you: The promise of God's presence meant that God would protect and provide for Jacob in a special way. God's promise to be with his people is repeated throughout Scripture (see also [26:24](#)), prompting a response of worship and confidence in those who have faith ([28:16–22](#)).

Genesis 28:16–22

The second half of the passage gives Jacob's response to the revelation. He felt reverential fear and awe in the Lord's presence, and his acts of devotion became archetypes of Israel's worship. When God graciously visits his people and promises to be with them and make them a blessing to the world, his people respond in faith with reverential fear, worship, offerings, and vows. They preserve their faith in memory for future worshipers.

Genesis 28:18

Anointing with oil became a way of setting something apart for divine use in Israel's worship ([Exod 29:1–7](#); [40:9](#); [Lev 2:1](#); [1 Sam 10:1](#)).

Genesis 28:19

Bethel later became a holy site for Israel (see [Judges 20:18–27](#); [1 Samuel 7:16](#); [10:3](#); [1 Kings 12:26–13:10](#); [2 Kings 2:2–3](#)).

Genesis 28:20–22

In view of what God would do for him, Jacob vowed to do certain things for God. He believed the Lord's words and responded in gratitude. Jacob's vow influenced Israel's way of making commitments to God in worship.

Genesis 28:22

I will present to God a tenth: By paying a tithe (*a tenth*) as an act of worship, a person acknowledges that everything is a gift from God and belongs to God (see [14:19–20](#); [Num 18:21–32](#); [Deut 14:22–29](#); [2 Chr 31:5–6](#); [Mal 3:7–12](#); [Matt 23:23](#)).

Genesis 29:1

Jacob hurried on: The Hebrew text says that he “picked up his feet” as if he felt the wind at his back; he continued his journey with fresh enthusiasm. His changed outlook was the direct result of the vision he received at Bethel, a marvelous revelation that God was going to protect and bless him. He now sought the fulfillment of God's promises to him, not just an escape from Esau. Jacob's attitude had become positive and magnanimous to the point of being naive and vulnerable.

Genesis 29:1–31:55

These chapters tell how God kept his promise by abundantly blessing Jacob with family and possessions. God also disciplined Jacob, leaving him to struggle with Laban for many years. Laban was Jacob's match in deception, and thus a means of correction. • The story of Jacob and Laban parallels Israel's later sojourn in Egypt. Jacob struggled while serving his uncle but finally emerged with a large family (the founders of the twelve tribes) and great wealth. In Egypt, the Israelites suffered under their oppressors, but they also flourished, becoming a great nation of twelve large tribes and escaping with great riches.

Genesis 29:2–12

Jacob's meeting Rachel at the well was providentially timed by the sovereign God who was leading Jacob to fulfillment of the promises (cp. [24:12–20](#)). The well was a reminder of God's blessing (cp. [16:13–14](#); [21:19](#); [26:19–25](#), [33](#)).

Genesis 29:10

In contrast to the lazy, unhelpful shepherds ([29:7–8](#)), Jacob is portrayed as generous, industrious, and energetic. • Jacob . . . watered his uncle's flock: Laban's flocks would flourish under Jacob's care.

Genesis 29:11

Jacob kissed Rachel: Kissing relatives was an appropriate way to greet them ([29:13](#); compare [Song 8:1](#)).

Genesis 29:14

You are indeed my own flesh and blood: Laban welcomed Jacob into his house and treated him much like a son.

Genesis 29:14–30

Jacob's joyful prospect of marriage to the lovely Rachel became an occasion for Laban's shrewdness and Jacob's discipline. Jacob and his mother had deceived his father and brother to gain the blessing; now his mother's brother deceived him. Jacob received a dose of his own duplicity through twenty years of labor, affliction, and deception in Laban's service ([31:38](#)). In God's justice, people harvest what they plant ([Gal 6:7](#)). Laban's deception was perfectly designed to make Jacob aware of his own craftiness. God often brings people into the lives of believers to discipline them. But Jacob was tenacious, and God blessed him abundantly with a large family and many possessions ([30:25–43](#)) during this time of service.

Genesis 29:18

Seven years of service was a high bride-price in the ancient world, but Rachel was beautiful (like Sarah and Rebekah), and Jacob was in love with her.

Genesis 29:23–26

Like Isaac, Jacob was plied with food and wine (cp. [27:25](#)), deprived of sight in the darkness (cp. [27:1](#)), baffled by clothing (cp. [27:15](#)), and misled by touch (cp. [27:23](#)). The marriage had been consummated

([29:23](#); see [2:24](#)), so Jacob was bound to Leah. • It's not our custom here to marry off a younger daughter ahead of the firstborn: Laban's words are a reminder of what Jacob did when he, the younger son, pretended to be his older brother to gain the blessing (ch [27](#)). Now Leah, the older sister, pretended to be the younger sister to get a husband. God gave the deceiver a dose of his own deception as a discipline in his life.

Genesis 29:28–30

After the bridal week ended ([29:27](#)), Jacob also received Rachel as his wife, though he then would have to work an additional seven years (cp. [31:41](#)). Laban seemed to have gained the upper hand.

Genesis 29:30

Jacob loved Rachel much more than Leah: Favoritism was an ongoing cause of dysfunction in Jacob's family (cp. [25:28](#); [37:3](#)). Jacob's favoritism had lasting effects: his family was never together, and their descendants, the tribes of Israel, were rarely unified.

Genesis 29:31–35

Leah's first four sons were born in rapid succession, but Rachel could not conceive. She was barren, like Sarah and Rebekah (cp. [16:1](#); [25:21](#); see also [1 Sam 1:1–28](#); [Luke 1:5–25](#)). • Each name is a memorable wordplay on Leah's experience and hopes.

Genesis 29:31–30:24

The rivalry between these sisters explains much of the later rivalry among their sons, and then among the tribes, just as the rivalry between Jacob and Laban foreshadowed conflict between Israel and the Arameans of Damascus ([2 Sam 8:5–6](#); [10:8–19](#); [1 Kgs 20:1–34](#); [2 Kgs 5:1–8:29](#); [13:1–25](#); [Isa 7:1–9](#)). • God champions the cause of the poor and oppressed; he exalted Leah, the despised first wife, as the first to become a mother. Judah's kingly tribe and Levi's priestly line came through her despite Jacob's favoritism for Rachel and her children. Despite the tension and jealousy resulting from Laban's treachery and Jacob's favoritism, God still

built Jacob's family and brought about the births of the tribal ancestors.

Genesis 29:32

Reuben (Hebrew re'uben) sounds like the Hebrew for "He has seen my misery" (ra'ah be'onyi). His birth gave Leah consolation from God and hope for Jacob's love. Jacob seems not to have seen her misery, but God did (cp. [16:14](#); [24:62](#); [25:11](#)). The name was a reminder of God's intervention.

Genesis 29:33

Leah named her second son Simeon. The name suggests that she had cried out to the Lord and was heard (cp. [16:11](#)).

Genesis 29:34

Leah named her third son Levi, hoping that her husband would become "attached" to her since she had given him three sons. This hope was not fulfilled.

Genesis 29:35

Leah reconciled herself to the reality that nothing would turn Jacob's affections toward her. She named her fourth son Judah with the sentiment, "I will praise the Lord." She seems to have given up on Jacob, taking her consolation from the Lord.

Genesis 30:1-2

In that culture, it was like death for a woman not to have children (cp. [1 Sam 1](#)); only God could open Rachel's womb.

Genesis 30:1-8

Rachel's naming of sons through Bilhah does not reflect faith as Leah's namings had. Rachel felt wronged over the marriage and her barrenness. The names of Bilhah's sons reflect Rachel's bitter struggle with her sister and her feeling of some victory.

Genesis 30:3-4

Rachel decided to have children through her servant, and Jacob agreed. This is similar to Sarai using Hagar ([16:1-4](#)).

Genesis 30:5-6

Dan means "he judged" or "he vindicated." Rachel felt justified (Hebrew *dananni*) by Dan's birth.

Genesis 30:7-8

The name *Naphtali* is related to the phrase *In my great struggles*. In Hebrew, the phrase is *naptule 'elohim niptalti*, which means "I have struggled the struggles of God."

Genesis 30:9

When Leah saw that she had stopped having children, she gave her servant Zilpah to Jacob as a wife, even though she already had four sons.

Genesis 30:10-13

Gad (meaning "fortune") was the name of a god associated with fortune. *Asher* (meaning "happy") was the name of a god associated with luck. These names show Leah's pagan background, but there is no indication she believed in these gods.

Genesis 30:14-17

People believed *mandrakes* could increase sexual desire and help women become pregnant (see [Song 7:13](#)). Rachel hoped they would help her become pregnant, so she made a deal with Leah. Rachel would let Leah spend one night with Jacob in exchange for mandrakes. Yet, Leah became pregnant, not Rachel.

Genesis 30:18

The name *Issachar* reflects this idea of being hired or receiving payment. It reminds readers of the events surrounding his birth. Leah says that Jacob was "hired" for the night ([Genesis 30:16](#)). The Hebrew word *sekari* means "my hire."

Genesis 30:19-20

Zebulun means "honor" or "gift," like a dowry or tribute. Leah believed God gave her Zebulun so her husband would honor her. She always hoped this would happen.

Genesis 30:21

Dinah was the only daughter of Jacob. See chapter [34](#).

Genesis 30:22-24

- Rachel finally had her own son, Joseph, thanks to God's intervention. His birth was not due to superstitions ([30:14-16](#)) or the custom of giving servants as wives.
- The Hebrew word translated as "taken away" (*'asap*) sounds similar to the name *Joseph* (*yosep*), which means "may he add." Rachel was happy about Joseph's birth and prayed for another son.

Genesis 30:25-34

After working for fourteen years, Jacob asked Laban if he could return home. The two nomadic leaders negotiated politely but stayed cautious. Laban wanted more from Jacob, while Jacob wanted to earn his wages through selective breeding.

Genesis 30:27

I have become wealthy: God had prospered Laban through Jacob's presence (see [22:18](#)). Laban may

have looked for omens, or simply have perceived what was happening. Since dark-colored sheep ([30:32](#)) were rare, a large number of them was considered an omen of God's blessing.

Genesis 30:30-33

Jacob agreed that God had blessed Laban through him, so he made a plan to gain something for himself. He proposed for his wages the rare black and multicolored goats and the speckled and spotted sheep that were born.

Genesis 30:32

As Abraham had done with Lot ([13:9](#)), Jacob gave Laban what he valued most. White sheep were more common and more valuable than dark or multicolored sheep; as a man of faith, Jacob was willing to take the rejects (cp. [1 Cor 1:26](#)).

Genesis 30:34-36

Laban verbally agreed with Jacob's plan, but he tried to prevent Jacob from accruing wealth by removing animals from the flock that would fulfill the agreement. • Laban's deception with his goats reminds us of Jacob's deception of Esau (cp. [27:9](#); see study note on 29:14-30).

Genesis 30:37

exposing the white inner wood: This clever wordplay explains the entire section. When Jacob *exposed the white* (Hebrew *laban*) streaks of wood underneath, he played the "white" game (the *Laban* game) and won. By outsmarting Laban ("Whitey"), Jacob's flocks increased and he became successful.

Genesis 30:37-43

God blessed Jacob despite Laban's duplicity. Not to be outwitted, Jacob used selective breeding to acquire a flock, following the traditional belief that peeled sticks influenced the kind of animal that would be born. The peeled branches seemingly made his animals produce streaked and spotted young; Jacob later acknowledged that God had prospered him ([31:7-12](#)). Jacob gained stronger

animals for himself and weaker ones for Laban ([30:41–42](#)).

Genesis 30:42

Laban now received due recompense for his treatment of Jacob. Laban's attempt to defraud Jacob resulted in Jacob's coming out ahead, because God was at work in his life.

Genesis 30:43

Jacob became very wealthy, in fulfillment of God's promises to him ([27:28](#); [28:13–15](#)).

Genesis 31:1–2

The animosity of Laban's sons against Jacob grew because his flocks were multiplying faster than Laban's. They were jealous of God's blessing on Jacob and afraid that he would completely overrun them.

Genesis 31:1–21

Jacob's return journey precipitated a confrontation with Laban that set a permanent boundary between Israel (Jacob) and Aram (Laban). God kept his word to Jacob by prospering him in Paddan-aram and protecting him on his journey home.

Genesis 31:3

- *the land of your fathers* was Canaan, to which God had called Abraham ([12:1–7](#); [17:8](#)).
- *Go back ... I will be with you*: See study notes on 26:2–5; 28:12–15. God protected Jacob (also called "Israel," [32:28](#)) as he led his family back to the land God promised them. Later, God brought Israel back to Canaan after many years of slavery in Egypt. This return had many similarities to this passage:
 - God defeated foreign gods and beliefs.
 - He used dreams for rescue and protection.
 - He gave victory over threats.
 - He set boundaries between nations and tribes (see [Deuteronomy 32:8](#)).

Genesis 31:4–13

Jacob explained to his wives how God had blessed him despite Laban's opposition. He was not sure they would want to leave Laban and go to Canaan. He wanted to take a willing family, so he had to make an effective appeal. He rehearsed God's leading and provision over the years and then told them that he had to keep the vow he had made at Bethel ([28:20–22](#)).

Genesis 31:14–16

The women responded immediately that they would go with Jacob because God had blessed him. They were very willing to leave Laban, who had squandered their wealth (the property that would have provided for them). They knew that what God had given to Jacob would also be theirs.

Genesis 31:17–21

Jacob left Laban secretly because he was afraid of revenge ([31:31](#)).

Genesis 31:19–20

Rachel stole her father's household idols: Rachel probably wanted to regain some of the assets Laban had squandered; possibly she also worshiped idols (cp. [35:2–4](#)). To have the idols may have signified claiming the family inheritance, as customs in subsequent periods indicate. Laban apparently felt vulnerable without them. Whatever her reasons, Rachel's theft almost brought disaster on the fleeing family when Laban caught up with them. • A wordplay shows that Rachel and Jacob were very much alike—Rachel stole (Hebrew *wattignob*) Laban's household gods, and Jacob outwitted (Hebrew *wayyignob*, “stole the heart of, deceived”) Laban.

Genesis 31:21

The journey took the family from Haran southwest to the land of Gilead, just east of the Jordan River in the north of today's kingdom of Jordan.

Genesis 31:22–23

The theft of the idols ([31:19](#)) was probably the main reason that Laban and his men chased Jacob. It was one thing for Jacob to take his family and flocks—Laban probably still believed they were all his—but another matter entirely to take his household gods. Laban may have feared that Jacob would return someday to claim all of Laban's estate. When he failed to find the gods, he asked for a treaty to keep Jacob away ([31:43–53](#)). • It took Laban seven days to catch up with Jacob.

Genesis 31:24

leave Jacob alone! (literally *Do not speak to Jacob either good or evil*): God commanded Laban not to take justice into his own hands. When we try to enact our own sense of good and evil apart from God's command, we always do evil (see study note on 2:9).

Genesis 31:25–30

The dispute between the two men used the language of legal controversies and lawsuits (see also [31:36](#)). In his first argument, Laban presented himself as a wounded party that Jacob had robbed.

Genesis 31:32

Jacob, so convinced that he didn't have the gods, used an oath that unwittingly put Rachel under a death sentence.

Genesis 31:33–35

Laban searched for the idols but found nothing. Laban never dreamed that a woman having her monthly period would desecrate the idols by sitting on them (cp. [Lev 15:19–24](#)).

Genesis 31:36–42

Jacob retaliated by accusing Laban of false charges and humiliation. Laban now became the defendant, for his charges were demeaning and apparently groundless.

Genesis 31:40

Jacob, who preferred domestic life ([25:27](#)), had for twenty years endured the rigors of the outdoors that Esau had loved.

Genesis 31:42

The God that Isaac feared (see textual note) was with Jacob ([31:3](#)), had seen his hard work and faithfulness despite Laban's abuse, and had rewarded Jacob. Laban's dream only proved to Jacob that he was in the right.

Genesis 31:43–44

Laban pushed for a treaty to settle the dispute—he felt vulnerable, so he wanted to secure the borders. Jacob did not need a treaty, since God had provided for him and protected him.

Genesis 31:45-48

The stone and the heap of stones were a monument to the border treaty between the two men, as a witness to future generations. Each man named the monument witness pile in his native language. It remained the perpetual border between Israel and the kingdom of Aram (Syria), two nations often at war.

Genesis 31:49

The witness pile was also called watchtower. God would watch over Jacob and Laban and keep them apart, for they could not trust each other.

Genesis 31:50-53

Laban added some face-saving stipulations to the treaty, using many words to cover up his own untrustworthiness and portray Jacob as the unethical party. He even took credit for the monument Jacob had erected (this monument I have set, [31:51](#)). The women and children would be much safer and better cared for with Jacob than they ever were with Laban.

Genesis 32:1

God assured Jacob of his protection at a time when Jacob most needed such consolation. His journey was both a physical return to his homeland and a spiritual return to the land of God's promised blessing. God protects his people and fulfills his plan.

Genesis 32:2

This is God's camp! Jacob must have seen the angels that revealed God's presence as a sign of protection, as with the earlier vision when he was departing the land ([28:10-22](#)). • Mahanaim ("two camps"): Jacob's company and the company of angels were together in one place.

Genesis 32:3-5

Apparently inspired by the vision of angels ([32:1](#), Hebrew *mal'akim*), Jacob sent messengers (*mal'akim*) into Edom to meet Esau.

Genesis 32:7-8

Jacob divided his company into two groups or camps (Hebrew *makhanoth*, related to "Mahanaim" in [32:2](#)) because he was afraid, remembering Esau's character and his threat to kill Jacob (see [25:25](#); [27:41](#)).

Genesis 32:9-12

Jacob's prayer is a wonderful example of how to address God. He based his appeal on God's will, reminding God of his relationship with him, his command for him to return to the land, and his promise ([32:9](#)). He had a correct attitude of genuine humility and total dependence on God ([32:10](#)). Finally, he asked that God rescue him from his brother, and he repeated God's promises (see [22:17](#)).

Genesis 32:13-21

Taking a large portion of the wealth God had blessed him with (some 550 animals), Jacob prepared a gift to appease Esau's anger and gain his favor.

Genesis 32:22-24

The Jabbok River flows westward to the Jordan Valley, dividing the region of Bashan on the north from Gilead on the south. Wordplays on Jacob's name and character preserve the memory of this encounter. Jacob (Hebrew *ya'aqob*), while at Jabbok (Hebrew *yabboq*), wrestled (Hebrew *wayye'abeq*). Through his fight with an adversary to receive the blessing, Jacob's name would be changed, and his deceptive striving would partially give way to faith as his way of life.

Genesis 32:22–32

Before Jacob returned to the land God had promised him, God met him, crippled him, and blessed him, changing his name to Israel. This episode was a significant turning point for him.

Genesis 32:24

a man came: The narrative unfolds as the event did for Jacob. No details are given about the assailant, who later refused to identify himself ([32:29](#)). • until the dawn: The darkness fit Jacob's situation and increased the fear and uncertainty that seized him. In the darkness he had no idea who it was—it might have been one of Esau's men, or Laban's.

Genesis 32:25

he touched Jacob's hip and wrenched it out of its socket: Jacob, the deceitful fighter, could fight no more. When his assailant fought him as man to man, Jacob could hold his own. But like so many of his own rivals, he had now more than met his match.

Genesis 32:26

At daybreak, the significance of this fight began to dawn on Jacob. He realized who his assailant was, and since it was futile to fight, he held on to obtain God's blessing.

Genesis 32:27

What is your name? The Lord's question was really about Jacob's character, not his identity (cp. [3:9](#); [4:9](#)). By giving his name, Jacob confessed his nature, his way of doing things as "Heel-grabber, Deceiver, Usurper." Before God would bless him, he had to acknowledge who he was, and then God would change his identity.

Genesis 32:28

Jacob: See study note on 25:26. • Israel ("God fights"): God first had to fight *with* him, but now God would fight *for* him. Jacob's name was thus full of promise for Jacob and his descendants. • you

have fought with God and with men: Through his entire life, Jacob had been seizing God's blessing by his own abilities and by any means possible. Jacob knew the importance of the blessing, but he was too self-sufficient and proud to let the blessing be given to him. He had been fighting God long before this encounter. • and have won: He had prevailed in his struggles with Esau and with Laban; now he prevailed in obtaining God's blessing.

Genesis 32:29

Jacob knew who was with him ([32:30](#)); the request was his attempt to regain some control. God would not reveal his name, which cannot be had on demand.

Genesis 32:30

Peniel (which means "face of God"): The name shows that Jacob recognized the man as a manifestation of God (a *theophany*). • yet my life has been spared (or *and I have been rescued*): The saying probably meant that Jacob realized that his prayer to be rescued from Esau ([32:11](#)) had been answered, for if he could meet God like this and walk away, he had nothing to fear from Esau. The saying may also reflect an ancient understanding that no one could see God and live (see [Exod 33:20](#)).

Genesis 32:31

God injured Jacob's hip, thus curtailing his proud self-sufficiency. Since the Lord had restricted his natural strength, Jacob would have to rely on the Lord with greater faith. He had thought that returning to his land would be a matter of outwitting his brother once again ([32:3–21](#)), but here at the land's threshold he met its true proprietor. He would get the land, but only if God fought for him. Self-sufficiency—trying to achieve the blessing by our own strength or by the ways of the world—will not suffice. If we persist, God may have to cripple our self-sufficiency to make us trust him more.

Genesis 32:32

The story includes a dietary restriction for Israel that became a custom but was not put into law. This custom helped preserve the memory of the story. Observant Jews still refuse to eat the tendons of an animal's hindquarters.

Genesis 33:1–2

Jacob's identity had been changed ([32:27–28](#)), but he had not yet learned to live up to the new name; he still showed the favoritism that divides families. He lined up his family and his possessions in the order of their importance to him, with the slave wives and their children in front (to face danger first), Leah's group behind them, and Rachel and Joseph in the back, where it was safest.

Genesis 33:1–17

Jacob's long-anticipated meeting with his brother Esau turned out far better than he had feared. Esau's changed heart is an example of how "God fights" (See [32:28](#)). Earlier, he had cared little about the birthright ([25:32–34](#)); now he cared little for old grudges. Jacob recognized that God had intervened.

Genesis 33:3–13

Even though Jacob had nothing to fear, he was afraid and tried to appease his brother. He assumed the role of a servant before royalty by bowing ([33:3](#)), using an honorific title ([33:8](#), [13](#)), making introductions ([33:6–7](#)), and presenting gifts ([33:8](#)).

Genesis 33:4

Esau's friendly greeting was an answer to prayer ([32:11](#)). God had rescued Jacob from Esau's revenge.

Genesis 33:5

your servant: In talking with his brother, Jacob continued to refer to himself as Esau's servant (also [33:14](#)) and to Esau as his lord ([33:8](#), [13–15](#)); Esau called Jacob "my brother" ([33:9](#)). Jacob was

cautiously warding off any possible retaliation by reversing the words of the oracle ([25:23](#)).

Genesis 33:7

Among Jacob's sons, only Joseph is named. Joseph was Jacob's favorite son and the recipient of the blessing.

Genesis 33:10

Jacob knew that Esau's friendly greeting was God's work, secured at Peniel when he saw God face to face.

Genesis 33:11

this gift I have brought you (literally *my blessing*): Jacob perceived Esau as a threat and tried to appease him with a gift (cp. [2 Kgs 17:3–4](#); [18:7](#), [14](#); [2 Chr 28:21](#)), perhaps in a guilty attempt to undo the past. Jacob would not take no for an answer.

Genesis 33:12–15

Despite Esau's apparent magnanimity, Jacob was wary and cleverly avoided traveling with his brother. • I will meet you at Seir: Jacob's lie manifests his old character, living by deception rather than by faith.

Genesis 33:16–17

Instead of following Esau south to Seir as promised, Jacob again deceived his brother, then headed in the opposite direction to Succoth, east of the Jordan River and north of the Jabbok.

Genesis 33:18–20

These verses form an epilogue to Jacob's adventures outside the land. He returned in peace with a large family and many possessions. • Jacob, like Abraham, built an altar at Shechem (see [12:6–8](#)) and purchased land from the family of Hamor.

Genesis 33:20

El-Elohe-Israel: The name of the altar (“God, the God of Israel”) commemorated Jacob’s relationship with God. Jacob publicly proclaimed that God was his God, and that God had led him back to the land he would inherit.

Genesis 34:1–2

As far as we know, Dinah was Jacob’s only daughter ([30:21](#)). • Shechem . . . seized her and raped her: Shechem violated and debased Dinah, so she had no chance for a proper marriage.

Genesis 34:1–31

Once Jacob and his family settled in the land, the Canaanite presence became a threat. This account is a stern warning to the Israelites about the possibility of their being defiled by the Canaanites. The nation of Israel was later commanded not to intermarry or make treaties with them, for they were a corrupt and corrupting people. This chapter implicitly warns against becoming familiar with the way they lived ([34:1–2](#)). It also taught Israel that in dealing with the Canaanites, they were to keep their integrity and not use the holy things of the covenant for deception and slaughter ([34:13](#)); Israel’s reputation was at stake in the land ([34:30](#)). For their ruthless violence, Simeon and Levi were passed over in the birthright blessing ([49:5–7](#)).

Genesis 34:3–4

While Shechem’s intense feelings for Dinah made him willing to undergo significant hardship ([34:11–12](#), [17–18](#), [24](#)), the way he showed his “love” for her was selfish, impetuous, and in violation of customary decency (cp. [Judg 14:2](#); see [1 Cor 13:4–7](#); [1 Jn 4:10](#)). His character illustrated why Israel needed to remain separate from the Canaanites.

Genesis 34:5–7

Jacob’s response to this crime is surprising. When he heard that Dinah had been defiled, he said nothing about it until his sons came home. Because Jacob did not act, his sons did, though without the

wisdom and integrity necessary for justice. Dinah’s full brothers were shocked and furious that Shechem had done such a disgraceful thing to Jacob’s family (literally *in Israel*; this is the first use of the name *Israel* to describe the family). This sexual crime was an outrage against the community of God’s people and deserved punishment, but the leader of the clan did nothing.

Genesis 34:8–10

Hamor proposed an alliance of intermarriage with the prospect of mutual economic benefit, but God had already promised Jacob everything, including the land ([34:10](#); see [14:21–24](#)). Hamor wanted to gain control of Israel’s wealth ([34:23](#)); no good could come of trusting the defiling Canaanites. For some of these reasons, intermarriage with Canaanites was not allowed under the law (see [Exod 23:27–33](#); [Deut 7:1–5](#))—unless, of course, they came to faith (see [Josh 2:1–15](#); [6:23–25](#); [Matt 1:5](#)).

Genesis 34:13–17

Dinah’s brothers responded to the proposal without waiting for Jacob to respond, and they acted deceitfully. They may not have thought that Shechem and his people would ever agree to the rite of circumcision, but they knew what they would do if the Canaanites accepted ([34:25](#)).

Genesis 34:18–24

The Canaanites accepted the stipulation and every male in the town was circumcised. This was not just to allow Shechem to marry Dinah, but to give them the opportunity to acquire everything that Jacob possessed ([34:23](#)).

Genesis 34:25–29

When Simeon and Levi used circumcision to deceive and slaughter the Canaanites, they showed disdain for the sign of the covenant. Their slaughter of all the males and their plunder of the city was not justice, but brutal and excessive revenge. In their moral outrage and desire to right the wrong, they should have demanded compensation (see [Exod 22:16–17](#); [Deut 22:28–29](#)). Instead, their

passionate act of rage cost them their birthright blessing ([Gen 49:5-7](#)).

Genesis 34:30

Jacob responded again out of fear of what would happen to him, but God caused the people of this land to fear him instead ([35:5](#)).

Genesis 35:1-7

Jacob returned to Bethel, about 24 kilometers (15 miles) south of Shechem, to fulfill the vows he made there ([28:20-22](#)).

Genesis 35:1-29

This chapter highlights God's promises, Jacob's vow, and the transition to Jacob's sons' carrying on the covenant. Deborah, Rachel, and Isaac all died, marking the end of an era and of the account of Isaac's family ([25:19-35:29](#)). • Idols were removed ([35:1-4](#)) and pure worship was established ([35:6-7](#)). During this transition, the faith had to be revitalized so that the covenant could be carried forward by Jacob's sons.

Genesis 35:2-4

Jacob had vowed wholehearted devotion to the Lord ([28:20-22](#)); establishing this required that his family remove all pagan idols and cease their devotion to other gods. God permits no rivals; only the Lord was to be their God (cp. [Josh 5:1-9](#)).

Genesis 35:3

He has been with me wherever I have gone: God had fulfilled his promises ([28:15](#); [31:3](#)), so Jacob must fulfill his vow.

Genesis 35:5

a terror from God: People had heard about the killing of the men of Shechem ([Genesis 34:25-30](#)).

Genesis 35:6-7

Jacob built an altar at Bethel as God had instructed ([35:1](#); compare [12:8](#)).

Genesis 35:9-15

At Bethel, God confirmed the promise he made earlier. He reminded Jacob that his name was now Israel, proving that he had received the blessing.

Genesis 35:11-12

God's reference to himself as God Almighty assured Jacob that his promise could and would be fulfilled. At Bethel, God had promised that Jacob would have descendants in the land (cp. [28:13-14](#)); here he added that his descendants would include kings (see [17:6](#)).

Genesis 35:14-15

In fulfilling his vow ([28:20-22](#)), Jacob's actions were almost identical to his actions in the earlier experience at Bethel (cp. [28:16-19](#)).

Genesis 35:16-20

Benjamin's birth completed the family, but it was a sorrowful event because Rachel died in childbirth (see study note on 31:32).

Genesis 35:18

Rachel found the name son of my sorrow appropriate to the situation, but Jacob did not want such a sad name for his son, so he changed it to son of my right hand. Jacob thus turned the day of sorrow into a day of hope that gave his son the prospect of success.

Genesis 35:19

Jacob did not carry Rachel's body to the family tomb at Machpelah ([23:1-20](#); [25:9](#); [49:30](#); [50:13](#)) but buried her in the territory that would be Benjamin's (see [Josh 18:21-28](#); [1 Sam 10:2](#)).

Genesis 35:20

it can be seen there to this day: This seems to be a later editorial comment by someone who was living in the land after the conquest and giving directions to the tomb (see Genesis Book Introduction, “Composition”).

Genesis 35:22

Reuben had intercourse with Bilhah, thus defiling his father’s marriage bed. Perhaps Reuben, as the oldest son, was trying to replace his father as head of the clan by a pagan procedure (cp. [2 Sam 16:15–22](#)), but by this action he lost his birthright (see [Gen 49:3–4](#)). • Jacob soon heard about it, but he again delayed his response (see [49:3–4](#); cp. [34:5](#)).

Genesis 35:23–26

The 12 sons of Jacob became the leaders of the 12 tribes of Israel. Their names are the beginnings of the nation.

Genesis 35:27–29

Esau and Jacob (listed here in ordinary birth order) came together—probably for the first time since they had reconciled ([33:16–17](#))—to bury Isaac in Hebron (see [13:18](#); [23:1–2](#), [17–19](#)).

Genesis 36:1–8

The account of Esau stresses two points. First, Esau’s sons were born . . . in the land of Canaan ([36:5](#)) before he moved to Seir ([36:8](#)). Jacob’s children, by contrast, were almost all born outside the land but then moved into it. God was giving the land to Jacob and his descendants and so made room for them by providing for Esau in a different place. Second, Esau’s other name was Edom. Israel often struggled with the Edomites (see [1 Sam 21:7](#); [22:9–22](#); [Obad 1](#)).

Genesis 36:1–43

The book turns to the accounts of Isaac’s sons, concluding the unchosen line of Esau (ch [36](#)) before proceeding with the chosen line of Jacob (ch [37](#)).

Genesis 36:2

Oholibamah was a great-granddaughter of Seir the Horite, whose descendants lived in Edom when Esau went to live there ([36:20](#), [25](#)).

Genesis 36:2–3

Esau’s three wives—Adah, Oholibamah, and Basemath—are listed. Two of these wives’ names are different from those listed earlier ([26:34](#); [28:9](#)). Perhaps the others died, or Esau favored these three among a total of six, or these were just different names for the same three. There is not enough information to decide.

Genesis 36:7–8

Esau, like Lot, left for the eastern land (compare [13:5–6](#)).

Genesis 36:9–14

This passage names the descendants of Esau’s five sons.

Genesis 36:9–43

This passage begins a second account of Esau’s descendants ([36:1](#)). It introduces a new list of his family line and traces his descendants through later generations. It also records marriages and alliances

Genesis 36:15–19

Thirteen of Esau’s descendants had positions as leaders of various clans. A picture begins to emerge of Esau as a grand overlord of tribes (cp. [36:40–43](#)).

Genesis 36:20–30

Seir the Horite was an early inhabitant of the land; his descendants populated the region until Esau moved in and displaced them ([Deut 2:12](#)).

Genesis 36:31

before any king ruled over the Israelites: This editorial note was probably inserted into the text during Israel's monarchy (see study note on 35:20).

Genesis 36:31–39

It is not clear how these kings of Edom were related to Esau. The clans in Edom followed the same pattern of organization as the later tribes of Israel. They eventually chose a king from one of their tribes and carried on a line of succession from him.

Genesis 36:40–43

These chiefs descended from Esau, who was a great and powerful overlord. As father of the Edomites, he ruled over clans and regions, with eleven chiefs descended from him. By separating from Jacob, Esau was beginning to shake Jacob's yoke from his neck ([27:39–40](#)).

Genesis 37:1

In ch [36](#), Esau was well on his way to power and prosperity; by contrast, Jacob, still waiting for the promise, settled in the land as a foreigner, like his father. He was still a temporary resident with a single family. Worldly greatness often comes more swiftly than spiritual greatness. Waiting for the promised spiritual blessing while others prosper is a test of patience, faith, and perseverance.

Genesis 37:2

The account of Jacob and his family tells of Joseph and his brothers. Jacob is still prominent, but the focus is on Joseph, who is introduced as an obedient seventeen-year-old son. • Joseph reported . . . the bad things his brothers were doing: Bringing a bad report has never been popular, but

it was the right thing to do and shows that Joseph was faithful from the beginning. As the story progresses, we see more of his brothers' wickedness displayed until, like Cain, they tried to eliminate the brother who pleased God.

Genesis 37:2–50.26

The story of Joseph and his brothers comprises a separate unit in Genesis, distinct in tone and emphasis from the preceding material. It traces one continuous series of episodes with Joseph at their center. • Cycles of repeated motifs structure the entire Joseph account. The themes are closely related to those found in wisdom books such as Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and Daniel. Wisdom literature assures the faithful that God brings good out of evil and joy out of pain—if not in this life, then certainly in the life to come. Though the wicked may prosper for a time, the righteous should hold fast to their integrity because a higher, more enduring principle of life is realized through obedience to God. Everyone who aspires to leadership in God's plan should observe how wisdom led to Joseph's success. Christ Jesus embodied the life of wisdom portrayed here as no one else could, for he is the wisdom of God. • Judah is also an important character in the story. He began as irresponsible and mean-spirited as his brothers; but he truly repented, put his life on the line to ransom a child for his father, and received a very important inheritance.

Genesis 37:3

Jacob: Hebrew *Israel*; also in [37:13](#). • Jacob loved Joseph more because Joseph had been born to him in his old age and because he was the first son of his favorite wife, Rachel. • Jacob gave Joseph a beautiful robe to demonstrate that he intended to grant him the largest portion of the inheritance.

Genesis 37:4

Jacob's favoritism toward Joseph inflamed his other sons' hatred of their brother. Just as Isaac's and Rebekah's favoritism had separated their family, Jacob's favoritism would separate him from his son Joseph.

Genesis 37:5-11

God confirmed his choice of this faithful son as the eventual leader of the whole family through two symbolic dreams. This is the first of three dream sequences in chs [37-50](#) (see [40:1-41:36](#); cp. [15:13](#); [20:3](#); [28:12-15](#); [31:24](#)). Dreams carried weight as a form of divine communication, especially if the dream revelation was given twice.

Genesis 37:7

The *sheaves of grain* suggest how Joseph would gain authority over his family (see [42:1-3](#)).

Genesis 37:8

The brothers reacted angrily to the revelation, unlike Joseph, who was honest and faithful. This shows why they were not chosen as leaders. Leaders in God's plan cannot be full of jealousy and hatred.

In their anger, they missed an important part of the revelation. They also would become rulers ("stars," [37:9](#)) and would successfully gather their sheaves ([37:7](#)).

Genesis 37:9

the sun and moon and eleven stars: Signs like the sun, moon, and stars often stand for rulers. The dream showed that Joseph would become a leader over the whole family of Israel.

Genesis 37:10

your mother ... and I: Joseph's birth mother, Rachel, was dead ([35:19](#)). Leah was now the matriarch of the clan.

Genesis 37:11

His brothers hated Joseph because they were jealous of him. Rather than recognize the hand of God, the brothers tried to prevent the dream from being fulfilled ([37:18-36](#)). These actions show that they were not fit to lead the household of faith. God's sovereign choice of a leader, especially if the

one chosen is young or appears unqualified, often brings out the true colors of those who have to submit to that leader's authority. The brothers represent people throughout history who have been driven by envy and malice because they were not committed to doing the Lord's will. • Jacob wondered what the dreams meant because he knew that God would choose the next leader, that God could choose the younger son to rule over the older sons, and that God could reveal all this in dreams.

Genesis 37:12-13

It was foolish for Jacob to send Joseph on such a mission, knowing how the brothers felt about him. Joseph obeyed his father by going to find his brothers despite their hatred for him.

Genesis 37:14-17

The brothers ranged far and wide. Shechem was about fifty miles from Hebron, and Dothan another fifteen miles beyond Shechem.

Genesis 37:18-20

When Joseph's brothers saw him coming, they devised a plot to kill . . . the dreamer and end his dreams. Earlier, they had unjustly killed the men of Shechem to avenge their sister (ch [34](#)); in the region of Shechem, they now plotted to unjustly kill their own brother out of envy.

Genesis 37:21-24

Reuben was perhaps trying to get back into his father's good graces ([35:22](#)) by exercising the leadership of the firstborn (cp. [42:22](#)). Reuben succeeded in saving Joseph's life, but he failed to earn his father's favor ([37:29-30](#)).

Genesis 37:23

The recurring motif of changed clothes signifies changes in status, position, and authority (see [37:3](#), [23](#); [38:14](#), [19](#); [39:15-18](#); [41:14](#), [42](#)).

Genesis 37:25–28

The Ishmaelite traders were descendants of the slave child who was cast out for mocking Isaac. Now they would enslave Joseph. When he was sold for twenty pieces of silver and carried to Egypt, he was at least preserved alive.

Genesis 37:26

Judah began to take a leadership role, which he continued to develop as the story goes on (see [43:8–10](#)).

Genesis 37:28

the Ishmaelites, who were Midianite traders (literally *the Midianite traders*): Ishmaelites were descendants of Abraham through Hagar ([16:5](#)), while Midianites were descendants of Abraham through Keturah ([25:1–2](#)). The term *Ishmaelite* may have described bedouin tribes generally. The Midianites might also have been traveling with a separate caravan of *Ishmaelite traders* ([37:27](#)). • Kidnapping (see [40:15](#)) would become a capital offense (see [Exod 21:16](#)) in Jewish law.

Genesis 37:29–30

When Reuben returned, he tore his clothes in grief. His attempt to restore his relationship with his father by saving Joseph had gone awry.

Genesis 37:31–35

The old family propensity for deception seized the brothers' imagination. Jacob had killed a young goat to deceive Isaac ([27:5–17](#)); now Jacob's sons deceived him with a goat (see study note on 30:34–36).

Genesis 37:32

your son: In their cold hatred, the brothers did not refer to Joseph by name or acknowledge him as their brother (see [21:10](#)).

Genesis 37:33

recognized: Compare with [27:23](#).

Genesis 37:34–35

Jacob tore his clothes and dressed himself in burlap: These were signs of great distress and mourning (see [44:13](#); [Job 1:20](#); [16:15](#)). Jacob was devastated and refused to be comforted. The treachery thus affected everyone in his family.

Genesis 37:36

sold Joseph to Potiphar: Joseph found himself in a place of service that seemed congruent with his rise to authority, yet he still faced more testing.

Genesis 38:1–30

The story of Judah and Tamar is a carefully placed interlude; it reports what was happening in the family of Judah, who would later rise to prominence, and it shows the beginnings of assimilation with the people of the land to help explain why God sent the family to Egypt (chs [39–47](#)). The Egyptians were strict separatists ([43:32](#)); the Israelites would retain their unique identity better in Egypt than in Canaan.

Genesis 38:7

That Er was a wicked man is not surprising, since his mother was a Canaanite and his father a wayward Israelite.

Genesis 38:7–10

This story describes the Lord as the sovereign judge who ended the lives of Judah's wicked sons.

Genesis 38:8

as our law requires. . . . You must produce an heir for your brother: The custom that informs this episode is the law for levirate marriage (Latin *levir*, "husband's brother"). By this custom, which was later incorporated into God's law for Israel ([Deut](#)

[25:5–10](#)), if a man died childless, his brother or nearest relative would marry his widow to produce a child who would carry on the family name of the deceased and inherit his property. Apparently, the near kinsman had a right to refuse, but he would be disgraced in the family for refusing to perpetuate his brother's name.

Genesis 38:9–10

Onan married Tamar, but was not willing to provide an heir for his brother. He would have sex with Tamar but not fulfill his responsibility to his dead brother ([38:8](#)).

Genesis 38:11

Judah is now presented as the model for his sons' behavior—he, too, was unfaithful to his levirate responsibility to Tamar as next kinsman (see study note on 38:8). Judah and his sons were far too Canaanite in their ways (see study note on 38:27–30; contrast Boaz, [Ruth 3–4](#)).

Genesis 38:12–13

Without a marriage, the family's future was in jeopardy. • Judah's wife died: This made Judah available to fulfill the responsibility of providing an heir.

Genesis 38:14–19

Tamar realized that she would have to take matters into her own hands if the family were to have a future. Tamar acted in keeping with the levirate custom (see study note on 38:8) out of loyalty to her deceased husband. She had a legal right to an heir by Judah's son or by Judah, so she lured her father-in-law into having sex with her. Jacob's family was deceived again, this time by a Canaanite daughter-in-law.

Genesis 38:17

It would be normal for Tamar to ask for a pledge if the man did not have the money to pay. A woman in such a position would not trust anyone to send the money.

Genesis 38:18

identification seal: A stone or metal cylinder was engraved with distinctive designs and was usually worn around the neck on a cord; when rolled onto clay or wax, it left a distinct impression.

Genesis 38:20–23

Judah had gone in to Tamar as a regular prostitute (Hebrew *zonah*, [38:15](#)), whereas Hirah was mistakenly looking for a shrine prostitute (Hebrew *qedeshah*), of which there were none.

Genesis 38:24–26

Judah played the hypocrite when he condemned Tamar to death for adultery. When she produced the seal and cord and walking stick that identified him as the father, he withdrew the condemnation.

Genesis 38:26

She is more righteous than I am: Judah acknowledged that he had shirked his responsibility to provide an heir. It was sinful for Judah to go to a prostitute, but Tamar had a legal right to be the mother of Judah's child and had acted on that right. In the book of Ruth, the elders analogously blessed the marriage of Boaz and Ruth, praying that God would make Ruth like Tamar ([Ruth 4:12](#); cp. [Matt 1:3, 5](#)).

Genesis 38:27–30

Judah's line continued because of Tamar. The twins replaced Judah's two slain sons ([38:7, 10](#)); their birth was similar to the birth of Jacob and Esau ([25:21–26](#)) in that the "red" one was born first, but the other son pushed past him in later life. Jacob's gaining the right to rule over his older brother ([27:29](#)) seemed to be relived in Judah's line. The line was carried on through Perez and not through the elder son Shelah, whom he had gone to such lengths to protect ([38:11](#); see [1 Chr 4:21](#)), nor through the elder twin Zerah (see [Ruth 4:13–22](#); [Matt 1:3](#)).

Genesis 38:29–30

Perez moved ahead of his brother, just like Joseph would soon do with his own brothers (chapters [39–47](#)).

Genesis 39:1–23

Joseph's integrity in Potiphar's service contrasts with Judah's moral failure (ch [38](#)). God was with Joseph ([39:2–3](#), [21](#), [23](#)) and enabled him to prosper and be a blessing (see study notes on 12:1–9; 28:16–22) despite his slavery and imprisonment.

Genesis 39:1–47:31

Joseph began as a slave, alienated from his brothers and separated from his father; he ended as Pharaoh's viceroy. Through the trips to Egypt, the covenant family went from the brink of apostasy, divided by jealousy and deception, to being reconciled and united by Judah's intercession and Joseph's forgiveness.

Genesis 39:2

God is mentioned for the first time (apart from [38:7–10](#)) since Jacob built his altar in Bethel ([35:1–15](#)); his covenant name, "the Lord," is used for the first time since Jacob left Laban ([31:49](#)).

Genesis 39:5

God began to bless Egypt through Joseph (see [22:18](#)).

Genesis 39:6–10

One of the major motifs of wisdom literature (see study note on 37:2–50:26) is to warn young people that immorality will lead them to disaster (cp. [Prov 5–7](#)). Joseph was able to resist temptation because he had godly wisdom—he was guided by the fear of the Lord ([Prov 1:7](#); [9:10](#)).

Genesis 39:14

Though Potiphar's wife was addressing slaves, she appealed to them as fellow Egyptians (us) to enlist them as witnesses against the despised Hebrew (see [43:32](#)) who had won Potiphar's trust.

Genesis 39:19–20

This was the second time that Joseph, while faithfully doing the right thing, was thrown into bondage with his clothing used deceptively as evidence (cp. [37:23–24](#), [31–33](#)).

Genesis 39:21–23

Joseph thrived in prison because God was with him. Each time Joseph prospered, he was put in charge of something.

Genesis 40:1–4

Joseph was so faithful and trustworthy that the captain of the guard trusted him with the care of two of Pharaoh's chief . . . officials.

Genesis 40:1–23

Joseph did not lose faith in God's promises, as evidenced by his readiness to interpret the dreams of two prisoners. He was still convinced that God's revelation in his own two dreams ([37:5–11](#)) was true, and he had not abandoned hope that they would be fulfilled. When the fellow prisoners' dreams were fulfilled exactly as Joseph said, this confirmed that his previous dreams were from God.

Genesis 40:5–8

Pharaoh's cup-bearer and baker looked worried because they knew that their futures were somehow bound up in these ominous and disturbing dreams that they could not understand.

- Joseph still had faith that interpreting dreams is God's business and that he would understand them with God's help. He knew he had not misinterpreted his own dreams.

Genesis 40:9–19

Joseph listened to the dreams and offered their interpretations. These dreams were not trivial; they were ominous warnings from God about what everyone was going to face. These two dreams prepared for Pharaoh's two dreams, which revealed the periods of life and death that the nation would soon experience.

Genesis 40:14–15

Because he knew that the chief cup-bearer was going back into Pharaoh's personal service, Joseph saw an opportunity to seek his own release from prison.

Genesis 40:20–22

The interpretations Joseph gave the prisoners proved true. The death of the chief baker speaks of the harsh realities of life in ancient Egypt, with a king whose word was his land's highest law.

Genesis 40:23

The cup-bearer . . . forgot all about Joseph, but God did not forget him. Joseph's faith was about to be rewarded (ch [41](#)).

Genesis 41:1–4

Pharaoh's first dream was about cows. Cows liked to stand half-submerged among the reeds in the Nile River to take refuge from the heat and flies. They would come out of the water to find pasture. The second group of cows disturbed Pharaoh because they were scrawny yet able to swallow the fat cows.

Genesis 41:1–46

God had used two dreams to identify Joseph as a leader among his brothers ([37:5–11](#)). He used two dreams to test Joseph's faith in prison ([40:5–14](#)). Now he would use two dreams to elevate Joseph from prison to preeminence. Joseph had repeatedly

proven faithful in small matters; now he would be put in charge of great things.

Genesis 41:5–7

Pharaoh's second dream carried a similar message. Seven plump . . . heads of grain on a single stalk were swallowed up by seven shriveled and withered heads that sprouted after them.

Genesis 41:8

The magicians and wise men belonged to a guild of supposed experts in spiritual matters, including dreams and visions (cp. [Exod 8:18–19](#); [Dan 2:10–11](#)), but they could not interpret these dreams. God used an Israelite slave to confound the wisdom of the world (cp. [Dan 2](#)). However powerful a nation becomes, it is still under God's sovereign control ([Dan 2:20–23](#)).

Genesis 41:9–13

The chief cup-bearer finally remembered Joseph and testified that his interpretations were true.

Genesis 41:14–15

- Pharaoh quickly summoned Joseph from prison to explain his dreams.
- Joseph shaved, following the Egyptian custom.

Genesis 41:16

Joseph knew that only God could explain Pharaoh's dreams (compare [40:8](#)). He was sure God would reveal their meaning, as the dreams had a purpose ([41:25, 28](#)).

Genesis 41:17–24

Pharaoh recounted his dreams and testified that no human wisdom could interpret them.

Genesis 41:25–32

Both dreams predicted that seven years of abundant crops would be followed by seven years of severe famine.

Genesis 41:32

The two similar dreams showed that *the matter has been decreed by God, and He will carry it out shortly*. This was like the dreams of the two prisoners that God quickly fulfilled ([40:5–23](#)). Joseph's own two dreams ([37:5–11](#)) were also about to come true ([41:37–46](#); [42:6–9](#)).

Genesis 41:33–36

God's revelation demanded a response—it was not given just to satisfy curiosity about the future. Joseph's advice about planning and preparing showed that he was the kind of intelligent and wise man that Pharaoh needed ([41:37–40](#)). • Joseph instituted central planning and control with a supervisor, local managers, a 20 percent tax on grain, and a rationing system. Later wisdom literature (see study note on 37:2–50:26) teaches the principle of planning ahead rather than living just for the moment (see [Prov 6:6–8](#); [27:12](#)).

Genesis 41:37–40

Pharaoh recognized that Joseph was the man for the job; he had the spirit of God and was intelligent and wise. God showed his sovereign rule in Egypt; Israelites who later read the account could be confident that God would save them as he had promised.

Genesis 41:41–46

Joseph was made the acting ruler or manager of Egypt.

Genesis 41:42

Pharaoh's signet ring had a seal used for signing documents. The seal was impressed in soft clay, which hardened and left a permanent impression of the ruler's signature, which carried his authority.

Numerous seals of this type have been found in archaeological digs. • The linen clothing and gold chain signified Joseph's new status as ruler.

Genesis 41:43–44

Pharaoh made Joseph second-in-command; all the people had to submit to him. Compare [Psalm 105:16–22](#).

Genesis 41:45

As token of Joseph's new status, Pharaoh gave him an Egyptian name and a wife from a high-ranking family. • On was a center for sun worship that came to be known as Heliopolis ("sun city").

Genesis 41:46

He was thirty years old: It had been approximately thirteen years since his brothers had sold Joseph into slavery ([37:2](#)). • he inspected the entire land of Egypt: As a wise manager, his first priority was to learn the scope of his responsibilities.

Genesis 41:47–57

Pharaoh's dreams were fulfilled just as Joseph had explained.

Genesis 41:50–52

In spite of his position and authority, Joseph never abandoned his heritage; he gave Hebrew names to his two sons. • Manasseh: Joseph's prosperity and success made him "forget" the misery of separation from his family. • Ephraim: In so naming him, Joseph proclaimed his gratitude to God for making him "fruitful" in Egypt.

Genesis 41:53–57

Joseph's wisdom paid off, for the seven years of plenty were followed by seven years of severe famine, but throughout Egypt there was plenty of food. Joseph had grain to sell to the Egyptians and to people from other countries as well.

Genesis 42:1–44:34

Joseph did several unusual things to his brothers when they came looking for grain. The last time Joseph had been with them, they were filled with jealousy, hatred, and anger; they attempted to destroy their brother, and they deceived their father. Joseph put them through various tests, similar to the trying situations they had put him through, to see if they had changed.

Genesis 42:1–47:31

God used the famine to bring Israel to Egypt under Joseph's rule, thus fulfilling two prophecies ([15:13](#); [37:7–11](#)).

Genesis 42:4

Jacob may have believed that Benjamin would not be safe with his brothers.

Genesis 42:6–7

Joseph's first dream ([37:5–11](#)) was partially fulfilled when his brothers bowed down to him without recognizing him (see also [43:26](#); [44:14](#)). It was totally fulfilled in [50:18](#). Joseph recognized his brothers immediately, but he could not reveal himself because he did not yet trust them to be the honest men they claimed to be ([42:10](#)).

Genesis 42:8

they didn't recognize him: Joseph was a grown man, not a boy. He was not wearing a beard, was dressed in Egyptian clothes, and was in an unexpected position, speaking to them through an interpreter ([42:23](#)).

Genesis 42:9

You are spies! The brothers had considered Joseph a spy for their father and had treated him roughly ([37:2](#), [14](#), [18–28](#)). Joseph was putting them in a similar situation to see how they would respond.

Genesis 42:11

Joseph knew that they had not always been the honest men they claimed to be.

Genesis 42:15–17

Joseph put the brothers in jail for three days to see if they had a conscience functioning about what they had done ([42:21–23](#)). The brothers had similarly thrown Joseph into a cistern-prison while they decided what to do with him ([37:24](#)).

Genesis 42:18–20

Rather than keep all but one, Joseph would release all but one to take grain home to their starving families.

Genesis 42:21–23

Clearly we are being punished: The brothers sensed that having to bring Benjamin back to Egypt against their father's wishes was God's punishment for their having sold Joseph to the traders. The sense of divine retribution began to awaken feelings of remorse that Joseph's cries for mercy and their father's tears ([37:34–35](#)) had failed to arouse.

Genesis 42:22

you would not listen: Reuben had lost his place as leader (see study notes on [42:37](#); [49:3–4](#)).

Genesis 42:24

Joseph turned away from them and began to weep (cp. [43:30](#); [45:2](#), [14](#); [50:1](#), [17](#)); perhaps he was hearing part of the story that he had never known (Reuben's attempt to save him, [37:21–22](#), [29](#)), or his brothers' remorse moved him to forgiveness.

Genesis 42:25

return each brother's payment: He was now testing them to awaken their conscience and make them face their past guilt; once again, they were going home with silver instead of a brother ([37:28-35](#)).

Genesis 42:25-28

Joseph cared for his brothers' needs; he had forgiven them (see study note on 42:24) and was fulfilling his role to provide for them. God used Joseph's care to convict the brothers even more fully of their sin.

Genesis 42:28

What has God done to us? They knew that God was behind everything that had been happening, so they faced a day of reckoning for their sins.

Genesis 42:29-34

The brothers' account focused on the accusation that they were spies and on the need to take Benjamin back to Egypt with them. They omitted their growing realization of divine retribution for their crime against Joseph.

Genesis 42:36

Filled with grief over two sons lost already, Jacob feared that he would also lose Benjamin if he went to Egypt. • You are robbing me of my children! He did not realize the full truth of his words, but they must have stung his sons' guilty consciences.

Genesis 42:37

Reuben tried to take the lead; perhaps he thought he could get back into his father's good favor (see [35:22](#)), first by rescuing Joseph from certain death ([37:21-22](#), [29-30](#)) and now by keeping Benjamin safe.

Genesis 42:38

Jacob was resolute in his favoritism toward Rachel's remaining son. Benjamin would not go to Egypt even if it meant that Leah's son Simeon never returned. Jacob's grief apparently weighed heavily on the brothers' conscience ([44:18-34](#)).

Genesis 43:1-7

As the famine continued, Jacob's family needed more grain, but they could not return to Egypt without Benjamin ([42:16](#), [20](#)). Jacob realized that he was in a bind; he needed more food but was loath to lose Benjamin.

Genesis 43:8-10

Judah broke the deadlock by taking responsibility for Benjamin's well-being, thus succeeding where Reuben failed. His action was fitting, since it had been his idea to sell Joseph to the Ishmaelites ([37:26-27](#)) instead of killing him. Now he would secure Benjamin's safety with his own life (see [44:18-34](#)).

Genesis 43:11-13

Jacob provided everything he could to ensure a favorable reception from the Egyptian governor ("the man"; compare [32:13-21](#)).

Genesis 43:13-14

Jacob finally trusted *God Almighty* with his family's future. This divine title emphasizes God's power (see also [17:1](#); [28:3](#); [35:11](#); [48:3](#); [1 Kings 19:10](#), [14](#); [Revelation 21:22](#)).

Genesis 43:16

When Joseph saw Benjamin with his brothers: Joseph knew Benjamin was well (see study note on 42:1-44:34). The feast was both a celebration and a test.

Genesis 43:18

the brothers were frightened: Compare [32:6–12](#). Their guilt stopped them from seeing that something good might happen.

Genesis 43:19–22

The brothers, completely vulnerable and feeling the weight of God's judgment on their consciences, approached the manager in desperation.

Genesis 43:24

Joseph no longer treated his brothers harshly, but provided kind hospitality.

Genesis 43:26

For the second time, the brothers *bowed to the ground before him*. This fulfilled his first dream ([37:7](#); see [42:6–7](#); compare [33:3](#)).

Genesis 43:29

May God be gracious to you, my son: Joseph's blessing to his full brother fulfilled Jacob's prayer ([43:14](#)).

Genesis 43:30

he was overcome with emotion for his brother: Cp. [42:24](#). Joseph's tears were of painful memories and years of lost fellowship, as well as of joy and thanksgiving at seeing his brother again. • He went into his private room: He did not yet plan to reveal his identity.

Genesis 43:33

in astonishment: This ruler knew more about the brothers than seemed possible (compare [44:15](#)).

Genesis 43:34

The brothers experienced generous and gracious treatment from God through Joseph.

Joseph tested them. He showed special favor to Benjamin, who was also Rachel's son. In the past, their father's favoritism toward Joseph had caused jealousy and hatred.

By treating Benjamin with favor, Joseph tested whether they would respond with the same anger as before. This situation revealed whether their attitudes and behavior had changed.

Genesis 44:1–34

The brothers seemed different. They felt sorry for what they did to Joseph. They showed honor by returning the money and by bringing Benjamin. Given a chance to get rid of Rachel's other son, Benjamin, would they do it?

Genesis 44:2

Joseph was giving his brothers the chance to abandon Benjamin if they wanted to. Joseph was testing them to see if they were loyal to the family and faithful to their father.

Genesis 44:5

This description would make the brothers understand that the ruler knew things that others could not. • *Hydromancy* (pouring water into oil) and *oenomancy* (pouring wine into other liquids) were methods of divination used in the ancient Near East that would have required such a cup. Joseph was continuing his ruse (see [42:7](#); cp. [30:27](#); see also [Lev 19:26](#); [Num 23:23](#); [Deut 18:10–11](#))—he knew that only God grants revelation (see [Gen 37:5–9](#); [40:8](#); [41:16](#)).

Genesis 44:9–10

The punishment that the brothers proposed was harsher than necessary; it was normal in antiquity to stake your life on what you said. The palace manager was agreeable but enforced a punishment that matched Joseph's intentions ([44:17](#)).

Genesis 44:11–12

The palace manager knew where the cup was, but he created more anxiety by beginning with the oldest.

Genesis 44:13

they all tore their clothes: They knew what it would do to Jacob to lose Benjamin ([42:38](#)).

Genesis 44:14

This time, the brothers did not bow politely (see [42:6–7](#); [43:26](#)); they fell to the ground in desperation, fulfilling Joseph's first dream for the third time (see [37:10](#)).

Genesis 44:16

Judah again spoke for the group. • God is punishing us for our sins: God was completing the work of repentance in their hearts. Judah again proposed that they all be punished. Benjamin was seemingly guilty of this theft, but all of the others were guilty of sin against Joseph. They preferred not returning to Jacob at all versus seeing his grief at the loss of Benjamin ([44:34](#)).

Genesis 44:18–34

Judah made good on his promise to pay for Benjamin's safety ([43:8–10](#)). His lengthy plea to be imprisoned in place of the lad ([44:33](#)) is one of the most moving acts of intercession in Scripture. It demonstrated Judah's concern for their father and his willingness to give up everything for the sake of his brother. With this kind of integrity (see [John 15:13](#)), Judah showed himself to be a true leader, qualified to receive the blessing of the firstborn. Through him the kings of Israel would come (see [Gen 49:10](#)). • The brothers had fully repented, as expressed by Judah's intercession. Because of their change, Joseph could make himself known to them ([45:1–15](#)) and arrange for the family to join him in Egypt where there was food ([45:16](#); [47:12](#)).

Genesis 44:32–34

Judah was willing to give up his family, his future, and his freedom for others.

Genesis 45:1–15

In one of the book's most dramatic scenes, Joseph told his brothers who he was. This brought the process of reconciling with them to a climax (see also [50:14–21](#)).

Genesis 45:2

This is the third time Joseph cried over his brothers in the story (see also [42:24](#); [43:30](#); [45:14](#); [50:17](#); compare [50:1](#)).

Genesis 45:3

The news shocked the brothers. They were unable to speak because of amazement and fear ([45:5](#); compare [50:15](#)).

Genesis 45:5–8

God . . . sent me is the central message of the account of Jacob's family ([37:2](#)). As the Lord had told Abraham, he was leading the Israelites into Egypt ([15:13](#)). God had sent Joseph to Egypt to prepare for his family's rescue during the famine. In what has become a classic statement of God's sovereignty, Joseph explained that God had been working through all of the circumstances and human acts to bring about his plan. The certainty of God's will is the basis for forgiveness and reconciliation with those who do wrong, cause hurt, or bring harm. If people do not believe that God is sovereign, then they will blame others and retaliate. Those who are spiritual will trust that God is at work even through human wickedness (see also [Rom 8:28–30](#)).

Genesis 45:9–13

Joseph instructed his brothers to inform Jacob. The whole family was to move to Egypt and live in Goshen, a fertile region in the Nile delta (see [47:1–](#)

[12](#)). If they did not come to Egypt, they would not survive the five years of famine ahead.

Genesis 45:10

The region of Goshen was in the northeast corner of Egypt, only a few days' walk from Canaan. Jacob's family stayed there because there was food and water for themselves and their flocks; later, they were kept there by Egyptians who put them to slave labor.

Genesis 45:14-15

Joseph was reunited with his brothers—first with Benjamin and then with the rest. Their previous hatred and jealousy of Joseph ([37:4-11](#)) had come to an end. The brothers experienced forgiveness from God and from Joseph. Far from commanding his brothers to bow down to him (see [42:6-7](#)), Joseph welcomed them. Joseph held no grudge because he accepted what had happened as God's work and saw the good that had resulted (see [50:14-21](#)). This is how wisdom rules: The wise leader will forgive and restore (see study note on [37:2-50:26](#)).

Genesis 45:16-25

Joseph sent his brothers with instructions to bring Jacob and the entire family to Egypt. Out of gratitude for Joseph's having saved all of Egypt ([45:18](#); see [47:20](#)), Pharaoh promised the best of all the land of Egypt, and Joseph gave them the finest products of Egypt.

Genesis 45:16-47.12

This section is transitional, as the family moved from Canaan to Goshen, where they would live for the next four centuries.

Genesis 45:24

Don't quarrel about all this along the way! When they were away from Joseph, they might begin to accuse one another about the past or argue about how to explain what had happened to Jacob. It was

now time to put the past behind them and enjoy the reunion.

Genesis 45:26-28

As might be expected, Jacob was stunned when he heard that his son Joseph was still alive and ruling all the land of Egypt. As he heard the details of their story and saw all that Joseph had sent him, he was convinced that it was true. He immediately prepared to move to Egypt and reunite with his son Joseph, whom he had not seen for twenty-two years.

Genesis 45:27

their father's spirits revived: This royal invitation to Jacob, an old man near the end of hope, and to the ten brothers burdened with guilty fears, was a turning point in their lives. It was also a fulfillment of God's prediction ([15:13-16](#)) that they would go into seclusion in a foreign country and there become a great nation without losing their identity. The joyful news about Joseph changed the lives of everyone in this family for the good.

Genesis 46:1

set out for Egypt: A little over 200 years earlier, Abraham had similarly gone down into Egypt during a famine in Canaan ([12:10](#)), and God had protected him there. • Jacob's first stop was at Beersheba, where Abraham had sacrificed to the Lord and worshiped him after settling his land and water rights with the Philistines ([21:31-33](#)). This was where Isaac had lived, and where Jacob had lived before he fled from Esau's anger ([28:10](#)). • all his possessions: See [46:5-7](#).

Genesis 46:1-4

God reassured Jacob about his move to Egypt.

Genesis 46:2-4

In a night vision, the Lord promised Jacob that he would be with him and make his family a great nation in Egypt. The same God who led them into

Egypt promised to bring them back to live in Canaan.

Genesis 46:4

will close your eyes: He would have a peaceful death, surrounded by his family and many blessings from God ([49:33](#)).

Genesis 46:8-27

This family history of Jacob's sons shows that all the tribes of Israel went to Egypt together. They would also leave together (see the book of Exodus).

Genesis 46:20

On: See study note on 41:45.

Genesis 46:26

The total number . . . was sixty-six: This is the number of those who traveled with Jacob to Egypt, excluding his sons' wives, the servants, and others attached to the household. It also omits Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Jacob.

Genesis 46:27

The total seventy includes Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Jacob. Seventy is also a symbolic number for perfection or completion (see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note). From these seventy (i.e., all Israel) would grow the nation of Israel that would bless the seventy nations (i.e., all the nations) of the world (see study note on Gen 10:2-32; cp. [12:3](#)).

Genesis 46:28-34

Jacob finally saw his son Joseph again; their reunion was overwhelmingly joyful.

Genesis 46:29

Joseph . . . embraced his father and wept: Joseph was seventeen when he had last seen his father ([37:2](#)); now he was thirty-nine.

Genesis 46:30

Jacob was satisfied just to see his beloved son alive—the firstborn of his chosen wife Rachel and the designated family leader (see study note on 48:5-7; see also [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)). More than just a family reunion, this was confirmation that God's plan was intact.

Genesis 46:34

In contrast to the syncretistic Canaanites, who would have absorbed the Israelites had they stayed in Canaan, Egyptians detested Semitic shepherds out of a sense of ethnic superiority and observed a strict segregation (see [43:32](#)). When Jacob's family settled in Egypt, this separation would allow the people to grow into a great nation without losing their identity.

Genesis 47:1

Goshen (see study note on 45:10) is not referred to in ancient Egyptian texts; the name it bore in later Egyptian writings was "the region of Rameses" ([47:11](#); see [Exod 1:11](#)). It was fertile and near to Joseph at court, which suggests that it was on the eastern side of the Nile delta.

Genesis 47:1-6

Pharaoh responded as Joseph hoped by giving Jacob's family the best part of the land; he even gave some of the brothers oversight of his own livestock ([47:6](#)).

Genesis 47:7-10

When Jacob entered Pharaoh's court and when he left, he blessed Pharaoh, an indication of Jacob's position as God's representative (see [Heb 7:7](#)). God had promised that he would bless those who

blessed Abraham's family ([Gen 12:2–3](#)), so he now blessed Pharaoh and Egypt.

Genesis 47:13–26

The Lord blessed Pharaoh because Pharaoh was blessing Abraham's descendants ([12:3](#)). Through Joseph's wise administration in Egypt, the Lord saved the people from starvation and prospered Pharaoh. In selling food to the Egyptians during the years of famine, Joseph accepted money, livestock, and finally land as payment, until almost all of Egypt belonged to Pharaoh. Meanwhile, God provided Israel with some of the best land in Egypt where they could live, work, and multiply.

Genesis 47:21

he made them all slaves: In Hebrew script, the difference is very slight between *slaves* (Hebrew 'abadim) and *towns* (Hebrew 'arim). Moving the people into the towns doesn't fit the context very well, so most translations select *slaves* as the reading that makes the most sense (cp. [47:20](#)).

Genesis 47:27

God blessed his people according to his promise to Abraham that his descendants would be innumerable ([15:5](#); [22:17](#)). They had to wait for the fulfillment of the second promise, that they would own the land of Canaan ([17:8](#)).

Genesis 47:29–31

bury me with my ancestors: Cp. [49:29–33](#). Jacob wanted to be buried with Abraham and Isaac in the cave of Machpelah (see study note on 49:29–33; see [23:1–20](#); [25:7–10](#); [35:27–29](#)). • Put your hand under my thigh: This custom (cp. [24:1–9](#) and study note on 24:2) was a serious oath to carry on the covenant, which had as its main promise innumerable descendants in the Promised Land.

Genesis 47:31

When the oath was taken, Jacob bowed humbly in worship and thanked the Lord for ensuring that he

would be buried with his ancestors in the land of promise (cp. [1 Kgs 1:47](#)).

Genesis 48:1–22

In blessing Ephraim and Manasseh, Jacob reached out by faith for the promise to be continued, having learned that God's ways are not always the ways of men. Out of Jacob's long life, the writer to the Hebrews selected the blessing of Joseph's sons as his great act of faith ([Heb 11:21](#)). As Jacob acted in light of God's will, the primary blessing was again given to the younger instead of the older son, but without scheming and its bitter results.

Genesis 48:3–4

Jacob rehearsed how God Almighty had appeared to him and had promised him Abraham's blessing—innumerable descendants dwelling in the land ... as an everlasting possession (cp. [28:10–22](#)).

Genesis 48:5–7

Jacob, prompted by his memory of Rachel (see [35:16–20](#)), blessed Joseph by elevating his two sons as coheirs with his other sons—the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh would have shares along with the other tribes that came from Jacob (see [Josh 16–17](#)). Jacob also gave Ephraim, Joseph's younger son, the birthright (see [1 Chr 5:1–2](#)). As a result of this blessing, Ephraim and Manasseh became large and powerful tribes (see [Josh 17:14–18](#)).

Genesis 48:10

Like his father Isaac, Jacob now gave the blessing when his eyesight was failing (compare [27:1](#)).

Genesis 48:14

The right hand was for the head of the firstborn, and Jacob was deliberately giving that position to the younger son. That pattern was followed for four consecutive generations: Isaac over Ishmael, Jacob over Esau, Joseph over Reuben, and Ephraim over Manasseh. Many years later, Ephraim became the leading tribe in the northern kingdom, superior to

the tribe of Manasseh. The entire northern kingdom of Israel was occasionally called Ephraim (see study notes on 2 Chr 28:12; Isa 11:13; Ezek 37:15-28; Hos 6:4; Zech 9:10).

Genesis 48:15-16

In his blessing on Joseph, Jacob used a threefold invocation to describe the God in whom he trusted: (1) the God who was in covenant with his fathers Abraham and Isaac ([28:13](#); [31:5](#), [42](#); [32:9](#); [46:3](#)); (2) the God who had been his shepherd (cp. [49:24](#); [Exod 6:6](#); [Ps 23:1](#); [Isa 59:20](#)); and (3) the Angel who rescued him from all harm. He prayed the same blessings for Joseph's sons.

Genesis 48:17-19

Joseph was upset: He expected God to act according to convention, but faith recognizes that God's ways are not man's ways, and God's thoughts are not man's thoughts. It took Jacob a lifetime to learn this lesson, but he did learn it, and here he acted on it.

Genesis 48:22

Joseph was later buried at Shechem ([Josh 24:32](#)) as a sign that he possessed this bequeathed extra portion (Hebrew shekem) of land. Jacob had apparently conquered this area though the occasion is not mentioned elsewhere.

Genesis 49:1-2

Jacob's words were deliberately chosen prophetic oracles. The days to come refer to the conquest and settlement of the Promised Land, and beyond that to the messianic age. They would all share in the blessing; all the tribes would enter the land with Joshua, but they would not all participate equally.

Genesis 49:1-28

Jacob, by faith and as God's spokesman, looked forward to Israel's settlement in the land, and beyond that to the glorious future. Here at the end of the patriarchal age, he foretold what would happen to each tribe as he evaluated his sons one by one, just as Noah had done at the end of the

primeval era (cp. [9:25-27](#)). The character and acts of each ancestor affected the lives of his descendants ([Exod 20:5-6](#); [34:6-7](#); [Num 14:18](#); [Jer 32:18](#)).

Genesis 49:3-4

As firstborn, Reuben was entitled to be head of the family, but because he had the ungoverned impulses of boiling or turbulent waters ([35:22](#)), Jacob prophesied that Reuben would fail in leadership (see [37:21-22](#), [29](#); [42:22](#), [37-38](#); cp. [Judg 5:15-16](#); [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)).

Genesis 49:5-7

Simeon and Levi were violent and lawless; instead of serving justice, they indulged their uncontrolled anger and disregarded life ([34:24-29](#)). • I will scatter them: Simeon's land was largely absorbed into Judah's ([Josh 19:1](#), [9](#)); Levi was given a more honorable future because the Levites became the priestly tribe (see [Exod 32:25-29](#)), but they had no region of their own ([Josh 21](#)).

Genesis 49:8-12

The blessing on Judah commands the most attention. In this oracle, Jacob predicted the fierce, lion-like dominance of Judah over his enemies and over his brothers, who would praise him (cp. [29:35](#); see, e.g., [Ruth 4:11-12](#); [1 Sam 18:6-7](#); [Pss 2](#), [45](#), [72](#); [Isa 11:1-13](#)).

Genesis 49:10

This verse anticipates the kingship in Judah (cp. [17:6](#), [16](#); [35:11](#)). Although the birthright blessing went to Joseph, Judah would provide Israel's rulers (see [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)). A long line of kings from Judah would retain the scepter, the symbol of rule; the last king would be the one to whom it belongs, the promised Messiah (see [2 Sam 7:4-16](#); [Pss 2](#), [45](#), [60](#); [Isa 11](#); [Ezek 21:26-27](#); [Zech 9:9](#); [Rev 5:5](#)). • from his descendants: Literally *from between his feet*, a poetic euphemism for reproductive organs. • until the coming of the one to whom it belongs (Or *until tribute is brought to him and the peoples obey*; traditionally rendered *until Shiloh comes*): These differences arise from ambiguities in the Hebrew

text. Rule of Israel belongs to Judah's descendant through David's line ([2 Sam 7:8–16](#)), and he will eventually rule all nations, as signified by the bringing of *tribute* (see [Pss 68:29; 72:8–11; Isa 2:2–4; Eph 4:8–10](#)).

Genesis 49:11–12

These descriptions envision the abundance of the Messiah's kingdom (see [Isa 61:6–7; 65:21–25; Zech 3:10](#)). When the Messiah comes, there will be paradise-like splendor and abundance on the earth. • He ties his foal to a grapevine: Grapevines will be so abundant that they will be used for hitching posts, and wine will be as abundant as fresh water (see [Amos 9:13–14; Zech 3:10](#)). • The coming one will have eyes . . . darker than wine and teeth . . . whiter than milk: He will be vigorous and healthy, as will be the era of his rule. Jesus' miracle of changing water into wine ([John 2:1–12](#)), his first sign, was an announcement that the Messiah had come; it was a foretaste of even better things to come.

Genesis 49:13

The oracle said Zebulun would dwell by the sea and be a safe harbor, but in the actual settlement they spread inland (see [Josh 19:10–16](#)). The oracle did not give specific borders for the tribes.

Genesis 49:14–15

Like a sturdy donkey, the tribe of Issachar would be forced to work for others. Issachar was often subjugated by invading armies.

Genesis 49:16–17

Dan was called to provide justice (*Dan* means "judge"), but the tribe would choose treachery, like a snake beside the road (see [Judg 18](#)).

Genesis 49:18

At this point, Jacob interjected an expression of hope. He may have been indirectly reminding his sons of their need for dependence on the Lord or expressing his hope in the Messiah's reign, when he

and his descendants would be rescued from all trouble, grief, and human treachery.

Genesis 49:19

Three of the six Hebrew words in this verse are wordplays on the name Gad ("attack"). Gad will be attacked by marauding bands (attackers), but he will attack. The tribes that settled east of the Jordan River frequently experienced border raids (see [Josh 13; 2 Kgs 10:32–33; 1 Chr 5:18–19](#)).

Genesis 49:20

Asher would be fertile and productive, providing rich foods. The tribe settled along the rich northern coast of Canaan.

Genesis 49:21

Naphtali was like a doe. This may mean the tribe would live as a free people in the mountains (compare [Judges 5:18](#)). The tribe of Naphtali settled in the hill country northwest of the Sea of Galilee.

Genesis 49:22–26

This oracle treats Joseph more expansively than any of the others, for here the main blessing lay (see [1 Chr 5:1–2](#)). Jacob lavished promises of victory and prosperity on Joseph's two tribes. Ephraimites recorded as victorious in battle include Joshua ([Josh 6, 8, 10, 12](#)) and Deborah ([Judg 4](#)). Victorious descendants of Manasseh include Gideon ([Judg 6–8](#)) and Jephthah ([Judg 11:1–12:7](#)).

Genesis 49:24–26

the Mighty One of Jacob ... the Shepherd ... the Rock of Israel ... the God of your father ... the Almighty: Five names for God introduce five blessings. God is the giver of all good things.

Genesis 49:25

- The *blessings from the heavens* brought rain for crops.
- The *blessings of the depths below* provided streams and wells.
- The *blessings of the breasts and womb* led to many children.

Genesis 49:26

Joseph ... the prince of his brothers: He is a leader among his brothers, showing his strong character and high status.

Genesis 49:27

The oracle about Benjamin describes a violent tribe (see [Judges 20](#); [1 Samuel 9:1–2](#); [19:10](#); [22:17](#)).

Genesis 49:28

These prophecies cover a wide range, predicting the future of various tribes in general terms. Individuals could receive great blessings from God through faith and obedience, no matter what happened to their clan.

Genesis 49:29–33

Bury me with my father: This grave in the land of Canaan represented hope for the future (cp. [47:29–30](#)). Others buried at the cave of Machpelah near Hebron were Sarah ([23:19](#)), Abraham ([25:7–9](#)), Isaac ([35:27–29](#)), Rebekah, and Leah.

Genesis 49:33

Jacob died at the age of 147 ([47:28](#)), bringing his life of struggle and sorrow to an end. Jacob had always had an unquenchable desire for God's blessing. He had a deep piety that habitually relied on God despite all else. In the end, he died a man of genuine faith. He learned where real blessings come from, and through his faith would be able to hand these on to his sons ([Heb 11:21](#)).

Genesis 50:1–6

Like his father and his grandfather, Jacob's death marked the end of an important time in Israel's history.

Genesis 50:2

Jacob's body was embalmed for burial in typical Egyptian fashion. Embalming is the process of preserving a body after death.

Genesis 50:3

The Egyptians mourned Jacob for 70 days, just two days less than they would for a pharaoh. This showed their great respect for Joseph.

Genesis 50:4–6

Joseph needed Pharaoh's permission to leave his official duties for a short time. He wanted to bury his father in Canaan.

Pharaoh quickly gave permission to Joseph, who had once been a slave.

Genesis 50:7–9

This was Joseph's first return to his homeland in thirty-nine years. The trip was temporary. Centuries later, the family of Israel would permanently leave Egypt, taking Joseph's bones with them for burial in the land of promise (see [50:25](#)).

Genesis 50:10–13

This journey into Canaan was made in sorrow to bury a man; the next journey into the land would be to live there.

Genesis 50:15–18

The brothers pleaded for Joseph's forgiveness, referring to themselves as Joseph's slaves (cp. [37:7](#);

[44:16](#), [33](#)). The brothers were afraid that Joseph's earlier reconciliation with them had been motivated only by his desire to see his father again. With neither Jacob nor Pharaoh to restrain him, they feared that he might now take revenge on them. But Joseph . . . wept because they still feared reprisal.

patriarchal age. From this point forward, God dealt with Israel as a nation. • Joseph's body was kept in Egypt as a pledge of hope for slaves awaiting the Promised Land (see [Exod 13:19](#); [Heb 11:39–40](#)). He was eventually buried in Shechem (see [Josh 24:32](#)), where Jacob had originally sent him ([Gen 37:13](#)).

Genesis 50:19–21

Joseph reassured his brothers that God planned to fulfill the promised blessing (cp. [45:5](#), [7–9](#)), and he promised kindness and provision (cp. [45:11](#)).

Genesis 50:22–23

Joseph lived to see his great-great-grandchildren by Ephraim, and his great-grandchildren by Manasseh—a sign of God's blessing (see [Ps 128:6](#); [Prov 17:6](#); [Isa 53:10](#)).

Genesis 50:23

whom he claimed as his own (literally *who were born on Joseph's knees*): Placing them on his knees at their birth was a symbolic act signifying that they came from him and belonged to him (cp. [Job 3:12](#)).

Genesis 50:24–25

God will surely come to help you (literally *visit you*): These words of Joseph, given twice, summarize the hope expressed throughout both the Old Testament and the New Testament. God's visitation in the person of the Messiah, the offspring of Abraham, would bring the curse to an end and establish the long-awaited blessing of God in a new creation. The company of the faithful would wait in expectation for that to happen. • Like his father before him, Joseph made his brothers promise that his bones would be taken out of Egypt when God would come to take them (to help you and lead you back) to Canaan (see [Exod 13:19](#); [Josh 24:32](#); [Heb 11:22](#)).

Genesis 50:26

Joseph's death signified the end of his generation (see study notes on 25:7–8; 35:1–29) and of the